

*William
Carlos
Williams
& Charles
Tomlinson*



*A
Transatlantic
Connection*

E D I T E D B Y

BARRY MAGID & HUGH WITEMEYER

William Carlos Williams
& Charles Tomlinson

Modern American Literature
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Yoshinobu Hakutani
General Editor

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New York • Washington, D.C./Baltimore • Boston
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Editors' Foreword

Early in the century, American poets went to London in order to be published and recognized. Ezra Pound, Robert Frost, H. D., and T. S. Eliot had their first success abroad. Even William Carlos Williams, who was soon to hoist a flag against the expatriates, published his first commercial volume, *The Tempers* (1913), with Elkin Mathews of London.

By the middle of the century, the trend had reversed itself. W. H. Auden, Christopher Isherwood, Aldous Huxley, and Dylan Thomas had found receptive audiences in the United States. Some of the younger British poets were better appreciated and more readily published across the Atlantic than at home. Charles Tomlinson, for example, brought out his first important volume, *Seeing Is Believing* (1958), with McDowell, Obolensky of New York.

The relationship of Williams (1883–1963) and Tomlinson (b. 1927) thus links the different transatlantic experiences of two generations and adds a fascinating chapter to the changing story of Anglo-American literary interactions in the twentieth century. Born more than four decades apart on opposite sides of the ocean, strongly rooted in their respective nations, regions, and localities, the two poets nevertheless shared many goals and values and genuinely admired one another's work. Although they met only twice, they corresponded for nearly five years from 1957 to 1962, and they helped each other in substantial ways.

The homage of *les jeunes* consoled Williams near the end of a career that had never received the public recognition it deserved. That the homage came in this case from a British source made it all the sweeter, for Williams had long been neglected by the British critical establishment. Despite some modest successes on the London liter-

ary scene around the beginning of the Great War, he had never attracted a dependable readership or a regular publisher there. Among the major English writers of his own generation, only Ford Madox Ford and D. H. Lawrence had fully acknowledged the achievement of Williams. Lawrence was the predecessor Tomlinson had in mind when he told Williams, in his first letter to the American poet: "I have tried . . . to be the second Englishman to read you aright" (Dec. 9, 1957). Tomlinson's admiration and, even more, his formal imitation of the work of Williams allowed the poet from New Jersey to hope that British taste might at last be turning in his favor.

In Tomlinson, the correspondence likewise fostered a sense of recognition and hope at a time in his career when such encouragement was much needed. In *l'an trentuniesme de son eage*, the poet from Staffordshire was a second-year lecturer at the University of Bristol. His first two pamphlets of poetry, *Relations and Contraries* (1951) and *The Necklace* (1955), had been published by small presses outside London, and neither had been well received. His current manuscript, entitled *Seeing Is Believing*, had been turned down by a number of British publishers; C. Day Lewis had penned the rejection for Chatto and Windus (Ross and Tomlinson 25). Having refused to align himself with either of the two dominant trends in post-war British poetry—the neo-romanticism of Dylan Thomas and the neo-classicism of The Movement—Tomlinson had few literary allies.

His communication with Williams, which began late in 1957, brought Tomlinson into contact not only with a great poet but also with a network of his supporters. It was heartening, Tomlinson later recalled, "for me . . . to find myself so suddenly one of a clan whereas previously my sense had been of almost complete poetic isolation" (*Some Americans* 18). That his newfound "clan" consisted largely of Americans must have seemed the odder in view of the fact that Tomlinson had never been to their country.

To be sure, he had been reading American poets—Walt Whitman, Ezra Pound, T. S. Eliot, Wallace Stevens, Marianne Moore, Hart Crane—for nearly ten years. He had even imitated some of them in his own work (*Some Americans* 1–14; Swigg 38–69). Two British friends guided Tomlinson's reading of American poetry: Donald Davie (1922–1995) and Gael Turnbull (b. 1928). Both played important roles in Tomlinson's initiation into the Williams "clan."

Donald Davie was Tomlinson's tutor at Cambridge in 1947–48. A poet-critic of growing influence, Davie became the first important spon-

sor of Tomlinson's work. The publication of Tomlinson's *The Necklace* in 1955 was facilitated by the introduction which Davie wrote for it (*Some Americans* 12). Early in the following year, Davie sent a review copy of the book to Hugh Kenner, thus initiating Tomlinson's personal contacts with the Williams circle in America.

The Necklace also linked Tomlinson to Gael Turnbull, who was to introduce him to the work of Williams. Turnbull and Tomlinson were contemporaries at Cambridge but did not meet there. After graduating in 1947, Turnbull moved with his parents to Philadelphia, where he entered the Medical School of the University of Pennsylvania, Williams' alma mater. Williams received his M.D. from Penn in 1906; Turnbull took his in 1951. Returning to England in 1955, Turnbull settled in Worcester, where he set up a general practice with a specialization in anesthesiology.

In addition to his medical practice, Turnbull wrote poetry and ran Migrant Books, "an organization for circulating recent American and Canadian works which appealed to him" (*Some Americans* 13). Migrant became Robert Creeley's first English publisher when it brought out *The Whip* in 1957. Well versed in contemporary North American poetry and personally acquainted with many of its writers and publishers, Turnbull periodically revisited the States to maintain his contacts. He corresponded with Williams from 1958 to 1961 and met him in Rutherford on September 29, 1958 (Turnbull, "A Visit with William Carlos Williams").

Turnbull first met Tomlinson in Somerset in 1956, having initiated a correspondence with the author of *The Necklace* shortly after its publication. When he saw that some of Turnbull's poems imitated the work of Williams, Tomlinson warned against the influence: "I think it a mistaken course" (Turnbull, "Charlotte Chapel" 11). This caution prompted Turnbull, in the autumn of that year, to lend Tomlinson two recent volumes of Williams' poetry, *The Desert Music* (1954) and *Journey to Love* (1955). Around the same time, Turnbull introduced his friend to the work of Williams' Black-Mountain followers, Creeley and Charles Olson (*Some Americans* 13, 17-18). Tomlinson was soon converted. Acknowledging Turnbull's role as mediator, Tomlinson later characterized him as an "indefatigable and indispensable negotiator between cultures" (*Some Americans* 46).

Besides Davie and Turnbull, there was a third "indispensable negotiator" in the cross-cultural parleying of Tomlinson and Williams. This was the Canadian-born critic, Hugh Kenner (b. 1923), who had taken

his Ph.D. from Yale in 1950 and had already published ground-breaking studies of Ezra Pound (1951), Wyndham Lewis (1954), and James Joyce (1956). From the University of California at Santa Barbara, Kenner was in correspondence with Davie, who had become a fellow of Trinity College, Dublin. Early in 1956, as we have seen, Davie sent Kenner a copy of Tomlinson's *The Necklace*. Kenner promptly reviewed the book in *Poetry* (Chicago) for August 1956. On more than one occasion, Tomlinson has cited this review as a turning point in his career. Soon after its publication, the editor of *Poetry*, Henry Rago, began to solicit and print Tomlinson's new poems, as did the editor of *The Hudson Review* in New York, Frederick Morgan. Kenner's review also interested Marianne Moore, who struck up a correspondence with Tomlinson in November 1956 (*Some Americans* 12-16; Ross and Tomlinson 25-26; Swigg and Tomlinson 229).

In the same month, Kenner was making his first trip to Europe. Having visited Davie in Dublin, he called upon Tomlinson at The Old Rectory in Hinton Blewett, Somerset. There Kenner saw Tomlinson's paintings and read the unpublished manuscript of *Seeing Is Believing*. Upon hearing the story of its British rejections, Kenner volunteered to take the manuscript back to America and seek a publisher for it there. Tomlinson accepted the offer, and Kenner "returned to the States with *Seeing Is Believing* in his satchel" (Ross and Tomlinson 25). Before his departure, though, Kenner traveled from Somerset to London, where he met T. S. Eliot and Wyndham Lewis for the first time. Told of Tomlinson's difficulties with British publishers, Lewis firmly recommended that the young man go west, to America (see Kenner's introduction).

Meanwhile, Tomlinson's poetry was beginning to show the influence of his reading of Williams. Having started with the late poems lent him by Turnbull, Tomlinson worked through the oeuvre in reverse chronological order, moving back to *Paterson*, *Collected Later Poems*, and *Collected Earlier Poems* (*Some Americans* 13, 16). In view of this sequence, it is not surprising that the figure who mattered most to Tomlinson at this stage was not Williams the legendary Imagist, trailblazing author of *Al Que Quiere!*, *Kora in Hell*, and *Spring and All*, but Williams the struggling contemporary, the embattled and self-reappraising author of the poems written after *Paterson IV* and the major stroke of 1951. At first, the groping, hard-won, meditative poems of the later volumes spoke more directly to Tomlinson than did the objectivist vignettes of the earlier books, to which he subsequently extended his interest.

In his early work, Tomlinson tried to stake out a middle ground between the two dominant poetic movements of his day: the lush, expansive, self-dramatizing romanticism of Dylan Thomas, on the one hand; and the austere, reductive, self-effacing, programmatically provincial realism of The Movement, on the other (Kirkham 153). The alternative envisioned by Tomlinson was a poetry of perception which strove to be painstakingly faithful to the realities of the world outside the mind (especially to the physical and temporal realities of place), while remaining no less faithful to the dynamic experience of the perceiving mind. "I was arguing," Tomlinson recalled in a 1981 interview, "for a kind of exactness in the face of the object, which meant an exactness of feeling in the writer" (Ross and Tomlinson 25).

The most useful models for such a poetry of perception and response Tomlinson found in a vital branch of the English Romantic tradition which runs from the meditative, loco-descriptive, "conversation" poems of Wordsworth and Coleridge to the naturalistic prose of Ruskin, the inscaped poetry of Hopkins, the precise syllabics of Marianne Moore, and the dialogic reflections of Wallace Stevens. Tomlinson's goal, as he later summarized it, was "a phenomenological poetry, with roots in Wordsworth and in Ruskin" (Cookson 865).

When he discovered the later poetry of Williams in 1956-57, Tomlinson at once enlisted it in the service of his endeavor to recapture "the attentive reach of the English romantic tradition" (Swigg 92). The best of Williams' later lyrics strike a balance between the contours of the world and the movements of the sentient mind. Tomlinson was particularly drawn to the triadic stanza or three-ply cadence that Williams used in "Asphodel, That Greeny Flower" and many other poems of the 1950s. This structure seemed well suited to the representation of mind in action: "it was the three-ply poems that appealed to me most, perhaps because they afforded the possibility of a more meditative movement . . . [I] needed a form that would progress at a speed resembling that of thought" (*Some Americans* 16). In an eloquent letter of August 29, 1960, Tomlinson tries to convince Williams that the variable foot has affinities with the rhythms of Wordsworth and is not peculiarly American.

The poems in Tomlinson's first three books, including *Seeing Is Believing*, were nearly all completed before he began to read Williams in 1956. The first poems to show the influence of that reading came in February 1957, and all four of them employed the three-ply cadence. One was an overt tribute entitled "Letter to Dr. Williams"; the others were "Sea Poem," which he sent to Williams, "Winter," and

"Le Musée Imaginaire." In all, Tomlinson published twenty original poems in Williams' measure. Seventeen of them appeared in *A Peopled Landscape* (1963) and two in *American Scenes* (1966). In addition, Tomlinson used the form in six of the translations from the nineteenth-century Spanish poet Antonio Machado y Ruiz on which he was working with his friend and colleague, Henry Gifford.

To be sure, Tomlinson's handling of the cadence differs in important ways from that of Williams, as Paul Mariani has pointed out ("Tomlinson's Use of the Williams Triad"). Nevertheless, the English poet found the form so useful at this stage of his development that at one point he spoke of publishing a separate volume containing "all my three-ply Williamsesque" (Tomlinson to Williams, June 2, 1960). He gravitated to Williams for many of the same reasons that were drawing the Black-Mountain poets in America to the same source. At a time when fixed forms were in vogue, Williams offered the model of a freer, more natural verse pattern, an open form flexible enough to mime psychic processes.

Tomlinson's earliest poems in this new form appeared in *Spectrum*, a literary review which Hugh Kenner and his students started early in 1957 at the University of California, Santa Barbara. The first six numbers all carried poems by Tomlinson. "Letter to Dr. Williams" was published in Fall 1957 alongside "Peer of the gods," a translation by Williams of a lyric from Sappho. This conjunction triggered the Williams-Tomlinson correspondence. Williams saw Tomlinson's tribute and wrote to him. Meanwhile, at Kenner's instigation, Tomlinson had already written to Williams. Their first letters to each other crossed in mid-Atlantic. Tomlinson received his at Christmastime 1957.

At the same time, he was notified that *Seeing Is Believing* had been accepted for publication in New York. That Christmas present, too, was a result of his initiation into the Williams clan, for the firm in question—McDowell, Obolensky—was also publishing books by Williams and Kenner at the time. *Seeing Is Believing* reached New York bookshops in 1958, forty-five years after *The Tempers* had appeared in London.

Reviewing the new volume in *Essays in Criticism* for April 1959, Donald Davie observed that

this most original and accomplished of all our post-war poets, profoundly English as he is in his attitudes and nowadays his landscapes, had to wait for

a transatlantic critic, Hugh Kenner, to discover him; for transatlantic magazines to publish him in bulk, pay him, and award him prizes; and for a transatlantic publisher to bring him out between hard covers.

("See. and Believe" 189)

The neglect of which Davie complained did not, however, last much longer. The American success of Tomlinson's book soon led the Oxford University Press to propose an expanded English edition, which came out in 1960. Tomlinson was at last launched, and Oxford has remained his principal publisher ever since.

He and Williams began immediately to support one another's efforts. Williams sent warm praises of *Seeing Is Believing* and reviewed it favorably in *Spectrum* for January 1959. Tomlinson in turn was enthusiastic about *Paterson V*, just out from New Directions. He also participated in a broadcast on the B.B.C.'s Third Programme, in which some of Williams' poems were read along with the "Letter to Dr. Williams." Tomlinson's praise in that poem of Williams' "propriety of cadence" was soon picked up by Denis Donoghue in an article entitled "For a Redeeming Language: William Carlos Williams in American Literature," published in *The Twentieth Century* for June 1958. Cultivating his own audience, each poet was doing what he could to encourage and promote the work of the other.

Tomlinson's first visit to the United States in 1959-60 was also due to his affiliation with the Williams circle. Henry Rago, the editor of *Poetry*, nominated Tomlinson for one of six traveling fellowships offered by the International Institute for Education in New York. The grants made it possible for foreign intellectuals to tour the country for a period of six months. Letters in support of Tomlinson's nomination were submitted by Williams, Kenner, and Marianne Moore. Others who received awards in 1959 were Fernando Arrabal, Italo Calvino, and Günter Grass (Swigg and Tomlinson 229).

Tomlinson and his family arrived in New York in October. In the company of Denise Levertov, he soon called upon Williams in Rutherford and spent a lively afternoon with him (*Some Americans* 24-26). During a stay of several weeks in New York, Tomlinson also met Robert Lowell, Elizabeth Hardwick, and other writers.

The family then crossed to California, where they saw Kenner again in Santa Barbara. Tomlinson also made the acquaintance of Yvor Winters at Stanford (*Some Americans* 27-32). On their way back east, the Tomlinsons came under the spell of New Mexico and the South-

west, a region that fascinated Williams as well (see Witemeyer and Walkiewicz).

Upon reaching New York in April 1960, Tomlinson was introduced to Marianne Moore (*Some Americans* 32–36). He also paid his second and last visit to Williams. The English guests were given several mementoes to take home from Rutherford: a Victorian metal letter-holder shaped like a hand for Charles, and the chickens from an Easter cake for eighteen-month-old Justine (*Some Americans* 25–26, 36–38). When the correspondence resumed in June 1960, it was an exchange not only between the poets but also between their families.

The letters continued for two more years. Poetic cadence and diction were the main subjects of discussion. Williams struggled to formulate his theories of the American idiom and the variable foot in a treatise on measure and a two-page manifesto entitled "The American Idiom." When Tomlinson read the manifesto, he immediately took issue with its chauvinism, pointing out that the three-ply cadence is inherently no better suited to the American idiom than to the English. "As far as I can see the variable foot & your three-ply measure work just as well in Englishman's English as in American" (August 29, 1960).

There was no opportunity to pursue the discussion in person. The deterioration of Williams' health brought an end to the correspondence in June 1962. A few months later, Tomlinson arrived in the United States for a second extended visit, but Williams was not well enough to see him. When Williams died in March 1963, Tomlinson was teaching at the University of New Mexico. He later wrote an elegy entitled "Remembering Williams," which incorporates phrases from the last letters he received from his American friend. He continued to correspond occasionally with Mrs. Williams.

Since 1963, Tomlinson has visited the United States frequently and extended the network of personal contacts that began with his Rutherford correspondence. At home, he has served the memory of Williams well by encouraging the growth of British interest in the poet's work, a trend which began within a year of his death. A London edition of *Pictures from Brueghel* appeared in 1963, and one of *Pater-son* followed soon thereafter. Tomlinson spoke warmly of Williams in the Black-Mountain special issue of *The Review* that he edited for January 1964, and he corrected the *Times Literary Supplement's* review of *Pictures from Brueghel* in a letter to the editor. The anonymous *TLS* reviews of the first English editions of Williams' novels *White Mule* (1965) and *In the Money* (1966) were written by

Tomlinson himself, and he also reviewed three books on Williams from London publishers in the pages of *Encounter* for November 1967.

In 1972 Tomlinson edited an anthology of Williams criticism for Penguin, and in 1976 he put together a *Selected Poems* of Williams for the same publisher. In 1985, an expanded version of the Penguin text was published by New Directions as the American edition of *Selected Poems*, replacing the 1949 edition. The handsome portrait of Williams in Tomlinson's book of memoirs, *Some Americans: A Personal Record* (1981), and the publication of their correspondence in the present volume, are further repayments of the English poet's debt to the American author who helped him at a crucial juncture in his early career. On October 25, 1992, Tomlinson spoke and read at the induction of Williams into the American Poets' Corner of the Cathedral Church of St. John the Divine in New York.

The present volume documents the transatlantic connection of the two men as both a personal relationship and a cultural nexus whose ramifications are still being explored and assessed. To that end, our edition includes texts written not only by the poets themselves but also by scholars of British and American literature who have found the transactions of Williams and Tomlinson relevant to artistic and social issues that continue to engage us.

The documentary record opens with brief retrospective accounts by Tomlinson himself and Hugh Kenner. It continues with an annotated edition of the extant correspondence between Williams and Tomlinson. The letters establish the personal dimension of their relationship and formulate many of the central poetic issues. To contextualize the correspondence, we next present a group of ancillary prose texts that illuminate events and issues discussed in the letters. These include Hugh Kenner's important 1956 review of Tomlinson's *The Necklace*, passages from Kenner's letters to Williams about Tomlinson, and Williams' generous 1959 review of Tomlinson's *Seeing Is Believing*. We also reproduce two late essays by Williams that are mentioned in the letters as part of an ongoing craftsman's debate about national speech-rhythms and diction. One is Williams' fragmentary 1959 essay on "Measure," here reprinted for the first time since its original publication, and the other is his 1960 manifesto on "The American Idiom" (not to be confused with an identically titled subsection of "Measure").

Four prose pieces by Tomlinson follow the Williams essays. Written after the American poet's death, they show the British poet refining

his views of his predecessor's achievement and historical importance. In "The Continuity of American Poetry" Tomlinson surveys the American poetic tradition and locates Williams in its context. "Pictures from Brueghel" defends the unconventional lineation of Williams and the Black Mountain poets against British criticism. Tomlinson's introduction to his edition of Williams' *Selected Poems* presents his most mature and thorough critique of Williams' oeuvre. "William Carlos Williams" is an eloquent tribute to the American poet on a major commemorative occasion. These thoughtful assessments illuminate the poetics of both writers.

The next three essays broaden our perspective still further. In them, three informed observers of the Anglo-American literary scene show how the transatlantic parleyings of Williams and Tomlinson continue to resonate in current cultural discussions. Paul Mariani extends the debate over nationality and poetic measure as he examines Tomlinson's adaptations of Williams' triadic foot. Hugh Kenner assesses Tomlinson's poetic achievement against that of British contemporaries who have been less receptive to American innovation. And Donald Davie distinguishes Tomlinson's "disenchanted" social and political views from those of "sanguine American democrats like W. C. Williams." Forty years on, questions canvassed by Williams and Tomlinson still command our attention.

The edition concludes with a selection of Tomlinson's poems and translations in the three-ply cadence and with his elegy "Remembering Williams." (Three other poems are contained in his letters to Williams.) The poems inspired by Tomlinson's reading of Williams are perhaps the most eloquent and enduring records of their transatlantic connection. The first of the group, "Letter to Dr. Williams," marks the beginning of their friendship. The last, "Remembering Williams," is Tomlinson's most recent verse tribute to Williams; appropriately, it incorporates phrases from the final letters that Williams wrote to his English friend in 1962. Our selection of poems also acts as a reference source, since all of the works in it are discussed or mentioned earlier in the book.

Notes on the Text and Acknowledgments

The known correspondence of William Carlos Williams and Charles Tomlinson consists of twenty-six items, eleven from Williams or Mrs. Williams to Tomlinson and fifteen from Tomlinson or Mrs. Tomlinson to Williams or Mrs. Williams. The earliest letter is dated December 9,

1957; the latest, August 7, 1964. All are included in the present edition. To judge from references in the correspondence and in Tomlinson's poem, "Remembering Williams," other letters were written which have since been lost.

Eight of the eleven letters from the Williamses to the Tomlinsons are housed in the Kenneth Spencer Research Library, University of Kansas, MS 142B: 4-11. The letter dated September 24, 1960, with an addendum by Flossie Williams, the letter to Brenda Tomlinson dated December 8, 1960, and the letter from Flossie dated August 7, 1964, are in the possession of Charles Tomlinson. We are grateful to Mr. Tomlinson and to Alexandra Mason of the Kenneth Spencer Research Library for providing photocopies of these letters, which served as copytexts for the present edition.

Thirteen of the Tomlinsons' fifteen letters to the Williamses are housed in the Beinecke Rare Book and Manuscript Library, Yale University. We are grateful to Dr. Patricia C. Willis, Curator of the American Literature Collection at the Beinecke Library, for providing photocopies of these letters, which also served as copytexts for the present edition. The letter from Tomlinson to Florence Williams, dated August 2, 1964, is among the Williams family papers at 9 Ridge Road, Rutherford. We are grateful to the late William Eric Williams for providing a photocopy of this item. Tomlinson's letter to Williams of June 23, 1958, is in the private collection of Barry Magid.

The acquisition of this last letter led to the present edition. In a 1986 sale of items from Williams' remaining library, Magid purchased Williams' copy of Tomlinson's *Seeing Is Believing*, into which the letter of June 23 was laid. Magid subsequently contacted Tomlinson, asking permission to publish the letter and inquiring about the rest of the correspondence. Tomlinson put him in touch with Hugh Witemeyer, who had independently expressed an interest in editing the letters. Working in collaboration, the editors began to assemble the materials for the present volume.

In transcribing the texts of the letters, we have employed the following guidelines. Letterheads and return addresses have been deleted throughout; otherwise, every letter is reproduced in its entirety, without editorial abridgement. Williams' letters are uniformly from 9 Ridge Road, Rutherford, New Jersey. The Tomlinsons' letters were sent either from The Old Rectory, Hinton Blewett, Somerset, or from Brook Cottage, Ozleworth Bottom, Gloucestershire; the family's move from one address to the other is recorded in the text.

Each item is preceded by a headnote, which gives its number in the present edition, its form, and the number of its leaves. To designate epistolary forms, we have used the following abbreviations: ALS (autograph letter signed), TLS (typed letter signed), and ACS (autograph postcard signed)

Some standardizations have been applied to the texts of the letters. The positions of dates, salutations, closings, and signatures have been regularized, as has the spacing of paragraphs and sentences. Obvious misspellings and typographical errors have been corrected throughout, and capitalization has been standardized. Unpunctuated literary titles have been italicized, missing apostrophes and hyphens have been supplied, and periods have been added to such abbreviations as "Dr." and "Mrs." Otherwise, however, Williams' idiosyncratic punctuation has been preserved. Occasional missing words and alternate readings are suggested in brackets, with question marks. Dates provided by postmarks and editors' notes are also given in brackets.

The letters from Hugh Kenner to Williams reproduced in this edition are housed in the Yale Collection of American Literature, Beinecke Rare Book and Manuscript Library, Yale University. Photocopies of these letters have provided our copytexts. The headnotes and positions of dates in the passages we have excerpted are styled according to the guidelines stated above.

The copytext of Hugh Kenner's "A Creator of Spaces" is its first printing in *Poetry*, listed in "Works Cited" following. The copytexts of Williams' "Seeing Is Believing" and "Measure" are the versions in *Spectrum*, whereas the copytext of "The American Idiom" is the version which appeared in *New Directions 17*. The copytexts of Tomlinson's "The Continuity of American Poetry," "Pictures from Brueghel," and "William Carlos Williams" are the printings listed in "Works Cited." The 1985 *New Directions* edition provides the copytext for Tomlinson's "Introduction to the *Selected Poems*" of Williams; we have deleted the page references following quotations of poems in the edition. The copytext of Paul Mariani's "Tomlinson's Use of the Williams Triad" is its first printing in *Contemporary Literature*. The copytexts of the excerpts from Hugh Kenner's *A Sinking Island* and Donald Davie's "Larkin's Politics, and Tomlinson's" are the printings listed in "Works Cited." In some cases typographical errors and misquotations have been silently corrected.

The copytexts of all but two of the poems of Charles Tomlinson reprinted at the end of our edition are the versions in Tomlinson's

Collected Poems (1985). The copytext of "Poem of a Day" is the version in Tomlinson's *Translations* (1983). The copytext of "Letter to Dr. Williams" is the *Spectrum* version listed in "Works Cited." This poem has never appeared in subsequent collections of Tomlinson's poetry. In a letter of March 19, 1991, to Hugh Witemeyer, Tomlinson explains: "The reason 'Letter to Dr. Wms' was not collected was, in the first place, I thought it would mean little to an English audience. Then I simply forgot about it."

Almost every letter and essay in the edition is followed by a set of explanatory notes. Each note is keyed to the immediately preceding text by the repetition in italics of a word or phrase from that text. The names of William Carlos Williams and Charles Tomlinson are abbreviated in the notes as WCW and CT, respectively. Some of the sources cited in abbreviated form in the notes are fully identified in the list of "Works Cited."

A limited, letterpress edition of *The Letters of William Carlos Williams and Charles Tomlinson*, edited by Barry Magid and Hugh Witemeyer, was published in 1992 by the Dim Gray Bar Press of New York, owned and operated by Barry Magid. The Dim Gray Bar edition comprises 150 copies signed by Charles Tomlinson. It contains the first twenty-four letters that appear in the present edition, the preface by Charles Tomlinson, and the introduction by Hugh Kenner. The Dim Gray Bar edition also includes "Remembering Williams" and a holograph fair copy of Tomlinson's "Letter to Dr. Williams," written out by the author especially for that edition. However, the Dim Gray Bar edition omits the editors' foreword, the annotations of the letters, the other prose texts and notes, the appendix of poems by Tomlinson, and the index. Selections from the Dim Gray Bar edition appeared in *American Poetry Review* 21, 6 (November–December 1992) 27–30.

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Preface

Charles Tomlinson

This correspondence arose after I had written a verse letter to Williams in 1957. I hesitated to actually mail this letter, but it appeared in the autumn number of *Spectrum*, a little magazine published by students at the University of California and with Hugh Kenner on its editorial board. Kenner had already shown the much refused typescript of my first full-scale collection, *Seeing Is Believing*, to his own publisher in New York, and at Christmas 1957 two things happened. I got news of the book's having been accepted, and there was a postcard from Williams which promised a letter "in reply to your poem in *Spectrum*." A few days after, the letter followed and our correspondence was underway.

It was something of a welcome surprise to Williams to be admired by an Englishman, and of the poem which copied the three-ply lay-out of his verse, he wrote: "It makes me feel that my divisions are valid and not mere eccentricities. . . ." So the old poet was encouraged by a young admirer, and the young admirer, whose verse at that time was no more popular in England than that of Williams, felt himself less isolated and in touch with one of the great generation. A new sense of confidence and quite literally a new sense of direction—I was soon to travel to the States—replaced my rather wry awareness of myself as an outsider at home.

Williams was one of the most openly generous people I have known. In spite of his age and the incapacity brought on by his suffering major strokes, he still had a youthful buoyancy and a lively response to people as people. When Denise Levertov kindly took me to see him late in 1959, she warned me of his being easily tired: "Probably better if your wife and child don't come along. It might be too much for him." At

Rutherford, the first thing that Williams asked was, "Wherever's your wife? And the child?" They, too, were to meet him next spring, after our first and longest journey through the length and breadth of the States, then back to New York. And it did not prove too much for him after all.

I see my first meeting with Williams as heralding my meetings with many other Americans, including Marianne Moore, James Laughlin, Louis Zukofsky, George Oppen, Henry Rago (in 1959 editor of *Poetry*), Fred Morgan of *The Hudson Review*, Robert Creeley, Robert Duncan. Later I was also to meet Pound. Going to America in 1959 meant a completely new lease of poetic life for me, and was ultimately to open vistas to both Mexico and Canada, a further reaching out among the spaces and possibilities of the continent.

Getting to know Williams was also bound up with getting to know two others who responded to what I had written, namely Hugh Kenner and Marianne Moore. All three of them were instrumental in different ways in making possible that first trip—Hugh Kenner by finding me a publisher and the others in seconding my nomination by Henry Rago for a travelling fellowship. I have reason to believe that Kenner was also affectionately active in promoting my case, and it was *Spectrum*—in effect *his* review—which had published that (for me) historic "Letter to Dr. Williams." Previously I could never have imagined receiving from one of the great the message, "God be praised! for to meet an Englishman to whom my name is not anathema is almost to be classed by me as an event." That event entailed my getting to know America and Americans: beyond it stretched a future rich in poetry and experience, and one which, without Williams, would have been substantially different, in fact poorer.

Introduction

Hugh Kenner

The Ur-Wizard was Donald Davie, thanks to whom I received a copy of Charles Tomlinson's fascicle, *The Necklace*. In what follows, I figure as the apprentice wizard. I promptly reviewed *The Necklace* for *Poetry*, and in November 1956, *annus mirabilis*, en route between Dublin (Davie) and London (Lewis, Eliot) on my first trip abroad, I stopped off to visit Charles and Brenda at their luscious address: The Old Rectory, Hinton Blewett, Temple Cloud, near Bristol. And we visited Wells Cathedral in their putt-putting car (started, that morning, by coasting down a long hill), and stayed up late of nights talking poetry and examining Charles's paintings (of which I bought two; twenty years later, in Baltimore, they bemused him, so much of his early style had slipped from his memory).

He didn't bemoan his nigh-invisibility but he didn't conceal it either; British reviewers had dismissed *The Necklace* ("... sensibility without mind . . ."—TLS) and British publishers were routinely rejecting his first major collection, *Seeing Is Believing*. In London I described the case to Wyndham Lewis, knowing his keen zest for diagnosing cultural cases. "Tell him," said Lewis, "by all means to go to America." (I told Charles, and later he did go, to New Mexico.) Something else I did, some time in 1957, was urge *Seeing Is Believing* on David McDowell, at that time my publisher (McDowell, Obolensky). And David accepted it; the one and only time a publisher has followed an unsolicited prompting of mine. He was open, clearly, to manifest qualities in Charles's language.

And that's interesting, because William Carlos Williams was too. Yet Tomlinson seems to me the most authentically English of poets, and Williams as everyone knows professed doctrinaire Americanism.

Charles had read American poets as a schoolboy (see the opening pages of his memoir *Some Americans*), and one thing he'd picked up—something Williams could recognize—was the tense force latent in single words. I'd visited Williams on the eve of that first transatlantic flight, and when I got home he was all curiosity. (Could one really, he wanted to know, talk to Eliot “animal to animal”?) I forget how I dodged that one; but part of the news I had for him pertained to the manifest quality of a young English poet near Bristol (of whom Eliot's Faber & Faber, by the way, made nothing).

What Tomlinson learned from Williams is a matter of record, for the diligent to codify. And in Williams's last stricken years it will have done him immeasurable good to know that Tomlinson was there; that he wasn't condemned to a province; hadn't after all failed to move a British sensibility.

The letters tell a sweet story. Bill's generous enthusiasm will be news to many who've bought the cliché image of the Rutherford Provincial. And it's an education to watch Charles respond to *Pater-son V*, rereading, marking passages (see Oct. 28, 1958). His last letter arrived in Rutherford a mere eight months before Bill Williams died.

The Correspondence of William Carlos Williams and Charles Tomlinson

1. ALS-3

Dec. 9 [1957]

Dear Dr. Williams,

I was cheered and deeply honoured when Hugh Kenner recently wrote to tell me that he had shown you a poem of mine, 'The Atlantic' in a past issue of *The Hudson*. One works so much amid isolation and indifference that the news of someone's having been interested by one's work comes always as an unexpected cordial. When that someone is a major writer like yourself the impetus to go ahead is immense. In this country one is in hopeless competition with mediocre rhymesters who have gone back to the iambic tick-tock; as for publishers, they will take no chances. Whatever the short-comings in the States people *seem* more open to things—an illusion, no doubt, based on the romantic perspectives it is possible to construct from this distance. I have hopefully sent a copy of a large book of verse to New Directions & to McDowell-Obolensky but the deepening silence from that direction bodes little good. Pazienza!

I have often wondered whether you ever read D. H. Lawrence's review of your *In the American Grain*? It hasn't been reprinted in 25 years and I've always thought it a miniature masterpiece of reviewing (it appears in his volume *Phoenix*). There, at any rate, is *one* Englishman who has done you justice. What you say of the sense of touch in your great book, indeed, your diagnosis in general accords remarkably closely with a good deal of D. H. L.'s *Studies in Classic American Literature*. It was his review first directed me to read Dr. Williams. I have tried, inadequately, I fear, to be the second Englishman to read

you aright & to celebrate the fact in a little poem in the current *Spectrum*. Alas, your three-decker cadences are your own and in using them one rapidly discovers one's technical incompetence.

Homage and good wishes!
Sincerely,
Charles Tomlinson

Hugh Kenner: Hugh Kenner (b. 1923) is the author of *The Poetry of Ezra Pound* (1951), *Wyndham Lewis* (1954), *Dublin's Joyce* (1956), *The Invisible Poet: T. S. Eliot* (1959), *The Pound Era* (1971), *A Homemade World* (1975), *A Sinking Island* (1987), and many other studies of modern literature. In 1957 Kenner was Associate Professor of English at the University of California, Santa Barbara, and founding editor of *Spectrum*, the University's literary magazine. He is now Franklin and Calloway Professor of English at the University of Georgia.

'*The Atlantic*': This poem appeared in CT's "Four Poems," *Hudson Review*, IX, 4 (Winter 1956-57): 514, and was later reprinted as the opening poem in *Seeing Is Believing*.

New Directions: Founded by James Laughlin in 1936, New Directions was WCW's principal publisher from 1936 to 1950 and from 1960 to the present.

McDowell-Obolensky: Founded by David McDowell and Ivan Obolensky, this New York publishing company operated from 1957 to 1960. It issued two books by WCW, *Selected Letters* (1957) and *Yes, Mrs. Williams* (1959), and one by CT, *Seeing Is Believing* (1958).

D. H. Lawrence's review: Lawrence reviewed WCW's *In the American Grain* (1925) in "American Heroes," *The Nation* (New York), 122 (April 14, 1926): 413-14. Rpt. in *Phoenix: The Posthumous Papers of D. H. Lawrence*, ed. Edward D. McDonald (1936; rpt. New York: Viking Press, 1968): 334-36, and in CT's *William Carlos Williams: A Critical Anthology* 89-91. Lawrence's *Studies in Classic American Literature* was first published in 1923.

a little poem: CT's "Letter to Dr. Williams" is reproduced below.

2. TCS

[Dec. 17, 1957]

Recent letter recd. Many thanks. You will have a letter from me shortly, just mailed it yesterday in reply to your poem in SPECTRUM, very good.

The letter sent to you a day or two ago was sent c/o Kenner whose address I had but not yours, I hope he forwarded it to you in time, I sent it ordinary mail not air-mail so that will take at least a week to reach you.

Take care of yourself. Poetry is a tough racket.

Sincerely yours
WILLIAMS

a letter: The letter of Dec. 15, 1957 below. Because this postcard was mailed after but received before the letter, it was CT's first communication from WCW.

3. TLS-1

Dec. 15/57

Dear Tomlinson:

Through Hugh Kenner I have just become acquainted with your name, God be praised! for to meet an Englishman to whom my name is not anathema is almost to be classed by me as an event. Not that I give a damn except as it signalizes the advent of someone who may turn out to be a friend.

That poem which has been printed in SPECTRUM seems to clinch the matter. What you have written in that poem is high praise for me and I am all the more impressed that you have allowed yourself to copy (in this instance) my form. Anyone who is influenced by a verse form which liberates English verse is my friend.

Let's not go into that at the moment. I'm amazed that your lines fall so easily and beautifully into the pattern of my verses in *Desert Music & Journey to Love*. It makes me feel that my divisions are valid and not mere eccentricities—and that they may be susceptible of proliferation. There is no room for rancour in any serious study of English verse, your attitude shows a light hearted spirit which is tremendously encouraging to me. As you may know I have not many friends among the scholars in this country as well as England. A small clan makes for penetration in the attack when our front must be consolidated at all costs.

I'm glad to make your acquaintance, it bodes well for, I think, both of us if we can keep our eyes on the ball. It's a job in which Hugh Kenner can be a vast help with his undoubted scholarship in strengthening our position. My wife is now reading me a collection of his essays written in the last 5 years which McDowell, Obolensky is about to bring out. They fairly knock my head off! I have never read anything quite like them. I think they'll raise quite a stink in academic circles on both sides of the pond.

You're from the Liverpool area. Good weather to you on all the fronts, it's a great life. I know nothing about [you?] but the barest of reports. At least you're no snob. We'll exchange letters and find out more about each other as we go along. Glad to have made your acquaintance. Keep going.

Sincerely yours
William Carlos Williams

the pattern of my verses: In *Some Americans* 17–18, CT quotes the first three paragraphs of this letter and explains that *The Desert Music* (1954) and *Journey to Love* (1955) were the first volumes of poetry by WCW that he ever read. On CT's use of the triadic or three-ply line-structure that he found in these books, see the editors' foreword. WCW first used the pattern in "The Descent" (*Paterson*, Book Two); he liked to call it the "variable foot."

a collection of his essays: Hugh Kenner, *Gnomon*.

4. ALS-3

Jan. 11. [1958]

Dear Dr. Williams,

I was delighted & cheered to receive your letter & also the card. The letter came auspiciously, enclosed with the news from Kenner that McDowell-Obolensky are to publish my book of poems in the spring under the title *Seeing Is Believing*. It is typical of Kenner that he should have undertaken to push the book. His astuteness and generosity are a godsend at a time when critics seem to exist for their own self-advertisement and for the proliferation of books on books on books. Some of his shorter reviews on current poetry such as have appeared in *Shenandoah* & *Poetry* are superb in their grasp of essential values. Just over a year ago he sorted through a pile of versifier's garbage sent to him for reviewing, found a pamphlet of mine, *The Necklace*, & wrote a full-scale piece on it—just that complete commitment of reputation that Pound has asked for in the critic! He saw the essentials & he also saw the limitations of what I was then doing & he clarified them for me in my own mind. Which is more than any professional critic has done before or since. I await *Gnomon* with the warmest anticipation.

I also await with great interest the recording in the Poems in Folio series in order to hear your reading of the Sappho. I want to hear that 'propriety of cadence' as it should be heard. Difficult for an English-

man to hit it off (I've read a good deal of Williams to my wife) even *without* the Oxford voice. I enclose for your delectation (I trust) a little piece in your recent metre. Two others appeared in the second issue of *Spectrum*.

One hears that you are still at work on your epic. Is the work-in-progress to appear anywhere?

By the way, a friend of mine who is a fluent speaker of Russian has recently taken me through Blok & Mayakovsky—the latter uses a triple decker cadence & rhymes it a b a. Surprising the resemblance between you & him.

Every good wish & for your encouragement (Lord, how one needs it) many many thanks.

Sincerely,
Charles Tomlinson

SEA POEM

A whiter bone:
 the sea-voice
 in a multiple monody
crowding towards that end.
 It is as if
 the transparencies of sound
composing such whiteness
 disposed many layers
 with a sole movement
of the various surface,
 the depths, bottle-glass green
 the bed, swaying
like a fault in the atmosphere, each
 shift
 with its separate whisper, each whisper
a breath of that singleness
 that 'moves together
 if it moves at all,'
and its movement is ceaseless,
 and to one end—
 the grinding
a whiter bone.

[The quotation is from Wordsworth's 'Resolution and Independence']

a pamphlet of mine: The poems in CT's *The Necklace* were written between December 1950 and March 1953 (*Some Americans* 12).

a full-scale piece: Hugh Kenner, "A Creator of Spaces," reprinted on pp. 35–42.

the Sappho: WCW's "Peer of the gods," a translation of a lyric by Sappho, appeared in the same issue of *Spectrum* (Fall 1957) as CT's "Letter to Dr. Williams." The translation was also published in *Evergreen Review* for Fall 1957 and as a broadside entitled "Sappho: A Translation by William Carlos Williams" (San Francisco: Grabhorn Press, 1957) in the Poems in Folio series. The same series also issued CT's "Solo for a Glass Harmonica" in 1957. "Peer of the gods" was later incorporated into Book Five, Part 2 of WCW's *Paterson*.

a little piece in your recent metre: In *Some Americans* 16, CT explains that he wrote "Sea Poem" in February 1957 "in emulation of the three-ply cadences that Williams used in the two books of his I had read."

Two others: "Winter" and "Le Musée Imaginaire" were also written in February 1957 (*Some Americans* 16). They are reprinted on pp. 140–41.

a friend of mine: Professor Charles Henry Gifford (b. 1913) was a colleague of CT in the Department of English at the University of Bristol. A scholar of comparative literature, Gifford is an authority on Russian literature; he also reads Greek, Latin, and Spanish. His publications include *The Hero of His Time: A Theme in Russian Literature* (1950), *The Novel in Russia* (1964), *Comparative Literature* (1969), and *Pasternak: A Critical Study* (1977). He and CT collaborated on translations of Russian and Spanish poetry; see the notes to the letter of August 29, 1960.

Blok: Aleksandr Blok (1880–1921), Symbolist poet and playwright. At one stage Gifford projected a study entitled *The Poetry of Aleksandr Blok*, but it was not completed.

Mayakovsky: Vladimir Mayakovsky (1893–1930), Futurist poet and playwright. He appears with Marianne Moore in CT's poem, "Over Brooklyn Bridge," written in the three-ply cadence and reprinted on pp. 141–42. Around 1920 Mayakovsky began to experiment with progressively indented lines of two, three, or four steps. His poems of the mid-1920s, including one called "Brooklyn Bridge," employ many varieties and combinations of these stepped lines. The *aba* rhymes to which CT refers occur not within triads but among successive sets of indented lines; the rhyme falls on the last, farthest-indented, word in each set. WCW had met Mayakovsky and heard him read in New York City on September 19, 1925; see WCW's *Autobiography* (1967) 163, and Mariani, *William Carlos Williams* 247–48.

Wordsworth's 'Resolution and Independence': This note is CT's. In stanza XI of "Resolution and Independence," Wordsworth describes the leech-gatherer in the following terms: "Motionless as a cloud the Old Man stood, / That heareth not the loud winds when they call; / And moveth all together, if it move at all." For a discussion of the allusion, see Swigg 112–13.

Jan. 16/58

Dear Charles:

“Sea Poem” is a fine piece that impresses me both for its scholarly composition in the English sense of the term and for its generosity toward the American idiom and all it implies for me. I’m happy that Dave has accepted your book for McDowell, Obolensky, Inc., that’s a beginning for you in this country at least. What will they think of you in England! You’ll have to chance that. It implies many things which, perhaps, only in the political field can be resolved—except among moral and artistic titans. Good luck to you.

Hugh Kenner’s is a valuable talent, I’m glad you have had a chance at him and that he has been of assistance to you. It’s all in midbattle with us now. But the intelligence must have its chance to see what it can do for us, we may lose out in the end opposed to the academy as it is encountered at Oxford & Cambridge but we have to go ahead in this country. And maybe, if the old has grown ankylosed, therefore rigid, and is obstructing necessary change it may be that a necessary change is impending. It may not be pleasant to face but the results CANNOT but be good, even out of well hated America. No one, not even Pound, takes the necessary changes in our poetic construction half seriously enough.

You are fortunate to have encountered a Russian speaking poet who can translate for you. And read in the original the works you are interested in. In the international of the intelligence we are often blocked by our lack of knowledge of a foreign language. What would I do without my very faulty knowledge of French?! I know no Greek at all and a very scanty knowledge of German and Spanish . .

I hope you’ll write to me occasionally and tell me more of what you are doing. I myself have just finished *Paterson 5* which I hope before long you’ll get a chance to see. As far as recordings of my readings are concerned there are some records available if you can find them but the old ones were read too fast, too nervously, and the recent ones I don’t think are available and pretty soon I won’t be able to record at all—I can’t read very well any more.

It’s been a pleasure to chat this way in a letter.

Sincerely yours
Bill

Dear Charles: CT quotes the salutation and opening sentence of this letter in *Some Americans* 20.

Paterson 5: Paterson (Book Five) was published in New York by New Directions in September 1958.

recordings of my readings: For a checklist of recordings made by WCW between 1942 and 1954, see Emily Mitchell Wallace, *A Bibliography of William Carlos Williams* (Middletown, Conn.: Wesleyan University Press, 1968): 259–65. The two most widely disseminated recordings were made by the Library of Congress in 1945 and Caedmon Publishers in 1954 (Wallace, items F2 and F19).

6. ALS-3

June 23. [1958]

Dear Bill Williams,

I'm ashamed to have been so long in replying to your last letter. I trust that by this time McDowell-Obolensky will have acted on my instructions to forward you a copy of *Seeing Is Believing* & that the England which surrounds the above address will be percolating into the Rutherford atmosphere: stone built walls everywhere, stone of every size, from cobblestone to freestone to drystone to mushroom-stone, beautiful articulation of space with curving stone walls round the churchyards, round the remaining manor houses, round the smallest cottages. Alas, men have forgotten how to build and now we have the steady importation everywhere of stereotyped houses built of dehydrated seagull turd or some such mixture—THINGS that haven't *felt* their way into the texture of the landscape as the Englishman's building has known how to do for centuries. As in *The Amer. Grain* it is a question of touch and the English are losing touch as the Americans seem to have lost it. It is sad because there is still a core to the life here in Somerset & the people are splendid in many ways with an astonishing gentleness and hospitality. I've tried to get the feel of the place into poems like *On the Hall at Stowey* (a couple of miles from here) and in *The Churchyard Wall*. I've seldom seen anything so symbolically, so sensuously reassuring as the act of rebuilding a drystone wall: no mortar is used, only stone which must be *felt* into position. And it can STILL be done thank God. Perhaps it is done in the States?

I apologize for this—[corner torn off original] I was tearing off a piece of blotting paper just now & the letter came away with it.

I have been enjoying your volume of *Letters* recently & am looking forward to *Paterson V*.

Hugh Kenner was here a month or so back: I was able to show him Bath which is near us & a superb architectural experience.

And now what I had intended to say earlier: the B.B.C. broadcast a handful of *Williams* of late & concluded the programme with my *Sea Poem & Letter to Williams*. History is being made, you see! Bridges are being built. In *real* stone.

Tante belle cose,
Cordially,
Charles

the above address: The Old Rectory, Hinton Blewett, Somerset

On the Hall at Stowey and The Churchyard Wall: These meditative poems appeared in *Seeing Is Believing* (1958); the former was also published in *Spectrum*, II, 1 (Winter 1958): 37-39.

your volume of Letters: William Carlos Williams, *Selected Letters*, ed. John C. Thirlwall (New York: McDowell, Obolensky, 1957)

the B.B.C.: On March 3, 1958, the British Broadcasting Company's Third Programme carried a 30-minute feature entitled "New Poetry: Selected and Introduced by Thomas Parkinson" of the University of California at Berkeley. In this program, according to the *Radio Times* for February 28, 1958, "Professor Parkinson discusses recent volumes by Williams, Allen Ginsberg, Josephine Miles, and the English poet Charles Tomlinson. . . . Mr. Ginsberg and Mr. Tomlinson read their own work." The program was rebroadcast on May 10, 1958, but no recording of it is housed in the National Sound Archive in London.

7. TLS-1

July 12/58

Dear Charles:

Your file of letters which I got out last night and had Flossie read for me, all 3 of them, gave me the whole picture as much as I know of it since before the book was published. A night or two ago Floss read me the entire book of the poems. We were deeply impressed: the most moving book out of England that I have ever read. The pleasure we got out of it made me place it prominently on a lower shelf of the bookcase. We'll read it again from time to time so that we can familiarize ourselves with every poem for the pleasure it gives us. Well done.

The shorter pieces past the middle of the book made us prick up our ears. That was just before supper. Then after supper Floss began at the back reading in reverse, a poem at a time. The pleasure began to take hold of us. As we went on I could see that this was no tyro but a feeling man who could construct a poem as it should be built. We

gave ourselves up completely to the poems, reading many of them over several times until we had to go to bed.

I'm delighted to hear that you know Gael Turnbull. We have been corresponding for over a year. His former residence in the states and that he is a graduate of the U. of P makes me feel as if he were a member of my own family. Strange that two such men living close together in the same part of England should be the first to give the hand to the New World interest in this ancient craft. Were we living near each other we could talk and talk until I at least would be exhausted. How can *anyone* get through talking on the subject of the poem?

On the Hall at Stowey, is a thrilling poem *The Atlantic*, is another. Hugh Kenner is more competent to speak of the construction of the language, how it has been influenced by our transatlantic modes. I can only say that the deadly addiction to the iambic pattern has been avoided. I salute it in an Englishman but it has not been a surrender but a perception of a new world of today. I think I could talk forever on the subject. But the main thing is that you have written a good book. You are as a young painter friend of mine has been recently saluted, A Celebrant. I can't go on. I am grateful for your book of poems, I find it a major event in my modern world.

Sincerely yours
Bill

Paterson 5 carries the theme out of the physical world of the Paterson environments into the mind, off the earth, unconfined by any one place to a congeries of places—howbeit closely associated with the story. And since a man is the chief hero, a woman carries the burden in this part. She is no virgin, that is emphasized. My whole life has been spent in close association with one woman or another and so I felt it would be a misrepresentation to end the poem without saluting woman.

W.C.W.

Pat. 5 will be published at the end of August—did I say that before. I'm grateful that Kenner has let you have some of the earlier books. Cesa!

W.C.W.

the most moving book out of England: CT quotes WCW's tribute to *Seeing Is Believing* in *Some Americans* 20.

Gael Turnbull: Scottish-American poet and physician (b. 1928), whose publications in this period include *Trio* (1954), *The Knot in the Wood* (1955), *Bjarni Spike-Helgi's Son* (1956), *A Libation* (1957), and *With Hey. Ho* (1961). For Turnbull's relationships with WCW and CT, see the editors' foreword.

the U. of P: The University of Pennsylvania, where WCW and Gael Turnbull both studied medicine.

a young painter friend of mine: The painter and environmental artist Henry Ernst Niese (b. 1924) was born in Jersey City, New Jersey, and educated at The Cooper Union and Columbia University in New York City. He now teaches art at the University of Maryland. In a letter to Hugh Witemeyer of November 7, 1991, Niese explains the origin of the phrase, "A Celebrant" as follows: "In 1956, I was getting ready to have my first one man show at the 'G' Gallery in NYC. James Kearns, a fellow artist—a sculptor—who was a friend and also represented by 'G' Gallery, sent me a letter in which he included a wonderful statement about me. He said I could use it in the brochure for the show. The statement began, 'Henry Niese is a Celebrant . . .'. . . . At that time, Bill and Flossie would spend occasional weekends at my farm in Hackettstown, NJ . . . I showed him the statement Jim had written, and he loved it. I would have used Jim's statement, except that Bill wrote me the one that I used instead." Niese further recalls his friendship with WCW in "William Carlos Williams: A Remembrance," *The Journal of the Medical Society of New Jersey*, 80, 9 (September 1983): 689–97.

8. ALS-3

July 27. [1958]

Dear Bill,

I was delighted and relieved to have your approval of *Seeing Is Believing*. I had imagined that a book so close to the grain of the English setting could have little appeal for an American reader. On the contrary, the poems contained in it have been almost all rejected over here by the magazines & the book itself turned down by a wearily long list of London publishers. Kenner saw at once what was being done, McDowell accepted—and you know the rest. At least, I hope there'll be a rest & that the book will not fall as silently unrecognised from the press as did my 15 poems, *The Necklace*, published here by a little outfit in '53 or so. Again, virtually all the reconnaissance readers were Americans—Gael Turnbull being one of them.

Gael returns to the States tomorrow. He & his wife were here on a farewell visit a week or so ago & a pleasant time we had taking pictures under our massive beech tree & walking out among the hay fields. It was a double farewell. We too are leaving here in late August, having just acquired our own house—cottage, rather. A charming seven roomed affair in a Gloucestershire valley. A splendid setting but I shall be sorry to leave Hinton Blewett—there is a singular purity about the village: it's not just a suburban dormitory but a self-contained community with a life of its own, removed from the bustle & petrol stations of

the main road, and assured of its own rhythms, its own compactness and togetherness. We know everybody here & the experience is rather like that I have known in Italy—life is lived from the primary centres and there are few superfluities. When commercial television broke on it all a couple of years ago one's fears were of the worst. It hasn't helped, but a gang of money sharpeners can't kill the communal mind overnight. There is a reservoir of psychic energy still left in the rural centres of England & if my poetry has done anything I think that perhaps it has tapped it. I'm not fleeing from the modern city—I'm concerned with transmitting those deeper vibrations which the English city has lost these fifty years and more, and without which no true *civitas* can endure. A more radical *civility* subsists in the Somerset village than on the streets of Liverpool.

I look forward to receiving *Paterson V* shortly. I'm sure it will be a splendid conclusion.

I hope my babble about the English countryside doesn't bore you. I was so immensely cheered by your last.

Every good wish to Mrs. Williams & yourself.

Saluti,
Charles

9. ALS-2

Aug. 21. [1958]

Dear Bill,

Just a note to say two things. First, have you seen *The Twentieth Century* for June?—I take it that it's available over there? An article by Denis Donoghue on your work. How he got it into *The 20th C Gawd* alone knows. But a damn useful platform. The only semi-intelligent monthly with any kind of circulation over here. We shall see the collected works under the impress Faber & Faber yet. And what will the Empire do then, by God?

Second: we move on Aug. 28. to a new address—stone cottage—all our own—at:

1 BROOK COTTAGES, OZLEWORTH, WOTTON-UNDER-EDGE,
GLOUCESTERSHIRE.

Brief interlude for the muse.

STONE WALLS: Chew Magna

In this unyielding, even
Afternoon glow
One by one ,
You could unfasten
Like the tendrils of ivy
The filaments of all these
Sagging networks
Where the shadowed space
Divides walls
Into friable, pink blocks
And the glow would spread
More evenly over
Their resolved opacity
But who would unmake
This dislocation where
Each is located?

All the best to you both,
Charles

An article: Denis Donoghue, "For a Redeeming Language: William Carlos Williams in American Literature," *The Twentieth Century*, 163, 976 (June 1958): 532-42. Donoghue quotes CT on WCW's "propriety of cadence" (540), a phrase used in CT's "Letter to Dr. Williams." CT later described Donoghue's essay as "the first piece of real criticism to appear on Williams in a significant English review" (*William Carlos Williams: A Critical Anthology* 208).

Faber & Faber: A major London publisher of modern poetry, including that of T. S. Eliot and Ezra Pound.

STONE WALLS: Chew Magna: This poem appears in *Seeing Is Believing* under the title "Stone Walls: At Chew Magna." The village of Chew Magna lies south of Bristol and north of Hinton Blewett.

10. TLS-1

Sept. 3/58

Dear Charles:

Congratulations on completing your move to Stone Cottage, I'll copy the difficult address on the envelope of my letter, I hope I'm able

to direct it aright. Also a note has been sent to Brentano's, Inc., a N.Y. book store asking them to send me a copy of *The Twentieth Century*, for June, so that I may read Denis Donoghue's article—you'd think he would send me one himself long since.

You're a good poet and I'm proud to have you as an interested friend. It was a happy incident that Hugh Kenner met you in England and had the keenness and knowledge to recognize your importance to English verse. I'm afraid he let you in for a hard stint of uphill labor before you make any headway in gaining any recognition for what you are doing with the poetic line but it is a fundamentally important labor in the development of English modern prosody. Your failure to be recognized by our present day critics of the art is to be expected as a matter of course but your lot is not mollified by that. I hope I live long enough to have you come out on top as you are bound to do in the end.

I will be 75 on the 17th of this month, our Constitution Day, and have been hard at work getting my *Pat 5* ready for publication the same day. It has a drawing of me on the jacket cover made by my brother years ago which I do not approve of but that's that. You'll see the book as soon as I can get it to you. I hope you'll find something in it you can like—I'm not too sure of anything these latter days.

I am promised a play for an "off Broadway" performance in early October but I don't half trust the producer, I am sure he wants to get some money out of me before he will consent to go ahead, in which [case?] there'll be no play because I won't give him any, I'm too old for that.

Then David McDowell has me working on a book to be entitled, *Your Grandmother, My Son*, made up of notes taken down at her bedside when she was in her 80s etc. etc. One must keep occupied as age approaches. This book is in its final stage, should be finished before long.

Then, most important for us, you and me, is the book, also half written, on MEASURE. It is a difficult book for me to write because I have not been schooled sufficiently in English prosody. But with assistance from Kenner I have broken the back of the problem, the technical problem, and can confidently predict an early '59 deadline. I am fascinated by the problems which this book presents concerning us all I look forward with confidence to your sympathetic cooperation when I am able to send you advance sheets of what is going on—early next year.

I have gotten to be a terrific egotist and, I must say a terrific bore about the house talking of only the one thing. I'm sorry for my wife whom, you must have understood long since, I worship—tho' she will not acknowledge she finds much evidence of it sometimes in my deeds. We get along.

We're getting some brilliant cool days finally this summer. My wife lost a young cousin by pneumonia very suddenly a couple of weeks ago which shook her up quite a bit. Such is life. Good luck to you and your family in your new house.

Sincerely yours
William Carlos Williams

Stone Cottage: CT's new home was Brook Cottage. His description of it in the preceding letter as a "stone cottage" caused WCW to give the wrong name here.

a play: WCW's *Many Loves* was performed 216 times by the Living Theater between January 13 and November 17, 1959. Most of the performances took place on the second floor of a converted department store at the corner of Sixth Avenue and 14th Street (Mariani, *William Carlos Williams* 745-46).

Your Grandmother, My Son: This biography of WCW's mother was eventually published under the title *Yes, Mrs. Williams* (New York: McDowell, Obolensky, 1959).

MEASURE: WCW never completed this book. His notes toward it were edited by Hugh Kenner and published in 1959 as an essay entitled "Measure." It is reprinted on pp. 49-76.

a young cousin: Four years younger than Floss, Elvyn Olaf Haslund of Wilmington, Vermont, was her first cousin, the son of her mother's brother, Einar Hjalmar Hafslund. Elvyn Haslund died August 21, 1958, at the age of 64.

11. ALS-3

Sept. 12. [1958]

Dear Bill,

I fear this will arrive too early or too late—I'm not sure how one calculates the air mail—but it's to wish you a very happy birthday and a very happy *Paterson V*. How thrilling to hear of all your projects—it's you who have all the joie de vivre that youth (myself) has ascribed to it: there are you at work on the grandmother book & the book on metric (how I long to see 'em) and here am I preparing lectures for next term at Bristol University: using the precious energies I had hoped to keep for verse. It's been a tiring summer with the move, but

Ozleworth is lovely: a long deep valley between pasturelands—stone houses, stone walls, wide skies and rich lush woods crowning the hilltops between the pastures. Our daughter, little Justine aged 9 months, will have a paradise to grow up in.

A batch of reviews from various U.S. papers has just arrived. The trouble is, they're respectful about *Seeing Is Believing* but none of them registers any *difference of dimension* between the book & the 1/2 dozen volumes of verbiage reviewed alongside. Lord, one needs so much patience, so much quiet encouragement. Ach! it's discouraging to be placed in the queue by the nonentities of reviewers.

But I am bemoaning my personal affairs when I had taken up my pen to wish you a happy birthday. I have a little poem for you—about the boy at our last village, Hinton Blewett, who every evening drove a herd of cows & a bull through the place, shouting, 'Moind the bull! moind the bull.'

HISTORY

It is the unregarded congruence:
 The boy who cries 'Bull'
 Because he is leading one
 Past the antique cart
 Which the winter's advent
 Will convert to firewood.
 He does not mark it
 Nor will he mark its absence—
 Himself, the guardian
 Of a continuity he cannot see
 And—grant him means—
 Would injure readily:
 Admire, but not revere
 This inarticulate philosopher.

And many happy returns along with every good wish to you & Mrs. Williams.

Sincerely,
 Charles

Our daughter: Justine Benedikte Tomlinson was born November 24, 1958.

HISTORY: This poem appears in CT's *A Peopled Landscape* 5.

12. ALS-3

Oct. 28. [1958]

Dear Bill,

Paterson 5 is here safe and sound, alive and kicking, shaming the silences, and telling 'em all they'll have to be trying damn hard in the future. It puts the whole into a new perspective and I have done what in conscience had to be done before writing you my many thanks for this lovely book: I've re-read the whole work. And now one sees how inevitable it all was: this modulation into absolute completion bringing the full dimension of innocence, of maturity and wisdom into the trajectory of the whole. It has its paradisal quality—I do not imagine you had Dante in mind but the dimension of total experience which shapes the *Comedia* towards its paradise necessarily shapes *Paterson* towards this world of the forest, the satyr, the unicorn, the tapestry. Having faced the *present* throughout you can *afford* the past now. That fact was evident in that earlier reference, in *Bk. IV* to the choral of the Abbess Hildegard sung at her funeral:

. . . she had written it for the occasion
and it was done, the peasants kneeling
in the background . as you can see

Again, in the tapestry, there is no nostalgia but a direct current of life drawn out of the past but only because the present has been lived through, has been suffered through.

The sexual theme & the renewal of innocence bring to my mind once more the fact that it was D. H. Lawrence, who explored that same territory, who was the first Englishman to see the meaning & the reality of *In the American Grain*. I have gone back of late to your fine elegy on Lawrence—Kenner sees Joyce feeding your fires, but surely Lawrence is unmistakably there also? Yes?

But this is lapsing into mere details of literary scholarship. Qu'importe ça?! Let me tell you the passages I have especially underscored in *Paterson 5*: the marvellous letters on flowers & the nest in the pocket; 'Peer of the gods' (the Sappho); the Breughel nativity, the passage 'A flight of birds, all together', the whole wonderful chunk down to 'all together for his purposes'—the GREATEST single stretch in the book & one of the finest in the whole poem—; the whole of the

Unicorn passage carries exclamations on exclamations. Forgive me that I have so defaced the book, but let my scribblings be the measure of my thanks, my praise and my gratitude. The book is splendid.

All the best to you both,
Charles

you can afford the past now: Hugh Kenner makes the same point about the Abbess Hildegard passage in *Gnomon* 49–50: “by so late in the poem, Dr. Williams has so thoroughly presented the actual Paterson world that he can afford to insert one measuring point from the European past without sentimental nostalgia.” In “The Continuity of American Poetry” (1962, reprinted on pp. 79–85). CT quotes the Abbess Hildegard passage and cites Kenner’s remark about it.

the Abbess Hildegard: In Book Four, Part 2 of *Paterson*, WCW writes:

—and the Abbess Hildegard, at her own
funeral, Rupertsberg, 1179
had enjoined them to sing the choral, all
women, she had written for the occasion
and it was done, the peasants kneeling
in the background . as you may see

Saint Hildegard of Bingen (1098–1179) was founder and abbess of the Benedictine convent of Rupertsberg in Germany. She wrote mystical-scientific treatises, invented a new language, and composed liturgical poetry and music. She was buried before the altar of the church at Rupertsberg. We have not identified the picture of her funeral to which WCW appears to refer.

your fine elegy on Lawrence: WCW’s “An Elegy for D. H. Lawrence” was first published in *Poetry*, XLV, 6 (March 1935): 311–15. It was reprinted in *An Early Martyr and Other Poems* (1935).

Kenner sees Joyce feeding your fires: In *Gnomon* 51, Kenner writes: “Williams draws on other inventors: Pound who in cutting *The Waste Land* and building *The Cantos* revised our concept of poetic structure, Joyce who fused a man and a city and spent his life in astringent, compassionate cataloguing of banalities so as to set them down and force them to utter the poetry they ordinarily short-circuit. The very title is a Joycean pun: Paterson is a city, a man (sometimes a doctor), and Pater-son, the molecule of generative succession.”

13. ALS-3

Jan. 5 [1959]

Dear Bill,

Spectrum came yesterday and, really, what an unlooked for surprise to see you there reviewing me! And what a generous encourag-

ing piece you have given me! A little encouragement goes a long way with poets, as you well know, and how heartened I feel to have the support of your wise, perspicacious and warm enthusiasm. Yes, it is worth going on. I sometimes doubt it, faced with the charges of inhumanity & coldness in my verse—that's just about all *Seeing Is Believing* has drawn from my own milieu. How right you [are?]: once Englishmen will take these poems to their hearts I think they *will* see the rapport, the rootedness, the grain that their suburbanised minds cannot elicit from the poems at present. The coldness they see is their own reflected numbness, surely. I was pleased you seem to have seen *The Necklace*—I was out of copies & the printer seems to be out of business: at all events he never replies to my requests for more. Otherwise I would have sent you one myself long ago. Incidentally, *The Necklace* drew forth three comments from reviewers:

in *The Listener*—‘pure Wallace Stevens.’

in *The Times Supplement*—‘sensibility without mind.’

in (I forget what)—‘it is impossible to be sure what this poet means.’

Then Kenner wrote of it for *Poetry*—hence McDowell, Obolensky hence the encouragement to continue. But I have gone on too long about myself. How are you? I hope you had a pleasant Christmas. Our *real* Christmas weather came only yesterday—snow filled the entire Ozleworth valley—Ozleworth Bottom as it's called, & the whole of space seemed renewed, spread out afresh. The eye is never hungry here & one's ears are always full of the brook without one's realising the fact. Brook Cottage adjoins Bridge Cottage & the brook flies through the garden of the latter out into the pastures. The brook seems to travel in time—it washes up, or one fishes out of it, old stoneware bottles, uncrazed [uncracked?], unbroken, and one can still use them. Only the other week it yielded up an elegant little wrought iron mud-scraper—straight from the 18th century. Englishmen once *made* things with the unerring instinct for beauty & compactness with which the birds build nests. I don't think I sentimentalize the matter.

I have re-read *Paterson V* many times & the depth & richness grows into fresh power. I hope the reviews attended properly to its advent.

All the best for the New Year to you both, & for the *Spectrum* article again many thanks.

As ever,
Charles

a generous encouraging piece: WCW's "Seeing Is Believing" is reprinted on pp. 47-48.

The Listener: In the issue for January 12, 1956, the anonymous writer of "The Listener's Book Chronicle" begins a review of CT's *The Necklace* as follows: "Mr. Charles Tomlinson is a decidedly curious case. His range is remarkably narrow, and both matter and manner are pure Wallace Stevens" (69).

The Times Supplement: CT here paraphrases an anonymous review entitled "Poems and Images" in *The Times Literary Supplement* for September 2, 1955. According to the reviewer, the poems of Wallace Stevens "generally tell us something about the world of the senses and the mind behind the senses. In *The Necklace* the mind seems to have been withdrawn and the result is a collection of hard, clearly seen, but essentially fragmentary mosaics" (506).

(*I forget what*): We have not identified the third review of *The Necklace* to which CT refers.

14. ALS-3

Aug. 24 [1959]

Dear Bill,

I shall be in New York in early November!—the International Institute of Education have chosen me & five others to tour the U.S. between then & the following spring. I wonder if you had a hand in this? If so, my very many thanks and deepest gratitude. I'm bringing my wife & daughter (aged circa 2 years) with me. It'll be a struggle but I can't leave 'em stranded in the middle of Gloucestershire & anyway what's the good of having a family if you don't have 'em with you! I do hope we shall be able to give you a call & say hello. We set off west before the winter & take refuge in California, or so we tell ourselves. I wonder how one gets to Rutherford from N. York?

Is your book on your mother out yet? I hope to see it soon. Good news: the *Oxford University Press* of ALL people have accepted *Seeing Is Believing*! Happened in the same week that I was summoned to New York. Incredible.

I write in haste & in hopes of seeing you and with best wishes for your health and to Mrs. Williams.

Very sincerely,
Charles

International Institute of Education: CT's first trip to the United States in 1959-60 was subsidized by a six-month travelling fellowship from the Institute of International Education; see the editors' foreword.

Oxford University Press: An enlarged, British edition of *Seeing Is Believing* was published by the Oxford University Press in 1960.

15. ALS-3

June 2. [1960]

Dear Bill,

Just a line to let you know that we got off free of the income tax authorities and arrived safely in a green fresh English spring, the weeds half way to the cottage windows and the mice enjoying my last year's lecture notes with a greater degree of relish than any shown by the students for whom they were destined. Christina Rossetti was green with mould, *Paterson* (I-V) was untouched, Melville—well, Melville was unspeakable (Gloucestershire cottages were not constructed to house paperbacks).

Oxford has not yet produced my English edition—Lord, how slow they are. But a small press has offered to bring out a little book of a dozen poems in the fall—all my three-ply Williamsesque. So it will be an annus mirabilis if nothing falls through.

They are threatening to push a superhighway through the Cotswolds, so I suppose our days of solitude are numbered. How tedious all this improvement is that improves nothing. One *cannot* drive an immense highway across these lovely intimacies of steep green hills and deep recessed valleys with their stone villages and beech woods. Our scale is too small to withstand it. I must say I do so *approve* of the present pace of our little local town with the cattle coming through the street, the battered cars, the immoveable gossiping groups and the slow, intimate absolutely unhurryable shops. I was down at Cheltenham recently & horrified to see the supermarkets coming in and the older English type shop going out. WHY do we borrow all that is dreariest from the U.S.? Ach. . .

Examinations are on us now & I must turn to marking.

Love to you both—your tin hand
ing a sheaf of mail—



stands before me ground-

Charles, Brenda and Justine

a small press: This volume was never published.

a superhighway: The M5, which connects Exeter with Birmingham, runs only a few miles west of Ozleworth Bottom.

your tin hand: See *Some Americans* 25-26, 36-38.

16. TLS-1

June 11, 1960

Dear Charles:

Your view of your dilapidated garden is entrancing if sad but not irretrievable after hard work—came just at the time I was heartbroken at the failure to take away the trash from our curb during our trash removal week. They did finally come just in the nick of time but the men did a very slovenly job of it. The only good work is left for our artists to do, such men as our Shakespears whatever they may believe in their intimate souls. The artist must be a good craftsman which none among the plumbers and carpenters it seems is today. Maybe we're too impatient, maybe it has always been the same.

I'm glad you found something on which to let yourself go in America even if you had to go back to the primitive Indians of the canyons to find it—Mesa Verde fascinated me too though I did not see the dances as you did.

After the tribulations with the passport guys you succeeded in convincing them of your right to go and come in the country without molestation. I am happy that they did not succeed in breaking you. What a way to treat the defenceless artist! Or is he as defenceless as they fondly believe?

It is reassuring to learn that the Cotswolds have not completely surrendered to the Supermarkets, your well-run little markets and stores I hope will have a resistance that will carry them through . . . and yet isn't [it?] precisely that Americanism that I am advocating in my verses. It disturbs me. But it has to be saluted in its inevitability: the artist with his careful precision will show us the way to make a go of it though our nerves may be shocked and bruised. We can never turn back the clock, the dominance of the iambic pentameter is lost to us forever. Whitman was a clumsy artist but he was the first to hold the bridgehead.

I have been commissioned to write the introduction to a portfolio of photographs celebrating the 100th anniversary of the publication of *Leaves of Grass*. If I am right in my calculations this will be an important book which will concern you as a poet deeply. I'll see that you get a copy as soon as it will be published later in the summer. We are strangely allied in our interest in the prosody which goes too [so?] deeply into the inevitable structure of our modern lives. You English

are as fundamentally affected as I am. It should bring us together not drive us apart and will if we succeed, you and I, in what we are attempting. You'll hear from me again later in the summer.

Meanwhile how had your wife Justine [Brenda] and your charming little daughter come through the 'return trip unscathed? The Easter Chickens weren't seasick were they?

Sincerely yours
Bill

Dear Charles: CT quotes part of this letter in *Some Americans* 37-38.

Mesa Verde: Located near Cortez in southwestern Colorado, Mesa Verde is the site of a spectacular group of ruined Anasazi cliff-dwellings. WCW visited them in July 1948; see his *Autobiography* (1967) 312.

the introduction to a portfolio of photographs: *The Illustrated Leaves of Grass*, ed. Howard Chapnick (New York: Madison Square Press), with WCW's introduction on pp. 9-13, was not published until 1971. An early draft of the final page of the introduction is reproduced in *A Recognizable Image: William Carlos Williams on Art and Artists*, ed. Bram Dykstra (New York: New Directions, 1978): 231-32; see also 267.

your wife Justine: WCW is confusing the name of CT's daughter, Justine, with that of his wife, Brenda.

the Easter Chickens: These decorations from WCW's Easter cake were given to Justine during CT's second visit to Rutherford in April 1960; see *Some Americans* 36.

17. ALS-3

Aug. 29. [1960]

Dear Bill,

I was delighted to get your Whitman piece—let me know, would you, when the book of photographs is out—I'd love to buy a copy. The article is forthright and a jewel of compactness.

There is one point that comes to my mind regarding this business of the American idiom & the variable foot. Why do you make the two so completely identical? Aren't you merely creating a restriction here? As far as I can see the variable foot & your three ply measure work just as well in Englishman's English as in American. Isn't the foot really based on a convenient way of breathing as much as anything else

(vide Olson's 'Projective Verse') and don't we English break our breaths and take our breaths in very much the same manner as you Americans? In short is there really such a thing as the 'American language' (your fourth paragraph)—surely, it's simply the American *idiom*? An illustration: when you saw one of my earlier pieces following your three ply lay-out you wrote to me a treasured letter complimenting me on my feel *for the American idiom*. I hesitated to say in response that, at that period, I had scarcely *heard* the American idiom spoken and that I was, in fact, writing Englishman's English, and that your idea of the variable foot applies as much to 'English' as to 'American'. If you tie your discovery to 'American', I feel you're limiting it unduly. In fact, I was reading Wordsworth the other night and it struck me that (with occasional changes to break the iambic recurrence) one could perfectly well rearrange the cadences into the variable foot because, despite the passage of over a century, the genius of the language is the same now and that the same genius is *there* in your American idiom. A further discovery came to me while translating Machado's *Poema de un Día* into—well—English-three-ply-measure-variable-foot: one can use the iambic by playing it across and into the movement of the variable foot, just as Alban Berg (say) will allow his twelve note serial to come to rest in or to pass through a key. I think our aim should be marriage between iambic & variable—or my aim at any rate—not divorce utter and total.

I've heard nothing of David McDowell since I left N.Y. Have things sorted themselves out, I wonder?

The summer here is filthy—endless rain. But I've been working. I'll let you see the Russian translations once they appear.

Let me know what you think of the above.

Love to you both & all the best to your son.

Charles

your Whitman piece: In August 1960, WCW mailed out fifty mimeographed copies of a two-page manifesto entitled "The American Idiom"; see Mariani, *William Carlos Williams* 758–59. The piece was published several times in 1960–61 and is reproduced on pp. 77–78.

Olson's 'Projective Verse': Charles Olson's influential manifesto for open-form poetry was first published in *Poetry New York*, No. 3 (1950). WCW incorporated part of it into Chapter 50 of his *Autobiography*.

Machado's Poema de un Día: See *Castilian Ilexes* 20–8; rpt. in CT's *Translations* 34–42. "Poem of a Day" and five others in the group employ the three-ply cadences

of WCW; see *Some Americans* 16–17. “Poem of a Day” first appeared in “Versions from Antonio Machado,” *The Hudson Review*, XV, 2 (Summer 1962): 202–9. It is reprinted on pp. 142–43.

Alban Berg: Austrian composer (1885–1935) and pioneer, along with Arnold Schoenberg and Anton Webern, of the ordered, 12-note series as the organizing principle of modern, atonal music. In “Ode to Arnold Schoenberg,” a poem written in three-ply cadences, CT celebrates “the twelve notes” and “the liberation of the dissonance” which they make possible (*A Peopled Landscape* 50–51).

Have things sorted themselves out: The publishing firm of McDowell, Obolensky went out of business in 1960.

the Russian translations: See Charles Tomlinson, *Versions from Fyodor Tyutchev, 1803–1873*, with an Introduction by Henry Gifford (London: Oxford University Press, 1960); partially reprinted in *Translations* 13–23. Four of the translations also appeared as “Versions from Fyodor Tyutchev” in *Spectrum*, IV, 1 (Winter 1960): 49–51.

your son: Probably William Eric Williams; see the letter of September 24, 1960.

18. TLS-1

Sept. 5/60

Dear Charles:

The address of the company who will publish the photographic portfolio is—Ziff-Davis Publishing Company, One Park Avenue, New York 16, N.Y. The book will be on the stands near the end of the month, I wish I could afford to send you a copy but I suspect it will be expensive. We’ll see, the introduction, of which I am inordinately proud, is by me—I wish you could have it. Maybe some library service in London could loan it to you, it would be a disappointment to me if you should miss it.

It may interest you that of the nearly 50 copies of the mimeographed copies of the brief essay I recently sent you only 3 have been acknowledged. I’m amazed. I scattered the names of those who were to receive them over the entire world.

The reaction of the critics to your poems in England was tolerant though the use of such a word as “suspicious” to your reception of your work in the U.S. is quite up to what is to be expected of them. New Directions will publish a book of 5 plays by me this winter—but I have already told you that. Love to your wife and small daughter.

Bill

a book of 5 plays: *Many Loves and Other Plays: The Collected Plays of William Carlos Williams* (Norfolk, Conn.: New Directions, 1961).

19. TLS-1

Sept. 24/60

Dear Charles:

There is no haste required in replying to this letter. It has to do with my son and his family who are just beginning to talk about next summer's vacation which they may spend at least a month of abroad in England of all places in that part of the country where you live.

This is just a feeler to sound you out to get your opinion whether or not you'd be inclined to encourage my son in such a wild idea. Could he find a maid of your acquaintance to take care of the children while they, his wife and self, go to France let's say for a week?

Take your time, think it over and talk to your wife about it and let me have your opinion. An alternate plan would be for them to go to Norway, my son has Norwegian relatives on his mother's side—Bill seems to want to look them over but the language difficulty is something to consider.

We thought at once of you and your wife as likely to give us the proper steers. Not that we would expect you to do more than put your finger on a likely woman who might be willing to take the children in for the week the children would be under her care. The 3 girls would be Emily, Erica and Elaine, 10, 6, and 3 in that order. My wife whom you know would have her daughter-in-law write to you if it ever comes to a decision.

My book of plays is approaching the time of publication and the portfolio of photographs ditto. By midwinter the poems will be getting ready to hit the ways—I suppose it should be weighs, especially in the old country. No matter.

This is a magnificent fall day but the U.N. makes it a questionable atmosphere to be alive in. We hope for the best.

Take care of yourselves and don't let my troubles disturb you.

Affectionately yours
Bill

Dear Tomlinsons—

Bill's got it all wrong. What our son is looking for is the possibility of finding a *family* who would *board* them all five! So that Daphne would not have any household cares—and *if* the plan worked out—and a responsible person would be able & willing to care for the 3 girls 11-7-4 for a week or two while their parents took a trip alone.—

As Bill says—don't let it be a burden to you—but if something could be worked out—it would be fine.

All the best to you all—

Floss

my son and his family: William Eric Williams (1914–1995); his wife, Daphne; and their daughters, Emily, Erica, and Elaine. WCW's poems for these granddaughters appeared under the title "3 Stances" in *Pictures from Brueghel and Other Poems*.

Norwegian relatives on his mother's side: The maternal grandmother of William Eric Williams, "Nannie" Herman, was born in Norway.

the poems: *Pictures from Brueghel and Other Poems*. This volume won the Pulitzer Prize in poetry in 1963, after WCW's death.

the U.N.: Events at the United Nations dominated the news in late September 1960, as the Security Council debated the political crisis in the newly independent Congo and world leaders gathered for a historic meeting of the General Assembly. Premier Nikita Khrushchev of the Soviet Union and Fidel Castro of Cuba attracted considerable attention when Khrushchev visited Castro at his hotel in Harlem, embraced him, and called him "heroic."

20. ALS-3

3 Dec. 1960

Dear Williamses,

Just in case your son is still considering England for his summer vacation, here is the result of one or two enquiries I've been making. It seems that finding somewhere for the children to stay without their parents is one of the greatest difficulties. I obtained 2 promising addresses: one was booked up for the next 2 years and anyway wouldn't take young children; the other is still vacant for next summer, but if your son does want to take advantage of it he should write *immediately* and book. Here is the address:

Mrs. D. C. Morris,
The Lea Rectory,
Nr. Ross-on-Wye,
Herefordshire. \

We haven't seen the place but it was recommended by a trusted friend who is the sister of Mrs. Morris. She takes three or four children from overseas during their parents' absence, and has three children of her own whose ages roughly correspond with those of your grandchildren.

Mrs. Morris would not, however, accommodate the whole family (i.e. with parents), but I think once they could settle a place to leave the children they would have no difficulty in finding any normal guest house or hotel wherever they wished to stay for the period when the whole family would be together.

As I said in my last, the only alternative to this is to rent a furnished house with a girl au pair to look after the children during their parents' absence. But this would leave the housework for your daughter-in-law, as servants in England are hard to find.

Let us know what they decide. We're eager to know whether they are coming. If we find anything else we will let you know.

Charles told O.U.P. to send you his Russian translations and hopes by this time they have arrived.

We are almost deluged (but not quite) with water to the very threshold. Rain and storms have been our almost daily fare since we returned to England in May—which is unusual even for this country.

We hope you are both in good health and will enjoy a most happy Christmas.

Every good wish,

Sincerely,
Brenda Tomlinson

21. TLS-1

Dec. 8/60

Dear Brenda:

Bill and Daphne haven't made up their minds what they will want to do next summer but I think it is more and more unlikely that they will be coming to England. So although I thank you for the trouble

that you have gone to I think you can be relieved of thinking more about it. It was very kind of you to put yourself out on such a doubtful commission.

Your news about the wet weather in that part of the country in which you [live?] cannot be true for England generally for we had a letter from about Cambridge speaking of sunny days and sparkling nights but weather is something you cannot count on in any part of the world. Certainly I know that it is winter and that is a season inimical to me. It is always unpleasant from December through March, the only thing I ever heard cheerful about it was my Mother-in-law's annual prediction for New Year's Day, January first now it's Spring!

It's been pleasant hearing from you, I wish the weather may improve for you as the season advances. Every one is beginning to get ready for Christmas—well, the less said about that the better. The season's greetings to the whole Tomlinson family. I haven't heard anything about Charles' translations from the Russians but give them time. Nothing is happening either for the moment about my own literary inventions. So it goes.

Best to you both from Flossie and me.

Love
Bill

Certainly I know: This sentence and the following one are quoted by CT in *Some Americans* 38.

22. TLS-1

Jan. 26, 1962

Dear Charles:

I have been ill for over a year and unable to communicate with you during that time. I picked up an old copy of the magazine *Poetry* and stumbled on a poem that you had written. It had a familiar ring, called to mind something over which we had been working together.

It's a theme familiar to me which we had not worked out by half. Go on developing the theme for there is much good grist still in it.

Hope you can make something out of this.

Affectionately
Bill

Dear Charles: CT quotes this letter in full in *Some Americans* 38. He also quotes it in part in his elegy on WCW, "Remembering Williams," reprinted on p. 154.

23. ALS-3

Feb. 12th [1962]

Dear Bill,

I was delighted to get your note, but so sorry to hear that you haven't been well during this past year. Your letter came very appositely—I had just been enjoying reading your collected plays, together with the volume of stories from *New Directions*. What splendid material there & how close you have come to the bare essentials of things!

I wonder if you have seen this large, slightly portentous but (all the same) very interesting volume, *The Continuity of American Poetry* by R. H. Pearce of Princeton? It has a long and valuable section on *Paterson I-IV* & another on the other poems. He sees the work clearly at his best but I suspect he over-reads here & there. Is it true to say that in *Paterson IV*, where one reads

Oh I could cry!
cry upon your young shoulder for what I know.
I feel so alone. . .

is it true, as Pearce says, that you are echoing the pious end of *Ash Wednesday*, 'And let my cry come unto Thee'? It had never struck me in this way. I should like to know—I'm reviewing the book. It goes all the way from the early Puritans to Williams of New Jersey (a late Puritan?).

I still labour away under your tutelage—there's a longish poem I have in February's *Poetry* about life in the Italian village where I once lived as seen through the eyes of a young communist poet there—he was a nice boy, but had had five years of only semi-employment. This sort of thing is a new venture for me—I've been trying to get people to *speak* in my poems but with their own voices. It's a hard task & I have nothing but gratitude for the way in which you have pointed out the possibilities of a solution.

But I've been going on too long about literature—I didn't tell you that we had a second baby girl last November, Juliet Virginia. It's been a happy progress so far, through all the worst weather. The first primroses are out now, very fresh and buttery yellow along the hedgerows. The hay-stacks stand three quarters eaten through like vast sliced off

loaves, marking off the approach to spring & the new grass. And the first catkins are out now but there's still February to be lived through. . .

I hope this finds you on the mend, Bill. Brenda joins me in sending our very best love to you both,

As ever,
Charles

volume of stories: The Farmers' Daughters: The Collected Stories of William Carlos Williams (Norfolk, Conn.: New Directions, 1961)

Pearce: In *The Continuity of American Poetry* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1961), Roy Harvey Pearce discusses *Paterson* on pages 111–30 and other poems by WCW on pages 335–48. CT refers specifically to a passage on page 127, in which Pearce says that the words quoted in CT's letter "echo, in quite unflinching vulgarity and viciousness, the pious end of 'Ash Wednesday': 'And let my cry come unto thee.'" CT's review of Pearce's book, which appeared in *Critical Quarterly*, 4, 3 (Autumn 1962): 276–79, is reprinted on pp. 79–85.

a longish poem: Written in the three-ply cadence, CT's "Up at La Serra" appeared in *Poetry*, 99, 5 (February 1962): 276–80, and in *A Peopled Landscape* 23–27. It is reprinted on pp. 149–52. The "young communist poet" was Paolo Bertolani.

a second baby girl: Juliet Virginia Tomlinson was born on November 29, 1961.

24. ALS-2

June 30th [1962]

My dear Bill,

Many many thanks for the kind gift of your magnificent volume. It is a splendid collection, rich with the resources of life & technique. I am at a loss to say which are my favorites, & to forgo the necessity of choosing among such abundance, let me merely say that the contained power of the longer poems & the exactness of the briefer ones provide an unforgettable lesson, & that they all demand that the poetry that we make after them shall be new & different by our acknowledging their presence. I return, among others, again & again to SONG: beauty is a shell / from the sea. . . . What concentration, what a keen edge & yet what flexibility! Thank you. Thank you so much. This makes the summer richer by its presence. A marvellous book: it will outlast, outblast the bomb, Bill.

News. We come to the States in August. A year at the University of New Mexico. Perhaps there will a chance of meeting on our way back thro' New York? We do hope so.

Again, a thousand thankyou's & love to you both.

Charles

SONG: CT quotes the opening lines of "Song" from WCW's *Pictures from Brueghel and Other Poems* 15. He quotes the poem in full in "Dr. Williams' Practice," *Encounter*, 29 (November 1967): 66-70.

the University of New Mexico: CT was visiting professor at the University of New Mexico in Albuquerque during the academic year 1962-63.

25. ALS-3

Aug 2 [1964]

Dear Mrs. Williams,

I have been meaning to write to you for some time to ask whether the editor of *The Review* ever sent to you the Black Mountain number which I edited and asked to have sent. If he didn't, I'll get on to him again—there are some interesting remarks on Bill's work by Robt. Creeley in an interview in this same number.

I have a small request to make . . . Another little mag. *Agenda* has asked will I do for them a Louis Zukofsky number. I wd. like very much, if I may, to reprint there the little essay on Zukofsky Bill wrote to be included in Z's "A". As I am doing the editing job gratis & as *Agenda* comes entirely out of the pocket of its editor (a schoolteacher) there would be no money in this, I fear—just half a dozen copies or so. If you'd rather I didn't include the essay under these circumstances, I shall quite understand your reluctance, so please don't hesitate to say no—tho', of course, a yes would be a pleasure.

We passed thro' N. York last summer, coming home from a year's visiting professorship to the Univ. of New Mex—I often thought of *Desert Music* when down in the south, passing thro' El Paso. Alas, there was too little time to drop in to see you. We do hope you are keeping well. We often wonder what happened to David McDowell after those unhappy events four or five years back—he has quite disappeared from our ken & writing to him has brought back no answer.

Brenda joins me in sending her very best wishes,

Most sincerely,
Charles Tomlinson

The Review: For the tenth number of *The Review* (January 1964), CT edited a forty-page section entitled "The Black Mountain Poets, an anthology." This gathering of work by Charles Olson, Robert Duncan, Denise Levertov, Ed Dorn, Gary Snyder, and others sought to introduce British readers to the work of contemporary American experimental poets connected with Black Mountain College in North Carolina and/or with the *Black Mountain Review*. In the course of CT's interview with the poet, fiction writer, and critic Robert Creeley (b. 1926), the two men discuss WCW's legacy to younger writers (25–27, 31).

Agenda: A London poetry magazine edited by William Cookson, *Agenda* published a Zukofsky number (III, 6) edited by CT in December 1964. WCW's essay "Zukofsky" appeared on pp. 1–4; it was reprinted from Zukofsky's *A 1–12* (Origin Press, 1959) 291–96.

Desert Music: WCW's poem "The Desert Music" (1951) commemorates his visit to El Paso, Texas, and Ciudad Juárez in November 1950. It later became the title poem of *The Desert Music and Other Poems* (1954), one of the first books by WCW that CT read.

David McDowell: The American editor and publisher David McDowell (1918–1985) was co-founder of McDowell, Obolensky, the publisher of CT's *Seeing Is Believing* (1958) and of several works by WCW. The company went out of business in April 1960, after a disagreement between its owners. McDowell later worked for Crown Publishers and Kraus Reprints.

26. ALS-2

Aug 7/64

Dear Charles Tomlinson—

Nice to hear from you.—I am just back from a 5 weeks tour of Scandinavia. Great country!

Of course you may use the essay on Zukofsky—no need to think about a fee.—

No—I did not get a copy of *The Review* that you edited. I'd like very much to see it.

I know how pressed one can get when travelling—meaning to look up people & just not doing it. I skipped several people in Oslo & Copenhagen that I should have seen—but—just couldn't squeeze it all in.

Bill & I often spoke of your visit here with Brenda & your charming little girl. Bill admired you and your poetry very much—and whatever came to us in the little mags about you.—

Do let me hear from you and if ever I can be of assistance please let me know.—

My best wishes to all of you

Sincerely—
Florence Williams

A Creator of Spaces

Hugh Kenner

What claims to be the “agreeable minor verse” of anonymous British culture—the sort of thing for instance that gets printed for filler in *The Listener*—traffics, as the patient inspector quickly discovers, in void gestures of rumination over themes that, until the ruminative process seized on them, barely existed as themes. A thousand unpretentious poems are amplified samples of the background noise that continually accompanies the chatter of our mental processes, insistent, like all background noise, when the talking machine pauses for a moment: bits of commonplace assimilation of one’s environment, isolated and promoted as “poetic” because not crassly practical. This random example comes from *The Listener* for October 13, 1955 (elisions mine):

Hesitate with letters, there by the pillar-box,
Holding the gesture. Listen: . . .
. . . "It is the hour
Of—" But of what? . . .
. . . You watch the wind
Tumble the smoke, lift half the blossom of a tree,
Twitching away April like a table-cloth.
Sparrows occur. Wheels twinkle. Thin and high,
High and continuing high like a violin,
A vapour trail describes an enormous flower,
Grown out, nudging the blue, into absolute silence. . .

This has a delectable post-Thermidor complacency. Tennyson need no longer be guillotined every Wednesday; poetry has outlived the phase of manifestoes and metrical Schrecklichkeit and can resume its normal business of distracting the middle classes. It is no longer quite the *same* poetry of course; even the incorruptible pentameter admits numerous hypermetric syllables, and it is licit for vapor-trails, flowers

and violins to collapse into a simultaneous sensation. "Sparrows occur" is a very knowing bit of synthetic casualness, decidedly post-Auden. The revolution is consummated, Rupert Brooke is old hat, and we moderns (not of course glass-and-chrome moderns, but at any rate Eden's and Eisenhower's parishioners, not Bonar Law's) have our contemporary *poésie d'ameublement*. Civilization resumes its course. Time heals all things, even the schisms promoted by Vorticism. Mr. Wyndham Lewis gets a friendly nod now and then. And so on.

Under these circumstances the bored cisatlantic reader would have some excuse for supposing that Mr. Charles Tomlinson, with his apparatus of flutes, seashores and sunsets, was a member in good standing of the BBC party. Let the reader be undeceived; there could be no more convincing instance of the infallibility of the guardians of British public taste in distinguishing between the genuine and the specious than their unanimous condescension toward Mr. Tomlinson. A glance at the pages of *The Necklace* sufficed to persuade them that *all was not well*. Quite so: these mere fifteen poems constitute just such a flawlessly alert achievement in the joining of words, unassisted by rhetoric of form or empathy of theme, as the counter-Bohemian arbiters of the Queen's realm, though they go through the motions of prizing such criteria, must make it their business to proscribe.

. . . But how shall one say so?—

The fact being, that when the truth is not good enough
We exaggerate. Proportions

Matter. It is difficult to get them right.

There must be nothing

Superfluous, nothing which is not elegant

And nothing which is if it is merely that. . . .

This extract—both what it says and the quality of writing it typifies—will serve to illustrate Mr. Tomlinson's minimum virtue, not talking too much while not indulging in a mummery of laconism, epigrams, meaningful glances, knowing understatements. He functions, at his mildest, like a flute-player oblivious to listeners, in a tacit dialogue with his art, getting a short passage exactly right. When this intentness on the contours of a perception extends itself, we have such a poem as *Observation of Facts*, which needs to be quoted intact:

Facts have no eyes. One must

Surprise them, as one surprises a tree

By regarding its (shall I say?)
Facets of copiousness.

The tree stands.

The house encloses.

The room flowers.

These are fact stripped of imagination:
Their relation is mutual.

A dryad is a sort of chintz curtain
Between myself and a tree.
The tree stands: or does not stand:
As I draw, or remove the curtain.

The house encloses: or fails to signify
As being bodied over against one,
As something one has to do with.

The room flowers once one has introduced
Mental fibre beneath its elegance,
A rough pot or two, outweighing
The persistence of frippery
In lampshades or wallpaper.

Style speaks what was seen,
Or it conceals the observation
Behind the observer: a voice
Wearing a ruff.

These facets of copiousness which I proposed
Exist, do so when we have silenced ourselves.

This is elegant only in the sense in which a mathematician so praises a demonstration, or a physicist an experiment; its elegance denotes not a patent-leather glaze over a quotidian shoe, but the co-presence of the fewest possible components functioning with minimum waste. *Observation of Facts* isn't a surface but an action compact of surprises. The leap from "fact stripped of imagination" to "A dryad is a sort of chintz curtain" would have delighted Aristotle; and how finely weighed, in the vicinity of "dryad" and "curtain," is that "stripped"! And then we discover that we have paused too soon:

A dryad is a sort of chintz curtain
Between myself and a tree.

—only then and there, not always. Yet we need the pause, the half-joke of the first line in isolation. The line-ending *functions*; without it, without the shift of perspective it induces, the sentence would be merely fanciful. Dr. Williams once described Marianne Moore's *Marriage* as "an anthology of transit"; Mr. Tomlinson, though his affinities are rather with Miss Moore than with, say, Keats, doesn't display the copiousness of an anthology; he isn't culling a prickly heap of experiences. Nor is his world a stripped world; he doesn't arrive at it by subtraction, he builds from nothing; his world is a blank which he proceeds to furnish. He isn't a connoisseur of austerities, cultivating

an Olympian *apatheia*

In the presence of selected perceptions:

or inviting us to share an effete predilection for items that dangle before the appreciative gaze, in Calderesque whimsicality. Rather the ideal reader assists at an athletic act of creation, where subtle and exact relationships, like the ones that occupy an oriental geomancer, are not being found but step by step established. Yet this creator of spaces is no Mondrian; he is blessedly free of the revolutionary itch.

This comes out clearly in Mr. Tomlinson's third category of poems, the ones where he isn't explicitly purifying thought processes but simply building: as in *Nine Variations in a Chinese Winter Setting*. First we have the blank expectations aroused by the title; then we have, by fiat,

I

Warm flute on the cold snow
Lays amber in sound.

or a little later, with more aplomb than preciosity,

III

The sage beneath the waterfall
Numbers the blessings of a flute.
Water lets down
Exploding silk.

or later still, more intricate,

V

Pine-scent
In snow-clearness
Is not more exactly counterpoised

Than the creak of trodden snow
Against a flute.

One is constantly aware of what these poems are not; they have in that respect an odd affinity with Augustan satire, which works by just evading the regnant clichés. Mr. Tomlinson's flutes, for instance, manage not to be drawn into the convention of literary still-life; they are neither bourgeois stage-props whimsically disposed, like the guitars of the early cubist collages, nor are they a refined equivalent. Picasso might have employed the flute instead of the guitar if the matrix of his Romantic satire had been that of, say, Proust instead of Pécuchet; the flute would still have retained its connections with a certain social world, though a high bohemia instead of a sidewalk cafe. Mr. Tomlinson's flute on the cold snow does nothing of the kind; it posits a quality of music and so a quality of perception, and no more. The word "Chinese" in his title is merely part of the machinery for detaching the flute and the snow from Anglo-Saxon clichés; the poem isn't transferred into the allied cliché-world of chinoiserie.

Which explains in turn why this author's work differs so radically from the staple minor British verse to which his stock of images, his persistent synaesthesia, his preoccupation with moments of tranced half-attention would seem at first glance to ally him.

It is neither between three and four
Nor is it the time for lamps:
It is afternoon—interminably.

—one wouldn't be *very* surprised to come across those lines in a patch of versified filler. The difference is that Mr. Tomlinson compels a wholly different kind of attention from the reader: so much so that it is grossly wrong to speak of him as employing devices, or keeping images in stock, or being preoccupied with anything the reader is likely to remember from his own mental life. The lines just quoted aren't a situation from which the poem starts, a circumstance in which its meditations are carried on, but a point of perception through which it passes after it has been in movement for all of four lines. Which amounts to saying that Mr. Tomlinson, building up his austere little universes before our eyes, does something altogether different from the man who, pausing in the act of mailing a letter, notes the commonplace novelities of the sensual world ("Sparrows occur. Wheels twinkle.") and so flatters a reader who has undergone such moments of arrest himself.

He also does something very different from the Wallace Stevens who ravel[s] out into cumbersome frivolities, though his path has obviously intersected that of the Stevens of *Thirteen Ways of Looking at a Blackbird*. Even there, Stevens' unpeopled landscapes imply an ache, an absence of the familiar *point d'appui*, whereas Mr. Tomlinson's "facets of copiousness" ignore the inhabitant precisely because they "exist. . . when we have silenced ourselves." This explains why he has none of Stevens' itch for the grand style, nor the consequent Stevens delight in jokes attendant on the grand style gesturing in a void

(Yet that things go round and again go round
Has rather a classical sound.)

His mind isn't on styles but on the blank paper and the prospects of calligraphy.

It is hard to imagine where Mr. Tomlinson is going next; the chief defect of his fifteen poems is their air of having exhausted their method in a bare few hundred words. At any rate *The Necklace* deserves circulation in this country. It is neither applied art nor last season's dishwater. It belongs in the small category of poetic acts which can preserve us from being abused by the complacent rhetoric of the genteel inconspicuous.

A Creator of Spaces: Kenner is reviewing CT's *The Necklace* (Eynsham, Oxfordshire: Fantasy Press, 1955).

The Listener: Kenner abridges the first stanza of "Unaccountable Happiness," published in *The Listener* for October 13, 1955, p. 605, by the English poet, biographer, and glass engraver Laurence Whistler (b. 1912).

post-Thermidor: Kenner likens the modernist revolution in poetry of 1912–17 to the French Revolution of 1789–94, and the English Poet Laureate Alfred, Lord Tennyson (1809–1892) to a French aristocrat of the old order. "Thermidor" was the eleventh month in the French Republican calendar (July 19 to August 18).

Schrecklichkeit: German, "horror."

post-Auden: The work of the English poet and essayist W. H. Auden (1907–1973) is distinguished by striking variations in tone and diction, from the formal and traditional to the colloquial and contemporary.

Rupert Brooke: The English poet Rupert Brooke (1887–1915) was a leading member of the Georgian group of lyrical and pastoral poets, whose work appeared in a series of anthologies published between 1912 and 1922. Brooke and the other Georgians wrote in traditional metric and stanzaic forms.

Eden's: Anthony Eden (1897–1977) was the Prime Minister of Great Britain from 1955 to 1957.

Eisenhower's: Dwight David Eisenhower (1890–1969) was the President of the United States from 1953 to 1961.

Bonar Law's: Andrew Bonar Law (1858–1923) was the Prime Minister of Great Britain from 1922 to 1923.

poésie d'ameublement: French, "decorative poetry."

Vorticism: Between 1914 and 1917, Vorticism, an avant-garde movement in English art and literature, proclaimed an aesthetic of energetic, non-representational forms. Vorticist polemics were intentionally confrontational and abrasive.

Wyndham Lewis: The English artist and writer Wyndham Lewis (1882–1957) was a leader of the Vorticist movement.

the BBC party: *The Listener* is a publication of the British Broadcasting Company.

But how shall one say so?: These lines come from CT's "The Art of Poetry"; rpt. *Collected Poems* 10–11.

Observation of Facts: This poem is reprinted in CT's *Collected Poems* 11–12.

Dr. Williams: In "Marianne Moore," a 1925 review of *Observations* by the American poet, translator, and essayist Marianne Moore (1887–1972), WCW describes her poem "Marriage" as "an anthology of transit. It is a pleasure that can be held firm only by moving rapidly from one thing to the next" (*Selected Essays* 123).

an Olympian apathein: These lines come from Ezra Pound's *Hugh Selwyn Mauberley* (1920). They describe the refined, hedonistic impressionism of an aesthete. *Apathein* is the Stoic virtue of apathy—indifference to or detachment from the vicissitudes of life.

Calderesque: The American sculptor and painter Alexander Calder (1898–1976) is best known for his invention, around 1931–32, of the hanging mobile, a construction of painted metal shapes suspended from fine wires or cords and moved by circumjacent air currents.

Mondrian: The Dutch painter Piet Mondrian (1872–1944) is best known for his abstract, rigorously geometric compositions, in which rectangles oriented on horizontal and vertical axes are colored in a palette of red, blue, yellow, black, white, and gray. The rationale of this style lay in a Theosophical mysticism that Mondrian espoused with doctrinaire intensity.

Nine Variations: This poem is reprinted in CT's *Collected Poems* 3–4.

Picasso: Around 1912 the Spanish artist Pablo Picasso (1881–1973) began to employ an iconography of guitars and other musical instruments in the paintings, collages, and three-dimensional constructions of his synthetic-cubist period.

Proust: In *A la recherche du temps perdu* (1913–22), the French novelist and essayist Marcel Proust (1871–1922) assesses the artistic and musical tastes of sophisticated French society in the late nineteenth century.

Pécuchet: One of the main characters in *Bouvard et Pécuchet* (1881) by the French novelist Gustave Flaubert (1821–1880), Pécuchet is a retired copy clerk who com-

piles digests of received ideas in all major fields of knowledge, only to find that none of his summaries is of practical use. Through Bouvard and Pécuchet, Flaubert satirizes the simplistic empiricism and materialism of nineteenth-century bourgeois society.

It is neither: These lines come from CT's "Eight Observations on the Nature of Eternity"; rpt. *Collected Poems* 5.

Stevens: "Thirteen Ways of Looking at a Blackbird" (1917) by the American poet Wallace Stevens (1879–1955) is a "cubist" exercise in considering a subject from multiple points of view. "Yet that things go round . . ." are the last lines of Stevens's 1934 poem, "The Pleasures of Merely Circulating."

point d'appui: French, "fulcrum, point of purchase."

Passages from Letters to William Carlos Williams

Hugh Kenner

1. TLS-1

November 4, 1957

Dave [McDowell] has Charles Tomlinson's manuscript book of poems [*Seeing Is Believing*]. That lad needs to be published in the U.S., in book form (he's been hitting the magazines regularly, not always with his best stuff.) Do you suppose there's any point in your giving Dave a nudge, or would that generate resistance? You know him better than I. The British won't publish Tomlinson at all. His one pamphlet of poems [*The Necklace*] was privately printed, I believe at his expense, and hardly sold. I know the reviews in England were shocking. He occupies some point inside a triangle with you, Marianne [Moore], and [Wallace] Stevens at the vertices, and this triangle isn't staked on English soil.

2. TLS-2

December 16, 1957

Did you see in the new SPECTRUM—the one with your Sappho Ode—the poem by Charlie Tomlinson, "Letter to Dr. Williams," on the page following your poem? The best thing that can be done for Anglo-American letters, I think, is to bring all pressure on Dave to bring out Charlie's book of which he has the ms. The guy is simply not going to be published in England, and in the U.S., while he's appeared

in several mags, he needs the impact of a volume to distinguish him from the people who in any given 10 years carve three cherrystones.

3. TLS-2

July 9, 1958

And I hope Dave sent you a copy of Tomlinson's very handsome book. I think the world of that lad Tomlinson. I saw him in England this spring, and have subsequently at his request sent him all your collected earlier and later poems (he had only selections). Almost impossible to get American books in England by normal means.

4. TLS-3

July 15, 1958

Glad you like Charlie's book [*Seeing Is Believing*]. I've had the poems around, in ms. and in proof, for 6 months, and still they grow on me. In case you haven't written him, I shall quote to him what you wrote me. One of the surest tokens of his soundness is that he is, as anyone can see, intensely English in idiom and sensibility, yet in England they don't know WHAT to make of him. Total bewilderment. You should see some of the letters he had from British publishers, rejecting the book in honest puzzlement. But in America a college girl named Martha Murphy working in Dave's office can get farther than the most cultured British reviewers and write in half an hour a perfectly adequate jacket blurb (front flap of cover). Not that Martha is any critical genius, but she inhabits a milieu in which perception of what Charlie is up to comes more easily.

5. TLS-1

September 8, 1959

Knowing how highly you regard Tomlinson's book, I make bold to ask whether you feel you have time to do a short review of it for us. No formal treatment needed: just a compendium of things you want to say on the subject. I'm reviewing it myself for *Poetry* ["Next Year's Words"] and shouldn't give the appearance of a Tomlinson lobby by plugging it in yet another magazine, and needless to say a statement from you on this new development in international poetics would come with peculiar authority.

6. TLS-1

July 2, 1959

Charles Tomlinson has been nominated for a 6 months' travel scholarship which if he gets it will enable him to visit the United States for 6 months. This, given his great 'capacity for development, would be the best possible thing for his poetry. Not only would it free him from teaching for 6 months, but it would help him know the American world and language at first hand.

Henry Rago [the editor of *Poetry*] nominated him, and I am sending along a very strong recommendation on an official form, but I think a note from you, independently, would be helpful.

7. TLS-1

January 15, 1960

Charles and Brenda Tomlinson are in Santa Barbara now. Their visit here has three more weeks to run, the first week having had the heart punched out of it by an Asiatic flu virus which laid Brenda low for five days. I'm glad they got to see you. Charles had a wonderful visit with you, he tells me. He has showed me some new poems which keep up the standard. Your 3-ply meter glows in his hands. And what is awe-inspiring, they tell me you are still serenely writing poems.

Seeing Is Believing

William Carlos Williams

The English will not or at least do not accept one of their best younger poets, Charles Tomlinson, because he writes with many characteristics of an American. Not superficial characteristics but the measured strokes dictated by a new world. That is not cricket to an Englishman, to imitate the Yankees. Have they not been carefully instructed during the past 6 generations that the course of literary training lies in the direction of France and the classics with the whole tradition *Beowulf* through Chaucer to T. S. Eliot to guide them? Now comes a disturbing note found among the accepted voices of Oxford and Cambridge to join the newer rebels and swell the unholy rout. The worst is that in this young poet Tomlinson, a breach in the technical order of the measure, the sacred construction of the poetic phrase, is sanctioned, and everyone knows that once that has occurred the whole dike against barbarity, a finger through it, must collapse.

So the present day brood of British critics appear to think. It is not an overt rebellion. Tomlinson is a very modest man. He is a mere poet going his own way convinced that something has been done to the poetic phrase that is valid. An Englishman, if he is the guardian of his country's scholarship through an enviable tradition, cannot avoid the issue but with the grim determination of the breed must follow where his betters have led him. If scholarship has led him astray he must re-examine his sources and finding an error correct it.

This, Tomlinson, working alone and quietly in his Gloucestershire stone cottage among the trees and country homes in a world tumbling about his ears out of the day's news, has taken in hand as a poet to interpret to his countrymen as he is able. They will, as I say, have nothing of it. But his poems are artificially built. They have much of the natural charm of the Georgians, a pastoral surface. Englishmen

will be certain to like them once they get over their first suspicions and take them gladly to their hearts. Speed the day.

For there is in such a well made and beautiful poem as Tomlinson's *The Atlantic* such a measure as this:

Launched into an opposing wind, hangs
 Grappled beneath the onrush,
 And there, lifts, curling in spume,
 Unlocks, drops from that hold
 Over and shoreward. etc.

—this, containing from the first, for it is the first poem in his new book *Seeing Is Believing*, the essential difference between this poet's work and that of all other English poets writing. He has escaped finally from the staid procession of the iambic pentameter—while cleaving to the rules of English composition as taught in the schools about him; has divided his line according to a new measure learned, perhaps, from the new world. It gives a refreshing rustle or seething to the words which bespeak the entrance of a new life.

This is an entrancing book by the sheer sound of it when read aloud. Many modern Americans I know could learn much from its pages in the conduct of their measure which is often without invention of any sort. You can't be a good poet by whipping up a froth over a lady's behavior in bed or out of it—or a man's either. We forget that *this* is the concern of writing, writing—and you can't get it but by originality in the measures, the lines and how they disport themselves.

Variant on a Scrap of Conversation has the woody feeling I think a writer must maintain, before he goes into his damned metaphysics. *Northern Spring* is a beauty, no bad habits to be learned there by the student. But *Meditation on John Constable* gives a depth of feeling toward the English which poor Lawrence might have envied without going to his hysterical excesses. You don't have to go to the depressed areas to learn how to WRITE. *On the Hall at Stowey* is a fine poem which should be proclaimed throughout England if it had any chance to be heard above words stemming from St. Louis, U.S.A., an exhausted measure, an influence now fortunately on the wane from the English past which it persists in imitating. This is serious. For the measure of the present and the future is involved: are we monkeys or men?

words stemming from St. Louis, U.S.A.: T. S. Eliot was born and raised in St. Louis, Missouri. WCW may be alluding to Eliot's 1953 address on "American Literature and the American Language"; see p. 75.

Measure—A Loosely Assembled Essay on Poetic Measure

William Carlos Williams

1. Champion, in addition to his abilities as a poet, was a composer of songs which charmed his age. I was reminded of this this morning when I heard a nameless bird singing, Ah chee, ah chee! Chee, chee, chee!
2. Chapman's genius came upon him when he was a young man struggling with a Greek hexameter, with which he was not thoroughly familiar, striving at first to translate into English the world's most celebrated poem: To render into his own language such a poem to be anything resembling the original measure, would be a colossal achievement . . .
3. And Shakespeare the dramatic (and lyrical) poet finding himself anchored in the iambic pentameter which he never broke yet in one drunken passage wrestled as if he wanted to be free of it.
4. A Baltimore poet, Sidney Lanier, Professor of English at Johns Hopkins, wrote in 1868 a treatise on prosody, *The Science of English Poetry*. A few years ago, at a reading in Brown University, I came to know a charming professor of English who told me of Lanier's essay, asking me if I had ever read it. I hadn't. He recommended that I should. I was disappointed, but it gave an opportunity to introduce something that turned out to be important in a discussion on measure.
5. The American Idiom, our spoken language, is not, of course, a uniform speech—but just as the various Greek dialects of the ancient world it shows enough similarity to the established forms to be taken, for a beginning, in its turn as a certain sort of English, a base from which to vary.

6. The Variable Foot carries this thesis to its logical conclusion—or develops it and expands it because of the possible interest of living poets, as shown in their poems, to have or to search to have a relation to the thoughts and speech of a living world, their own, in which they are contained like algae in the sea bathed by the same light that penetrates all the gardens we know.
-

1. Campion

From the scorn implicit in the writing of many scholars, see E. Tn in the *Encyclopedia Britannica*, Campion's 16th Century intention, and accomplishment, was merely to write rhymeless lyrical poems. It is to be noted that he was a song writer before he was a poet, a musician first and last. He was a great controversialist, even belligerent about his theories of musical composition, so convinced in his mind as to take his practice in the art carelessly, offhand on occasion—fortunately for students of what he did with his texts.

"Of course I will write lyrics without rhymes. Didn't the Greeks, the greatest song writers that ever existed, write rhymelessly?" He was popularly successful everywhere—though he did not stick to his rule, or preference, but on the contrary is best known for his rhymed "airs." The Commonwealth put an end to all that, a generation of hymn singers, just when the musical mode he practiced was at its height and had become, in fact, briefly the fashion in the greatest period in British literary history. The influence of the Greeks ended really just when his practice of musical innovations was beginning.

When Milton, a younger contemporary among Campion's successors, had written his Masque, *Comus*, shortly after his *Lycidas*, it was much after the mode of the Greek experimenters—with abundant distortions in the order within the sentences, inversions of the phrase which make them difficult to read. Sometimes these in fact, as indeed in the *Paradise Lost*, are horrible to behold. Campion knew better than that, to deform the language for his private purposes—pomposity entirely foreign to him. He was a singer and loved his lilting airs. But the ancient inflections of the language puzzled him: how to retain them when he felt the need of retaining them? How to bring over the old inflected into the modern measures? He was a pragmatist in his age. The Greek sense of elapsed time rather than our crude stresses possessed him practically. He had a job to do, he couldn't be fussing

over where the measure was to take him. The present hogging line, when the pinch came, was no longer tenable—without altering the grammatical order, inversions of the phrase which to say the best for them were awkward.

He was finally held to the accented line, but not without important variations. He was a scholar—a physician, by the way, who practiced medicine in London for many years. To be a rhymer was vulgar in his ears: he detested all quacks. He was a gentleman poet, like Bridges, in fact more or less Left Bank: an unconformist—like many of the prominent figures of his age, and it is said nearly lost his head because of it. No rhyme. There was a more valuable element. The measure with and by which the line is to be divided came near triumphing in him if he could have been bothered.

It was a deeply disturbed group of confident men who made up the literary London of those days of the century in which Campion lived. The poets were prominent among them. They had not yet come to an agreement as to how the classics were to be pronounced when they were spoken aloud, much less when they were translated and rendered into an equivalent English. The popular measure for dramatic poetry was the iambic pentameter—some at times must have grown restless under the implied restriction. Campion seems to have been one of those driven by his musician's ear to seek a greater freedom in the composition of his songs.

He was a theorist influenced by the classic mode whenever he wanted to give voice to one of the popular "airs" among his fellows. He never questioned what came into his head to do. A poet and musician, he wrote mainly as a pastime. When he published, it was among such distinguished friends as he associated with in the fashion of his day.

They did not all share his theories of musical composition as can be gathered from the title of one early book of his, *A New Way of Writing the Counterpart for a Fourpart Song*. He was partial to unrhymed verse for which he was roundly abused by his enemies in the craft; this partiality was an effect of the classic measures where no rhymes were used until centuries later when even in the Latin language a corrupt usage began to be adopted. Campion's turning away from rhyme is shown in the following air from Book 4:

Rose-cheeked *Laura*, come
Sing thou smoothly with thy beawties
Silent music, either other
Sweetly gracing.

Lovely formes do flowe
 From concent divinely framed;
 Heav'n is musick, and thy beawties
 Birth is heavenly.
 These dull notes we sing
 Discords neede for helps to grace them;
 Only beawty purely loving
 Knowes no discord,
 But still mooves delight
 Like clear springs renu'd by flowing,
 Ever perfect, ever in them-
 selves eternall.

But the thing characteristic of him is his habit of taking liberties with his use of the measure which came also from basic classic precedents, to be noted later, and also from the direct musical necessities, as they presented themselves, of the songs which caused them to flow about the words in unconventional ways. In that his success made him popular in his world. He was successful, a man recognized in his own time. His songs were well known to well known tunes among such names as Sir Philip Sidney, Ed. Spenser, Hugh Holland, Ben Jonson, Michael Drayton, George Chapman, John Marston, William Shakespeare.

A 19th century bibliographer, Percival Vivian writes "Campion's measures are not only curious, but sometimes perplexing, and occasionally they almost baffle analysis. We meet subtle changes in the midst of a song. . ."—and then goes on to analysis according to the accepted canons of prosody.

Campion's curious scansion appears when we attempt to follow some famous song, or "aire," which is given in most of the anthologies because of its extreme beauty: for instance the delicate and imaginative song, "Hark, all you ladies that do sleep." I do not know that the most skillful reader would make much of this poem if set to read it at first glance. (With this a present-day reader might contrast the dilemma of someone presented with a poem by Hopkins, say the *Wreck of the Deutschland*, and without instruction asked to read it)—

Hark, all you ladies that do sleep!
 The fairy-queen Prosperina
 Bids you wake and pity them that weep
 You may do in the dark
 What the day doth forbid;
 Fear not the dogs that bark,
 Night will have all hid.

Here we have—or have we?—straightforward iambs. It is just possible to struggle along with a measure consonant with that as far as the fourth line:

You may do in the dark

—but in the fifth it is totally impossible.

What the day doth forbid

is clearly either dactylic or anapestic. Line six again can be accepted as iambic—

Fear not the dogs that bark

but the seventh line can surely be an Adonic (- - -), the line of the Latin Sapphic!—

By now we see what a mess we get into if we think to deal with this according to the rigid line of the older prosody as it was before Campion ignored their rule in favor of his subtler ear.

The scholiasts were shocked and turned on him with all their venom; his arrangements were not accepted by the cognoscenti of his time though everyone in his set sang his songs. His idiom was to prove more acceptable than theirs, until a quarter century later when, after Campion's instinctive adjustments to accommodate himself to a new measure more in accord with the quantitative values of Greek, his age proved not up to it and though some had their antennae swaying to the new, most poets practising in the age were violently opposed. Campion's views were unpopular.

His tentative school stood to be entirely wiped out under the ideas of the Reformation which was soon to break over his world. Milton, caught in the overthrow, with his early classic best was caught in the same classic tide. In fact, after Campion, the trend of the world relating to the writing of the poetic foot became fixed in the accentual mold in English—with far reaching results: the final submersion of the quantitative measure and the triumphant assertion of stress as the measure of choice, the dominant measure today.

Campion was the true pioneer. So-called "free verse," popularized in our time through Walt Whitman who had no idea of its basic significance, has gradually developed to be the measure under which we are to achieve today's triumphs.

2. Chapman

Chapman lived in the same London which nourished Campion and much the same moods and ideas must have influenced him in his generation toward the completion of his verse ideas. They all knew the Greek as one of their more unschooled contemporaries, a man known to his friends as Will, did not.

When he was a young man Chapman had got some reputation for himself by beginning to translate the *Iliad* into English. He did the first seven books of it, a young man, and the success he had, not knowing the Greek language very well, astonished him.

The age he lived in nourished him. He was in the midst of scholars to whom Greek was second nature, but being a mere poet with all a poet's effrontery and desire to make himself out to know more than he did know, he must have thought it was much to his credit to have a reputation for Greek—much as poets will seek to be known today—and to pretend to know more than he did.

After a while, finding the job of working with a quantitative meter a tough one, more than he had bargained for and not so popular as he had at first thought, he gave up the attempt and when he came to translating the second work, the *Odyssey*, dropped the more difficult measure and turned to the more popular measure at the time, the iambic pentameter, to our everlasting loss.

For it has turned out that Chapman, writing out of his ignorance of Greek and quantitative verse, had done more than he bargained for or well knew. At least he did not know its significance in the development of a simply usable verse.

His measure is subtler than he had any idea of. The one aware intelligence among the lot of them was a musician, Campion, who laid no store by his verse at all, but tossed it off carelessly in the course of putting down his notes. As Chapman wrote his magnificent Greek translations in the mistaken idea that they were such, having no interest in the quasi-measure that came through in spite of all he could do, so Campion more consciously (before he gave up trying) did the modern measure a great service.

In all iambs in worthy hands there lurks a triple beat that transforms them into anapests when they are read with a subtle understanding of their true nature. The understanding poet can take advantage of this when it suits his purposes. Chapman in his translation of the *Iliad* (not the *Odyssey*) was caught by this indecision among the

accents, which has fascinated all poets that have come after him. It has made for variation in the measure which hides from the ear, giving the beat of the heart itself, which is complex and never merely plodding, as the man himself in his deeper nature.

If you are to count this other beat, which Chapman, when he was young seemed to feel predominantly, it led to the very sea beat of the *Iliad* itself. He could not acknowledge that rule and go on with that hidden measure, no more than could the later Shakespeare in the beat of his more subtle blank verse, where it breaks with the heroic declamatory mode of his earlier plays and seeks relief in a more conversational tone.

Chapman had a model on the page before him, he was doing a translation which according to his own statement had best be handled as a "fourteener." It led him a merry dance to his everlasting distinction, but it appears to have wearied him. He quit the pace as he grew older. It may be that he never fully realized what he had been doing.

You can count the lines either way if you are so inclined, by the regularity of the metronome, or the way the idiom that governs your speech without inversions of the phrase leads you. The clash between the two leads the mind to a choice which in certain ages is difficult to make.

It is to be noted that at this time, the late 16th century, the English were just approaching the printing of poetry on the page. For convenience a shorter line, the pentameter, instead of the more unwieldy "fourteener," was pressing poets for recognition. Chapman, nostalgic, remembering the old, was caught a young man, before it could be lost. He had to wrestle with the form, an unpopular form at the moment, slightly out of date, to bring it back to life.

Between this clumsy heptameter and the more popular pentameter he waged such a battle—of survival—that he outdid himself in metrical invention, luckily for us, an invention that still shows in the uncertainty of his measure until the ear is intrigued, no one can tell where the beat will lie. The interest comes from the uncertainty. Have we to deal with an iambic line or a line so struck with anapests, marked by spondees, that we are constantly left up in the air? Try it in Allardyce Nicoll's modern text and you, the reader, will still feel the uncertainty which has kept this poem alive through the ages.

The lance betwixt his ear and cheek ran in, and drove the mind
Of both those bitter fortunes out.

The feeling, even in this brief fragment, is far from iambic to our ears as we have been taught to hear it.

This said, the chamber-maid that held the Ewre and Basin by,
He had power water on his hands, when, looking to the sky,
He took the bowle, did sacrifice, and thus implor'd:

But to get the full of his achievement we have to take a longer passage. It is a new measure which must have carried him exhilarated, blindly, in its arms through the *Iliad*, as all discoveries carry a man into a new world, for in the *Odyssey* which he undertook next he had lost it. He went back on the new measure and for some unknown reason never returned to it. The vigor of statement he had fallen upon, coming as if by the intervention of a god, he was never to recapture—

Then rushed he on, and in his eye had heavenly Polydore
Old Priam's sonne, whom last of all his fruitful Princess bore,
And for his youth (being dear to him) the king forbade to fight.
Yet (not by inexperience'd blood, to show how exquisite
He was of foote, for which of all the fiftie sonnes he held,
The special name) he flew before the first heate of the field,
Even till he flew out of breath and soul—which, through the back, the lance
Of swift Achilles put in ayre, and did the head advance
Out at his navill. On his knee the poore Prince fell,
And gathered with his tender hands his entrails, and did swell
Quite through the wide wound, till a cloud as blacke as death concealed
Their sight and all the world for him. When Hector had beheld
His brother tumbld so to earth (his entrails stille in hand),
Darke sorrow overcast his eyes, nor farre could he stand
A minute longer,

That's straight talking, with a compelling vigor of phrase that has brought Chapman the attention and admiration of the ages. The secret of his success lies under the surface, under the measure he instinctively unearthed and employed—and later abandoned.

3.

Antony and Cleopatra

All Englishmen of the Elizabethan period, the beginning of the Seventeenth Century, had just been put through an experience that had shaken them to their shoes at least and beyond them to their very

bones, the writers among them. A change in their religious loyalties, from Rome to the King, Henry VIII, was a violent wrench for some—sweet choirs from which of late the sweet birds sang. Many lost their heads in the transition.

The consolidation of the crown, the threat of the Armada, left no room for dallying with the political situation. Either you were loyal to England, which meant the crown, or you were an enemy of the state. An insular people continuously threatened by the sea had this new incentive to conserve its institutions. Englishmen were born and bred in this mold; should we be surprised that their literary forms should be no other than conservative and have remained so continuously to this day and promise to remain so into perpetuity?

I'm amused that when at a middle western college where I was addressing the student body, I happened to speak of the form in which Shakespeare's superb plays were written as not, I hoped, the last word in dramatic poetry, one of the more commanding students rose in his place foaming at the mouth and accused me of disloyalty to the genius of our conjoined languages. I was somewhat taken aback. I protested that although we are taught English in our schools, we do not, as long since pointed out by Mr. Mencken, speak that language among ourselves.

The language which Englishmen use officially became fixed about the figure of Shakespeare and others, until it has become virtually a case of *lèse majesté* to even think of liberalizing the form of any language that may follow it. The Irish had to fly to ancient Gaelic to retain their own selfhood but Americans had to dig deeper. In fact the prosodic structure of blank verse itself has to be restudied to get at the root of the stasis. It's not a question of seeking to find a way to unseat Shakespeare as the young man implied, but to preserve our own future and those of our fellows, the Englishman among us, in the forms of our intimacies.

I have mentioned how the Champion of Shakespeare's day, being somewhat regretful of the change in his religious climate, and not completely sold on what forms his "airs" should take, adopted a not so dedicated mold as his friend. Shakespeare was a conservative, he never could have existed in the Queen's entourage if he had not been. He wrote after the same pattern over and over for a lifetime, never parting from the successes he had schooled himself in after such a sweating schooling. He was a successful playwright, he had to have a play ready for production every season. No doubt he did not have an easy

time making a go of it between his wife and wherever he went to do his writing—his own bedroom perhaps—what with the excitement of his own thoughts and more practical matters associated with the production of the plays.

The master of his craft, who made his cash at the trade of playwriting, kept himself continually busy at work on his plays, day and night. No wonder he got writer's cramp as shown by his later signatures. He also stuttered, they say. He was a hard worker by the evidence of the plays themselves, not written on the machine! A persistent worker as would be any Englishman devoted to his job.

The good Will was in his measures the child of his own epoch, bound to this pattern and limited to it, as were the rest of them, in the practice of his art. He was bound hand and foot, brain and instinct, nose and ear, to the whole pattern of the age and could not do otherwise than follow it—except under extreme provocation. Drunkenness has always been a great releaser, therefore all disciplinarians detest it. It is necessary, at times, to free ourselves from a tyrannical process of thought—such as the triumphant dictates of the Sixteenth Century—to free ourselves as in this small and unobtrusive instance the poet does from its dominance. It is no more than a straw in the wind, but in view of what is to come later it points the way. We answer the commands of the age by aping his minor gestures, patterning our own verse after the structures that were adopted in his day.

Campion was made restless by these same restrictions. Now the supreme versifier among us when he got the chance to show what he could do and dared do followed the same thought. Pompey and Antony when they got a binge on were shown to measure their measure, their idiom after a loosed mode. *In vino veritas*.

As Shakespeare progressed with his writing he abandoned a strict adherence to the academic forms governing his verses and allowed them more and more to follow speech patterns. The forensic manner which permitted an actor to take the center of the stage and declaim was made more to resemble the conversational pattern of people talking together.

The inevitable result was that the measure was broken. The formal measure had been more and more brought under a strain as the moods and thoughts it was called on to depict were more and more subtilized also until the lines could no longer bear it.

The internal tensions had gone beyond all measure, a new was imperative, but the forms had been irrevocably closed by the genius of a master's mind and spirit.

An age had come to an end. But until this time no one has known where to turn in the language for relief.

I insist that within Shakespeare's own plays exist the hints, which followed, will lead to our delivery.

4.

"The Science of English Poetry" (1868)

Sidney Lanier

Measure, the measure, led him by the nose, but he was a true American in being dissatisfied with what he had been taught, unwilling to accept the old dictates. He was restless. He didn't know where to turn, but he knew that the old would not do—so he invented a whole category, a whole inadequate and untenable division of the measure into musical pauses which he attempted to apply to the written poetic phrase. The result was an artificial, forced approximation which was untenable for any practicing poet. If a man or woman wants to write a poem it has to be as plain as two and two are four how he is to do it.

The modern is too complex a measure for Lanier to have so much as guessed. Unless we say that the concatenation of his theories following the classic development of the art was the closed cul de sac in which he was seeking the way. It is too complex an understanding of measure for us to spend much effort upon today, but historically it brings us abreast of the times.

There were many attempts by British scholars from the very beginning to discover something to build on relating to the science or even the art of English poetry. Nothing has ever come of it. It might as well, for the sake of beginning on a positive note, be said to have started in 1575 when George Gascoigne enters upon his *Certayn Notes of Instruction concerning the making of verse or rhyme in English, written at the request of Master Eduardo Donati*. Of course we gather from Gascoigne "that if there were as many opinions as men in poetry the science of it had still to be begun."

We have all the poems from the Greek and Latin constantly before us in our schools, of the pronunciation of which we know nothing at all. So we won't get any help there. We'll have to start fresh with our English and since the pronunciation leads direct to the construction, we'll have to start our investigation there.

Poets have always been concerned with what they have found before as the material with which they have to work, the words they have

most to do with. How to use them and for what, for what purpose, and the order they shall occupy in speech and later on the written page. The order they occupy elevates and satisfies the poet and gives him the only final satisfaction he is likely to get on earth. If he could only feel secure in this, lacking such a variable thing as what they call genius, he'd be eternally happy. He knows it's unlikely that he will catch his mouse by the tail, other men have for the most part failed. But there's the inspiration to whip him into a new effort and he's off.

In the last century (1804) a certain Mitford summarized what was to be said on the subject of poetic rhythm which is governed by our conceptions of the poetic foot, the known meters practiced by our poets, in short the measures of our lines—he is accurate and unequivocal enough. “When . . . I found that to follow the Greek and Latin rules for the mechanism of Greek and Latin verse in writing was easy, but to comprehend the ground, to see the reason . . . so that the voice might follow as well as the pen, and the ear might acknowledge its performance, was not only beyond me, but, as far as I could discover, beyond all teachers; when further I observed that for the very different harmony of English verse, no rule could be obtained . . . these contradictions engaged my thought.”

Mitford's researches had evidently been exhaustive; and his assertion that “no rule” could be found for English verse up to his time (or since) was sound. But a few years afterward we come upon Coleridge's “grave assertion in the preface to *Christabel* that he had discovered a new principle of English versification, that of accents.” This “principle” had been employed, as far as Lanier was concerned, in English poetry for more than a thousand years; “and the very nursery-rhymes and folk songs of our tongue present us everywhere with applications of it far more daring and complex than any line of *Christabel*.”

In this incomplete note on the state of English prosody up to his time, the hopelessness of the attempts at any codification, since there are no data to hedge us in, becomes apparent. *The Laws of (English) Verse* are nonexistent, there are none.

Not to say that in writing verse it has been every man for himself: the time he lived in has governed the poet's choice of his words, and his methods and styles of composing them, unless he has been overborne by some principle of the moment that took possession of him.

That is what makes absurd the whole book of Lanier's attempts to build a new structure of categories, no matter how he builds them up.

One thing, and that a very simple one, is choice, if it is necessary to make a choice, between quantity or accent in our counting of the

measure. And we must agree that the divisions of the rhythm are to be counted somehow, for without such at least tacit counting there is no verse—we go into prose which is a horse of an entirely different color.

The division of verse on the page—whether to begin our lines with capital or lower case letters—is entirely beside the point—except to the follower of precedent, the ritual of obedience, the divine right of our rulers to command. Enigmas in the line, requiring wit to solve them, has always been a measure adopted by priests and kings to hide their meaning from the vulgar; prominent in such a poet as our own E. E. Cummings to insure against the “wrong” people reading what he has to say to his readers. The poems of Villa, beautiful as they are when correctly deciphered, and rewarding, are of the same order.

But there is something unguessed by all poets present and of the past which could not be envisioned until we had reached an age when the measure itself had been brought into question, the measure of the line itself, regular as it may be.

The language we have always spoken in the past, by which we have been consoled, strengthened and protected, is being modified under our very feet; the American idiom comes slowly into this orbit and because of its origin as an outgrowth of English (in our schools) has been brought inevitably into conflict with it—to the distress of both camps. The British have the precedence of us, the powerful masters of our speech, and theirs, especially Shakespeare, command our allegiance because they are superb artists, but let us not surrender our intelligence along with our love.

Today as reported by Dudek from Toronto in a recent magazine article we have a new refinement and definition of measure—showing that the poets will not or cannot let the subject rest. Nor should they as long as there are new poems to engage their attention; invention goes on.

After all, Lanier codified and categorized, imposing a whole system of his own choosing to tabulate what a friend of mine asked for—“a regular system, including all English poetry so that you could recognize the title of a rhythm”—if you accept him. He named his divisions, Rhythm 1, Rhythm 2 etc., on to 6 giving examples of each so that you can recognize them each in its turn, wrongheadedly or not—trivial or not as you may decide. But, as to one statement as to measure itself and its significance—nothing.

All he does, and those who follow, is to clear the turbid atmosphere. This is valuable therefore I notice it here. No one, and this I am convinced, will ever reduce the art of poetry to a system. It is

impossible so long as the poets themselves retain a fleck of invention and the ability to invent a single line. It is in fact a definition of poetry itself that it cannot be harnessed to a dray. It may break its neck, but it cannot be broken.

When poetry, even the best of poetry, is written after a certain mode too long it becomes a bore. The mind must be relieved as we get higher in the scale of intelligent interests. You may say that Shakespeare never bores and in moments of greatest intensity of his inspiration such as the passage about the multitudinous seas it may be so—but when we listen to lines that become merely monotonous, it cannot be true.

5.

The American Idiom

The fixed measure, regularly counted, has dominated all prosody in all languages, except the Hebrew, certainly all the classic languages taught in our academies in recent times. Our young have come to think of a fixed foot of whatever sort, dactylic, amphybrachic or iambic, as synonymous with the term "poetry." Furthermore rhyme and a sequence of stanzaic groupings of the lines as in Villon's *Grand Testament* or Rimbaud's well known ballads, in Pope, Chaucer, Keats, Goethe, Lope de Vega or the Russians: poetry and rhyme have largely been accepted, save for the blank verse of the Elizabethan stage, as the same thing. It must never be forgotten however, that the Greeks and after them the Roman poets never bothered with rhyme though Sappho may have used it occasionally. But the fixed foot had been the invariable rule throughout the ages.

All subtleties of thought and composition from the sonnets of Shakespeare and Dante to those of Mallarmé relied on the fixed foot to give them stability, to give them a norm from which to vary. The art, the "art" of poetry meant very little else, a superlative choice of words, an unsurpassed vocabulary and the ready wit to call on it in the ecstasies of composition.

The artist is a restless man, never satisfied. No sooner he recognizes a genius in literature or painting than he will go beyond him if he can. Michaelangelo may have been unsurpassed in his time, when along comes a new talent. It is no different in the natural sciences, and

worse, we hail Copernicus and Galileo after which we are not satisfied till we launch ourselves at the moon. The art of writing is no different until we come to Dada and the nihilists and the destruction of all art along with everything else.

There is nothing to do but to begin again. But let us never forget the lesson of the spiral, the Vorticists in England discovered that though we do over and over the same things it is never on the same plane but elsewhere in space. There is always something new to be experienced if we have the wit for it.

At the same time the traditionalists, those who want things to remain forever in the same groove, must set themselves to find a way to dominate our lives. In every generation the struggle is renewed with bloodshed if the issues are too hard pressed, not that they are often pressed that far over the composition of a line of verse, but the violence implied in such a painting as *Nude Descending a Staircase* or certain of Mr. Pound's cantos or some of the poems of E. E. Cummings are potentially of the same sort. Murder could quickly follow them; Pound's confinement to an insane asylum stems from nothing else.

The "moral" issue is never far in the rear. The exact point of pressure for an American writer, or at best, poet, is his own language, how it will be put on the page to represent what his mind perceives directly about him.

That is a complex phenomenon simplified by the singleness of the observing eye. That is eternally one. Start with that. There is no other choice, even if you begin at a periphery as in some modern painting, you must make that at least your beginning. But that at least, as in the "verse librists," broke the deadly sequence of the measure as it tended to perpetuate itself in the structure of the poem. Unfortunately the realignment did not go far enough, in many poets—witness our own E. E. Cummings—the *measure* is unaffected and it is the measure which is the objective, a change in the measure, which most affects our lives.

To measure our lines after the accepted style of English prosody which we are still taught in our universities and to which our moral codes are still made, unacknowledged, made to fit, explains how deep the fissure, or fission, goes. It is an unthinkable breach of etiquette and manners to vary an expected poetic stress, make a plus come down where a minus is expected.

It is an important matter to be a school man. To have the discipline of the language under your control is vitally important to the race: the

suicide of Socrates is tightly linked to this matter and he knew it as did his judges. Poets, the image breakers, are the enemies, the mortal enemies of school men—even when they are backward at their “lessons” as today. But in a new country, as this must still be thought of, our compulsions must go to the new.

Our native idiom, the way we speak in this democracy, is the image our poetry must dig in as a fertile soil. But after all we are poets, men and women with the antennae raised to every intellectual vantage of our world. If we are alert to the vagaries of language we at the same time are moralists awake to the significance of what the language implies; when we say “dig” instead of “understand” we should know that it is a moral risk we are taking when we use the word.

But deeper than that, the measure of our lines, the way they are deployed on the page goes for us deepest of all.

The late Mr. Mencken was not a poet, but he loved the ordering of words, he knew at least enough not to make the mistake of Mr. Eliot when he said, the American language! there is no American language. Eliot being a poet should have known better. But Mencken missed the point by not speaking of the American idiom, the spoken language, when he came to go so exhaustively into his subject. His book on the subject, *The American Language*, nowhere speaks of the pronunciation of the language, a living language, linked to the current thought of the time which it has its part in moulding. It is taking its place beside other languages of the world, its verse formation is not to be traditional as in Europe or even Asia or Africa or the Orient, but, if we are able, at the forward fringes of our thought. When a Dylan Thomas comes against us with his poems with whom are we going to compare him? His measures are nothing with which we are familiar. We know nothing of the influence of bardic chants. I personally am made uneasy by his sonorous voice, his success with the ladies makes me distrustful of such women, but that is no new phenomenon.

The American idiom offered the poet an opportunity to rid himself of the necessity to be herded with other poets around him and also of the past. But the use of words had nothing to do with this. To make such a statement seems absurd. What else is verse made of but “words, words, words?” Quite literally, *the spaces between the words*, in our modern understanding, which takes with them an equal part in the measure.

A musician understands this, as should a poet also. Campion did, but the dictates of his time forced a different interpretation of the

necessity upon him—or attempted to do so, to follow the popular trend. A whole nation has no choice but to join with the rest if it is not to be unseated in its fancy.

(To anticipate a bit. Re variable foot: [from a letter] “in the back of the hymn book you will find the psalms marked off—I suppose for chanting to music—into measures like this:

“Praise / ye the / Lord. // Praise ye the Lord from the heavens. / Praise him / in the / heights.

“Praise ye him, / all his / angels: // praise ye / him, / all his / hosts.

“Praise ye him, / sun and / moon: // praise him, / all ye / stars of / light.

Three measures before the caesura, four after. The music [organ] gives the time-structure of the line, and the words vary in pace so that from one to six go into a ‘foot.’

“Of course the words and music are entities conceived on separate occasions, and the words are being stretched and compressed to fit them into the music. Your job, on the other hand, consists in making them both come out right together from the start. Otherwise, the analogy between the variable foot and the mensuration of the psalms seems to me rather close. . .”)

We are all taught the King’s English in our schools from Kindergarten to the university, but we speak another language using the same written words. But the idiom, what we speak, is animated by a different spirit. Thus our world, in the United States, is divided, one part servant to a world of the past, those who accept its domination, and the other a world of the future. An internecine struggle goes on that keeps the vigor of the language alive. We hate each other, as only brothers can, being bred to it, but the language itself can have only one conceivable loyalty, as the mind develops; it can be nothing if not partisan of the new.

6.

The Variable Foot

Measure is divided into feet. The meaning holds no matter how complex it may be. The elements of it are always regular, governed by the ear. Quantitative verse differs from accentative verse only in being more sensitive, divided according to the way a poet’s meaning varies,

as the environment of Athens differs from sixteenth century, and we today, with post-Einsteinian knowledge at our disposal, search to understand more of life's less confound implications.

On a continent recently discovered, speaking a language marked by an idiom shaken free from ancient restrictions, it is at least understandable that we approach a measure in our verses approaching in unrestrictiveness the ancient Greek, a verse, cultured by an age of great subtlety, to which the more rigid convention of the schools is violently opposed.

It is a conservative convention in the first sense, moral in its characteristics, of which I speak—the same sense in which the mediaeval Christian church was governed by it, the church which condemned the poems of Sappho and saw to their destruction. A moral gesture.

Time. The measure has to be stable to be accepted or acceptable. For otherwise it is immoral. As the French are today except in their academies!

The chief blemish which mars the composition of even the Shakespearean sonnet and all English poetry to the present day is the persistent inversion of the phrase. This has been enforced on even the greatest writers by a blind adherence to custom. The writers have been insensitive to a slavish fixed measure.

But the worst deformer of the sentence by inversion is Milton, the Latinist.

Insensitive to the language they heard spoken about them, by evidence of the recorded prose, the poets had an itch to conform as they do today and have done from the beginning, to something which they believed was above their heads. They completely missed the significance of the essential make up of what the poem is: measure. They all of them from Homer, from Aristotle down, took it to be something involving social prestige. They associated it with the gods, at least from the recent middle ages to our times, with the aristocracy. A princely thing too, we'll say in the case of a Milton, an appurtenance of God.

We can think of ages when—led by Dante—the Church dominated the verse of the ages and not only the verse of the ages but its most intimate forms. To deviate from the forms of the accepted poem was sacrilege punishable by the accusation of immorality, tacit but none the less effective.

The sonnet has presented itself throughout the ages, either in one or another of its forms, as the most desirable and completely desirable

form of the love lyric in spite of the fact that its composition, because of the language difficulties, makes it almost impossible to write—even for the greatest poets among us—without the deformities of inversion of which I have already spoken. But there is another difficulty; the almost complete restriction of the matter dealt with to a type of statement completely limited to literary reference which in this age is completely false.

Men and women who are in love do not any longer feel this way, the way adopted by the sonnet, toward each other. To me it is a revolting exhibition which, if it cannot be suppressed, should be ignored. It makes my guts turn over. Have they, these sonneteers, nothing else to write about? Do they forget that Dante or at least Shakespeare, with languages more adapted to the restrictive form and with a genius and in an age more conducive to the mood of the thing, have done the work of genius in each case. It is impossible for us to equal them if it were possible. They want to copy them, to prove what? That they are also great poets?

And if they succeed in writing a passable sonnet, such as Milton did to his blindness or Wordsworth on London Bridge, which is unlikely, does not the whole of poetry fairly shriek in their ears to go elsewhere? They are neglecting the present and the possible forms, not the sonnet, they should be using to express themselves in. Invention, the relating of opportunities the age offers, but they close their eyes or lock themselves in their imposed closet, to copy, to copy, to copy! the past and the active men of the past. Looking at their own belly-buttons they go into a trance, sweat over a few verbal relationships and come out with a composition, after some dead precedent that has had its day, a sonnet. And that is an active age with every incentive to literary invention if we knew only where to turn.

Where are we to turn? To measure, a reassurance of a new measure. The literary world has been closed to us from our birth by the past. The discovery of a new continent has the connotation of a new continent in the world of literature also. Measure is the only solidity we are permitted to know in our sensible world, to measure. A discovery in the province of measure to supersede the past is all we can hope for and that we are determined to possess.

In this country we have from the beginning all wanted to be aristocrats: imitating the English who used to be our masters—and have, failing honors, wanted power, that is to say, money. The history of the country is nothing other from the Tories down. The “freedom” which

we acquire from the Indians, stealing it from them, all but the Quakers, has been falsely touted as our dearest possession until we have believed it a God-given attribute. Cortez, that thief and murderer, should be our national hero. Whitman took it from his Creole sweetie, whom he wanted to make his wife until his friends and relatives prevented him from marrying a "nigger," prevented his happiness, took it over into the field of letters. Freedom, was what he understood. That alone.

But Freedom cannot be the end of it. We are free to do what, as our juvenile delinquents, and are we not all juvenile delinquents, find out to our sorrow? No verse can be free. That is solely a confusion in terms: all verse must be measured. The sole problem where shall we find the measure?

The past is the measure that alone can give us any security. Our schools have been built on nothing else. But the world of letters no more than the world of Galileo does not stand still. The world of our relationships is changing every day about our ears—affecting even our social relationships: marriages are not understood in the same light as formerly when a man had absolute power over his wife's body—if he could get it.

Comparable changes have taken place in the body poeticus ever since the days of Sappho, who had such powers over the measures she employed that we salute even today a loving master.

Defiance is a worn out symbol fitted more to a wop from Sicily for making us all pay for our vegetables if we live in the Chicago market area. But to rule our poetic measures we have to look for something more powerful than that.

Measure, to be universally applicable, has to go into the provinces of abstract thought. To be practical that is, we have to know where a ballistic missile is going. Not approximately where it is going, but exactly where it is going. When your wife goes out the back door you can't take a chance on it, you have to know where she is heading. Not approximately where, but exactly where she is heading in all its possibilities. When she returns at the end of the day you have only to look at her for an answer. That's what makes life interesting. That is why we are alive—love conquers all. That is the measure that dictates the structure of the lines of our poems.

A variable foot governs the lines of our poems. When we start a poetic sequence we have no idea where we are going. We are not fooled by that. The measure holds if we know what we're doing. Only the measure holds. But IT holds. The *measure* holds if we are not

children. We have special categories for children known as Kindergartens.

Some well disposed critic should be assigned to observe, to inspect and pull out all that is usable.

Now, getting down to brass tacks, as my father used to say (Shahn: ". . . A friend of mine once divided the whole thing into three broad categories: The Maze—as represented by Pollock; The Order—as represented by Mondrian; and The Monster—as represented by Picasso—of the Guernica period. It's oversimplification, of course, but I think you could almost divide our art today into those three broad categories.") Sitting down to the typewriter—having got over "the stage of pencil sharpening and opening the window to look up and down the street," what shall we put down on the paper?

I don't pretend that I know all the answers—but that the poetic measure must be to take its part among other measures in the assemblies of the age broken away from its ankylosed conditions I venture to dedicate myself, completely. We cannot escape it as intelligent men.

We know now that there is no such thing as free verse. That is no more than a contradiction in terms. To resort to measures, in short to verse, is to submit to a discipline, the identical discipline to which science has to be submitted. And at once it must be added that by no stretch of the imagination are art and science to be assumed to be an identity or even to resemble each other. They simply are measured similarly. The choice is infinite.

To use cadences dictated by the American idiom. All that I have learned in prose composition to get as much as I can in the fewest possible words, trimming wherever it is possible to make the sense come through without tautology, balancing the words against that. Using a full vocabulary, the fullest vocabulary of speech terms to maintain a sensible effect. Concentrating what I have to say so that an alert mind is encouraged to take the leaps necessary to bridge the gaps in the sense left to save time. That's where the test comes. What is and what is not permitted. Mere eccentricity is not permitted. It must be possible to reconstruct the sense from the scheme, the grid of the words supplied, but the reader must be empowered by the interest of the subject, its way, its topography, (not repelled by it) to follow.

And when he or she has followed he must be rewarded by achieving a satisfaction which awakens him to a maximum followed by a complete rest in which to enjoy his sensations. The passage must come instantly in an epigram to a climax.

The construction cannot be allowed in the idiom to rely on a habitual turn of phrase or of thought. Imagine if you will Ezra Pound or E. E. Cummings or even Ben Shahn facing a piece of paper dominated by some idea which he has proposed to himself—and I do not say that at times, facing the paper, he may not have an idea at all in his head save the impetus to write, to discover in himself what puts him on edge and to discover what will come of it.

The so called “divine” discontent of the artist may very well have no other objective. It is there that an idiom takes the lead. Words begin to occur to his ear. If Chinese ideograms occur to him it is with the Oxford trained intonation of a Mr. Waley—we hope. But be that as it may a variable meter should take the initiative.

Pound said to me years ago it was his conviction that we are all born with a pattern of speech to which we are native. We can take a Pound canto and plot it by the speeches it employs to a fairly constant design.

It doesn't matter how the speech is employed. The same with Mr. Cummings except for his cleverness in employing anapests to relieve his iambs: it goes invariably after the same dog trot. Miss Moore the same. The ideas all these poets employ making them make the words dance, come back to a constant repetitiousness that delights or repels their respective audiences.

What I in my American world am proposing is that they divide their lines differently and see what comes of it. We are finished with the aberration of free verse, but we have to learn to recount, taking our idiom as a constant (and for that we have to know what we are talking) and make units of it which we compose into our effects.

It is not easy to teach. It is not even easy to apprehend. But the incentive it gives to a choice of words not out of a book leads to surprising assemblies and turns of phrase which are sometimes rewarding in succinctness and vivid interplays when the poet does not feel constrained by the habitual.

The following “Note on *Measure*” by Hugh Kenner preceded WCW's essay when it was first published in *Spectrum*, III, 3 (Fall 1959).

Dr. Williams planned this essay in the summer of 1958 and drafted it in the following fall and winter. The state of his health in the spring of 1959 brought his work on the project to a halt. He was unable either to revise what he had done or to fill out several of the sections as he had planned.

The version presented here was edited by me at the author's request. He hoped that I would complete some of the incomplete portions, but for the

present I have thought it wiser to present the reader only with sentences Dr. Williams wrote and topics he sketched. By abridging redundancies and excising undeveloped passages I have shortened the author's draft by about one-third. What remains is not the full treatment of Measure Dr. Williams planned, but as far as it goes it is wholly his.

An unedited typescript of "Measure" is housed in the Collection of American Literature, Beinecke Rare Book and Manuscript Library, Yale University. Because the series of strokes that WCW suffered during the 1950s severely impaired his ability to read and write, the typescript contains many errors and incoherencies of spelling, punctuation, capitalization, grammar, diction, and fact. To make the essay more accurate and more intelligible to readers of *Spectrum*, Kenner not only cut passages but also made scores of changes in WCW's styling and wording. The present edition reproduces the *Spectrum* text without recording these changes because the apparatus required to do so would be both cumbersome and unilluminating. Kenner's revisions seem to the present editors consistent with WCW's intended meanings wherever they can be ascertained.

Campion: Thomas Campion (1567–1620) received his medical training at the University of Caen in France. A composer of poems, songs, and masques, Campion published four *Books of Airs* between 1601 and 1617. His *Observations in the Art of English Poesie* (1602) defended the use of classical meters and criticized the use of rhyme in English poetry. Samuel Daniel's *Defence of Ryme* (1603) took issue with Campion's arguments.

Chapman: George Chapman (?1559–1634) was an English playwright and translator of Homer. Chapman's *Iliad* appeared in several installments between 1598 and 1611. His *Odyssey* followed in 1614–16.

one drunken passage: In Act II, Scene vii of *Antony and Cleopatra*, Shakespeare depicts the revels of Antony, Pompey, Lepidus, and Enobarbus aboard Pompey's galley. WCW refers to the scene more explicitly in Section 3 below.

Sidney Lanier: The American poet Sidney Lanier (1842–1881) first lectured on "The Science of Poetry" in Baltimore, Maryland, in 1878 (not 1868). In 1879 Lanier was appointed to the faculty of English at Johns Hopkins University, though not as a Professor. His lectures were published in the following year as *The Science of English Verse*. In this treatise, Lanier argues that the laws governing music and verse are identical and that time, rather than accent, determines verse rhythms.

professor of English: Randall Stewart (1896–1964), a distinguished scholar of American literature, taught at Brown University from 1937 to 1955. The Yale typescript of "Measure" contains WCW's undated transcription of a letter from Stewart, in which he recalls meeting WCW at Brown and acknowledges that he was probably "the one who referred to Sidney Lanier's Science of English Verse."

E. Tn: The Reverend Ethelred L. Taunton wrote the entry on *Edmund Campion* for the eleventh edition of the *Encyclopedia Britannica* (New York: Encyclopedia Britannica, 1910), V, 136–37. The entry on *Thomas Campion* (137–38) was, however, written by Percival Vivian.

Milton: Milton's masque, *Comus*, and his pastoral elegy, "Lycidas," both appeared in 1637. *Paradise Lost* was published in 1667.

a pragmatist in his age: In the Yale typescript of "Measure," WCW adds the following words to the end of this sentence: "you might say an existentialist."

Bridges: The English poet and doctor, Robert Bridges (1844–1930), experimented with quantitative measures in several works that WCW studied carefully during the mid-1940s, especially *The Testament of Beauty*. See Mariani, "Hopkins and Williams" and *William Carlos Williams* 547. See also Witemeyer and Walkiewicz 212.

nearly lost his head: Campion was a friend of Sir Thomas Monson, a prominent Catholic who was convicted of murdering Sir Thomas Overbury in 1616. Campion was questioned about a sum of money that he had transferred to Monson, but maintained that he did not know the purpose of the payment.

one early book: Thomas Campion, *A New Way of making Fowre Parts in Counterpoint. etc.* (c. 1617)

air from Book 4: "Rose-cheeked Laura" comes not from Campion's *Fourth Book of Airs* but from the eighth chapter of his *Observations in the Art of English Poesie*; see *Poetical Works (in English) of Thomas Campion*, ed. Percival Vivian (London: George Routledge & Sons and New York: E. P. Dutton [1907]): 226. WCW employed this "Muses' Library" edition rather than Vivian's more complete and scholarly Clarendon Press edition of *Campion's Works* (1909).

Sir Philip Sidney: WCW takes this list of famous Elizabethan writers from Vivian's "Introduction" to Campion's *Poetical Works*: xviii. Vivian in turn quotes the list from William Camden's *Remaines of a Greater Worke concerning Britaine* (1605).

"Campion's measures: WCW misquotes Vivian's "Introduction": lii. Vivian speaks of "Campion's metres," not his "measures."

"Hark, all you ladies: This is song XIX in Campion's first *Book of Airs* (1601); see *Poetical Works* 19–20.

Wreck of the Deutschland: The poet-priest Gerard Manley Hopkins (1844–1889) published this elegy in 1876. It is written in an irregular and original cadence, which Hopkins called "sprung rhythm."

antennae: In "Henry James" (1918), Ezra Pound defines artists as "the antennae of the race." WCW echoes the statement again in section 5 of "Measure."

the first seven books of it: The first installment of Chapman's translation was published in 1598 under the title *Seaven Bookes of the Iliades of Homere, Prince of Poets*.

Allardyce Nicoll's modern text: Allardyce Nicoll, ed., *Chapman's Homer*, 2 vols. (New York: Pantheon Books, 1956). WCW reviewed this edition for *Poetry*, XCI, 1

The lance betwixt: This passage describes the slaying of Harpalion by Meriones in Book XIII of *The Iliad*, lines 604-5; see Nicoll, I, 269. WCW has modernized the spelling.

This said: King Priam prepares to pray to Jove, in Book XXIV of *The Iliad*, lines 276–78; see Nicoll, I, 485. WCW misquotes the second line of the passage, which begins: “He bad powre water. . . .”

Then rushed he on: Achilles slays Polydore, in Book XX of *The Iliad*, lines 359–73; see Nicoll, I, 417. There are many discrepancies between WCW's quotation and Nicoll's text, which reads as follows:

Then rusht he on, and in his eye had heavenly Polydore,
Old Priam's sonne, whom last of all his fruitfull Princesse bore,
And for his youth (being deare to him) the king forbad to fight.
Yet (hote of unexperienc't blood, to shew how exquisite
He was of foote, for which of all the fiftie sonnes he held
The speciall name) he flew before the first heate of the field,
Even till he flew out breath and soule—which, through the backe,
the lance
Of swift Achilles put in ayre, and did his head advance
Out at his navill. On his knees the poore Prince crying fell,
And gatherd with his tender hands his entrailles, that did swell
Quite through the wide wound, till a cloud as blacke as death
conceald
Their sight and all the world from him. When Hector had beheld
His brother tumbld so to earth (his entrailles still in hand),
Darke sorrow overcast his eyes, nor farre off could he stand
A minute longer,

sweet choirs: WCW misquotes the fourth line of Shakespeare's Sonnet 73: "Bare ruined choirs where late the sweet birds sang." WCW interprets the image of the ruined choirs as a reference to Henry VIII's forcible dissolution of the Roman Catholic monasteries during the Protestant Reformation.

a middle western college: Hanover College in Hanover, Indiana, where WCW lectured in May 1952; see Mariani, *William Carlos Williams* 646–47.

Mr. Mencken: The American journalist, editor, and critic Henry Louis Mencken (1880–1956) published the first edition of his popular study, *The American Language: An Inquiry into the Development of English in the United States*, in 1919. He revised and expanded the work in a series of new editions and supplements, which continued until 1948. Mencken's aim was to describe and document the growth of a distinctively American “stream” of the English language.

The master of his craft: In the Yale typescript of "Measure," this paragraph comes after "In vino veritas" following.

Drunkness: WCW never illustrates this point concretely. The Yale typescript of "Measure" shows that he was confused about which scene in *Antony and Cleopatra* departs from the iambic norm (was it II, vii or II, ii?) and about which "professor" originally alerted him to this departure (was it Randall Stewart or someone else?).

George Gascoigne: The Elizabethan writer George Gascoigne (?1534–1577) authored poems, masques, and interludes as well as the treatise on prosody which WCW cites. WCW's quotation ("that if there were . . .") comes not from Gascoigne, however, but from Sidney Lanier's account of him in the "Preface" to *The Science of English Verse* (1880). See Paul Franklin Baum, ed., *The Science of English Verse and Essays on Music*, Vol. II of The Centennial Edition of the Works of Sidney Lanier (Baltimore: The Johns Hopkins Press, 1945): 8.

a certain Mitford: William Mitford, *An Inquiry into the Principles of Harmony of Language, and of the Mechanism of Verse, Modern and Antient* (1774; 2nd ed. London: L. Hanford, 1804). Again, WCW quotes not from the original but from Lanier's "Preface" 11.

Coleridge's 'grave assertion': In his "Preface," Lanier speaks of "Coleridge's grave announcement, in the Preface to *Christabel* of 1816, that he had discovered a new principle of English versification, to wit, that of accents. This 'principle' had been employed, as far as it can be, in English poetry for more than a thousand years; and the very nursery-rhymes and folk-songs of our tongue present us everywhere with applications of it far more daring and complex than any line of *Christabel*" (11).

the poems of Villa: Born in the Philippines, José García Villa (1908–1997) came to the United States in 1929. New Directions published a volume of his poetry in 1948, and McDowell, Obolensky issued his *Selected Poems and New* in 1958.

Dudek from Toronto: Montreal, not Toronto, is the home base of the Canadian poet and critic, Louis Dudek (b. 1918). WCW is probably referring to Dudek's "A Note on Metrics," *Delta* (Montreal), 5 (October 1958); rpt. in Louis Dudek, *Selected Essays and Criticism* (Ottawa, Canada: Tecumseh Press, 1978): 111–15. "The music of great poetry," Dudek writes, "does not reside in the regular rhythm, nor even in any imagined counterpoint, but in the unique melody or structure of sound, in which each syllable is different from every other, and all together form a beautiful shape." Dudek credits WCW with having "written some of the best of the new poetry" (114).

a friend of mine: Unidentified.

the passage about the multitudinous seas: In Act II, scene ii of *Macbeth*, the protagonist sees on his hands the blood of King Duncan, and asks:

Will all great Neptune's ocean wash this blood
Clean from my hand? No, this my hand will rather
The multitudinous seas incarnadine,
Making the green one red.

the Vorticists in England: The Vorticists were a group of avant-garde visual artists and writers who joined forces in London from 1914 to 1916. Their members included Wyndham Lewis, Ezra Pound, Henri Gaudier-Brzeska, Edward Wadsworth, C. R. W. Nevinson, and David Bomberg. Their manifesto was the periodical *BLAST*, edited by Lewis, and their principal symbol was a vortex or dynamic spiral.

Nude Descending a Staircase: The French artist Marchel Duchamp (1887–1968) exhibited this dynamic, abstractionist painting in Paris in 1912. WCW saw it at the Armory Show in New York in 1913.

Pound's confinement to an insane asylum: From December 1945 to May 1958, the American poet Ezra Pound (1885–1972) was held in St. Elizabeths Hospital, the federal asylum for the criminally insane in Washington, D.C. He had been adjudicated mentally incompetent to stand trial on charges of treason.

Mr. Eliot: In "American Literature and the American Language," an address delivered at Washington University in St. Louis, Missouri, on June 9, 1953, T. S. Eliot took issue with H. L. Mencken's contention that American English is a separate language. Acknowledging the existence of discrepancies in spelling, pronunciation, vocabulary, and idiom, Eliot nevertheless concludes that "the sum total of these differences . . . does not . . . justify us in speaking of English and American as different languages. . . . There is, I suspect, behind the thinking of such students of languages as Mr. Mencken . . . a mistaken assimilation of language to politics" (*To Criticize the Critic and Other Writings* [New York: Farrar, Straus & Giroux, 1965]: 48–50).

the hymn book: The writer of the letter quoted here may have been Hugh Kenner. We have not identified the hymnal in which Psalm 148 is marked "for chanting to music."

his blindness: WCW refers to John Milton's Petrarchan sonnet, "When I Consider How My Light Is Spent" (1673).

Wordsworth on London Bridge: WCW misremembers the title of William Wordsworth's sonnet, "Composed upon Westminster Bridge, September 3, 1802."

Whitman took it from his Creole sweetie: The theory that Whitman, during his visit to New Orleans in 1848, had a love affair which produced a child was first put forward by Henry Bryan Binns in his *Life of Walt Whitman* (1905). The revised theory that the lady in question was "a Creole octoroon" was advanced by Emory Holloway in *Whitman: An Interpretation in Narrative* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1926): 67. Neither version of the story has ever been substantiated; but WCW, in several late writings about Whitman, accepts Holloway's speculation as fact.

Shahn: Ben Shahn (1898–1969) was an American painter and a friend of WCW. Shahn's "friend" is unidentified. The American "action" painter Jackson Pollock (1912–1956) created intricate abstract-expressionist paintings by dripping paint onto canvas with kinetic, improvisatory movements of his entire body. The Dutch abstract painter Piet Mondrian (1872–1944) is best known for his geometric compositions in bold primary colors. The Spanish artist Pablo Picasso (1881–1973) created *Guernica* in 1937 as a protest against the aerial bombardment of the Basque town by Nationalist forces during the Spanish Civil War. The suffering of *Guernica's* inhabitants is expressed through grotesque distortions of human and animal figures. During the same period, Picasso created a series of images of the Minotaur, a monster who was half bull and half man.

Mr. Waley: Sir Arthur David Waley (1889–1966) translated many works of Chinese and Japanese literature into English, starting with *A Hundred and Seventy Chi-*

nese Poems (1918). Most of his translations are unrhymed, and the irregular cadences of some were influenced by the sprung rhythms of Hopkins. Waley attended Rugby and Cambridge, not Oxford.

The American Idiom

William Carlos Williams

The American idiom is the language we speak in the United States. It is characterized by certain differences from the language used among cultured Englishmen, being completely free from all influences which can be summed up as having to do with "the Establishment." This, pared to essentials, is the language which governed Walt Whitman in his choice of words. It constituted a revolution in the language. (In France, only Paul Fort recognized what had happened about him to negate the *Academie*.)

The language had been deracinated in this country, but the English tongue was a tough customer with roots bedded in a tradition of far-reaching cultural power. Every nursery rhyme gave it a firmer grip on the tradition and there were always those interested in keeping their firm hold upon it.

Every high school in America is duty bound to preserve the English language as a point of honor, a requirement of its curriculum. To fail in *English* is unthinkable!

Ignoring the supreme masters of English composition and thinking to go beyond them along the same paths impugns a man's loyalty if not his good sense. In fact, it has been baldly stated in the highest circles and believed that there is no American language at all—so low have we fallen in defense of our speech.

The result is a new and unheralded language which has grown stronger by osmosis, we are asked to believe, but actually by the power of those Whitmans among us who were driven to take a chance by their fellows and the pride of an emerging race, its own. The American idiom had been driven into a secondary place by our scholars, those rats that had abandoned it to seek salvage elsewhere in safer places.

No one can blame them, no one can say that we shall survive to plant our genes in another world.

We must go forward—uncertainly it may be, but courageously as we may. Be assured that measure in mathematics as in verse is inescapable; so in reply to the fixed foot of the ancient line, including the Elizabethans, we must have a reply: it is the variable foot which we are beginning to discover after Whitman's advent.

"The Establishment," fixed in its commitments, has arrived at its last stand: the iambic pentameter, blank verse, the verse of Shakespeare and Marlowe which give it its prestige. A full stop. Until we can go beyond that, "the Establishment" has an edge on us.

Whitman lived in the nineteenth century but he, it must be acknowledged, proceeded instinctively by rule of thumb and a tough head, correctly, in the construction of his verses. He knew nothing of the importance of what he had stumbled on, unconscious of the concept of the variable foot. This new notion of time which we were approaching, leading to the work of Curie and the atom bomb, and other *new* concepts have been pregnant with far-reaching consequences.

We were asleep to the tremendous responsibilities—as poets and as writers generally—that were opening up to us. Our poets especially are asleep from the neck down—only the Russians with their state control of letters are stupider than we. And still we follow the English and teach it to our unsuspecting children.

Paul Fort: The French poet, playwright, and man of letters Paul Fort (1872–1960) published his *Ballades françaises* as prose, relying upon rhythm, cadence, and assonance rather than meter and rhyme.

the highest circles: See the note on *Mr. Eliot*, p. 75.

the work of Curie and the atom bomb: The discovery of radium in 1898 by Marie Curie (1867–1934) and her husband Pierre was closely connected in WCW's mind with the discovery of atomic fission and the detonation of the atomic bombs at Hiroshima and Nagasaki in 1945. He links the two events in Book Four, Part II of *Paterson* (1951); see also Mariani, *William Carlos Williams* 492, 506, 620.

The Continuity of American Poetry

Charles Tomlinson

This is a long book—too long, perhaps, to sustain continuously the undoubted interest of its themes. At the same time, its importance ought not to be overlooked and its reception in England has been unaccountably shabby. One thinks in particular of the way the *TLS* anonymously sniffed at it and how, throughout the year, many an inferior book has been hastily promoted to leading page status in the weekend reviews. Professor Pearce's study seems to have fallen victim to that familiar editorial weakness which leans a little too automatically towards the merely topical. Was it because a large part of his undertaking concerns Marianne Moore, William Carlos Williams and Pound, those poets the Englishman doesn't bother to read? At all events, Professor Pearce has lacked our due appreciation.

Perhaps one can best begin to describe the drama which is the occasion for the book—a drama of insistent epigraphs and often clashing intentions, with Stevens and Eliot at two extremes—by opening on the Whitman question. This makes for one of the inescapable continuities of the title, the manner in which modern American poets, for all their diversity of intention, have felt called upon to create their work in some degree as a reply to, even a dialogue with Whitman. There is Crane's naive and unequivocal "My hand / in yours, / Walt Whitman— / so—". There is Williams' far more qualified, but equally reconnaissant remark on Whitman's perception of the necessity to "break the old apart, to make room for ourselves": "From the beginning," writes Williams, "Whitman realized that the matter was largely technical. It had to be free verse or nothing. . . He had seen a great light but forgot almost at once . . . everything but his 'message' . . . and took his eye off the words themselves which should have held

him." There is also Pound who was trying for a pact with Whitman as far back as *Lustra*:

It was you that broke the new wood,
Now is a time for carving.

It was Pound also who had said in 1909 (in "What I feel about Walt Whitman"): "Mentally I am a Walt Whitman who has learned to wear a collar and a dress shirt. . . ." By 1934 in his *ABC of Reading* he is trying to get at the Whitman matter by shutting his ear to the Whitman manner. By Canto 82 he is still negotiating the pact:

and the news is a long time moving
a long time in arriving
through the impenetrable
crystalline, indestructable
ignorance of locality
The news was quicker in Troy's time
a match on Cnidos, a glow worm on Mitylene,
Till forty years since, Reithmuller indignant:
"Fvy! in Tdaenmarck efen dh' beasantz gnow him,"
meaning Whitman, exotic, still suspect
four miles from Camden. . .

and the poem, modulating through a lovely echo of *Out of the Cradle* proceeds to a paean to Gea Terra imitated out of the same poem, thence through a reminiscence of Theocritus and a synoptic vision of the Greek poet and the American 'singer'. Professor Pearce, in some of the most fascinating pages of his book goes on to show Pound, in the Cantos, consciously setting out to write the American epic that would make good what Whitman's omitted, identifying their roles but distinguishing them. "Where Whitman would include," writes Professor Pearce, "Pound would discriminate. Where Whitman would energize so as to define, Pound would define so as to energize." But Pound, like Whitman, adheres to the American task of providing an epic that shall, by its new materials, form the new man, its reader—unlike the classical epic which counted on an achieved cultural norm in its audience. "Like Whitman," says Professor Pearce, "Pound would create, not confirm, the hero of his epic."

This, then, is one of the great virtues of *The Continuity of American Poetry*: we are made to feel the pressures governing the poets' decisions. The Whitman question provides a case in point which, as Englishmen, we are prone to ignore, because we "don't like" Whitman.

We can well afford to profit from Professor Pearce's understanding of the meaning of the American poet's ventures, before we decide we don't like Pound and Williams or, for that matter, Miss Moore. This understanding goes a long way to enriching our view of Stevens and Eliot where the awareness of Whitman's presence helps once more. Suffice it to say here merely that a reading of *Prufrock*, in which we can hear an I which is the antithesis of the Whitmanian I, renews our sense of what the American artist is struggling with: "Eliot's pronouncements on Whitman indicate," says Professor Pearce, "that the latter was the demon whose achievement it was to torment any American who would dare to write poetry in any mode but his." Whitman's transmuting of the forms of ordinary discourse into poetry, his parallelisms and repetitions survive into Eliot's own style. As late as *East Coker* (Pearce puts side by side "Allons! to that which is endless as it was beginningless" and "To arrive where you are, to get from where you are not") Eliot uses the Whitmanian mode "to negate itself and generate its opposite; a wholly personal style takes on a grand impersonality."

Professor Pearce's book is not simply about Whitman but I have stressed that aspect of it to illustrate his view of one of the shaping pressures. That view extends to the very beginnings, from the Puritan anagrammatic poems, with their weird search for the given meaning of the individual life, to the brand of individualism which is the outgrowth of puritan and antinomian tendencies—the self which must search for its own definition in the face of its environment. De Tocqueville was struck by this people who looked at the world with reference to themselves and not, like Frenchmen, at themselves with reference to the world.

"Here's for the plain old Adam, the simple genuine self against the whole world," says Emerson. Professor Pearce traces out the direction of the antinomian Adamic poem and also that of a counter-current, the mythic poem. The latter, represented by Eliot, Pound, Ransom and Tate "took its most appropriate shape, as it leaned toward . . . tradition . . . principles of continuity derived from those large, extra-human, form-giving patterns of belief and commitment called myths." Yet in its turn this counter-current brought about a revival of the Adamic poem. Here Williams was to challenge Pound, as Crane had challenged Eliot, for what he felt to be Pound's selling out to the past, to Europe. D. H. Lawrence in his review of *In the American Grain* (Phoenix, p. 334) saw clearly years ago what Williams was

after: "William Carlos Williams tries to bring into his consciousness America itself, the still unravished bride of silences." And as Hugh Kenner has pointed out (*Gnomon*, p. 50) it is only when Williams has reached *Paterson*, Book IV, that he will admit Europe into his documentation of *Paterson*—only when America has been faced on its own terms that we get as measuring point for the dissonances of locality:

—and the Abbess Hildegard, at her own
funeral, Rupertsberg, 1179
had enjoined them to sing the choral, all
women, she had written for the occasion
and it was done, the peasants kneeling
in the background . as you may see

Yet for both Pound and Williams Whitman remains the key figure, and, as Professor Pearce writes, "the explicitly Whitmanian problem of the greatness of the audience has been restated as the problem of the greatness to which the poet can bring the audience. Their large difference—and it is the difference which makes for the issue between them—lies in their notion of what the audience is capable of being and how the capability may be realized."

I have already touched on the rather unwieldy length of this book. Two other qualifications come to mind, one minor, the other conceivably more important. First, it is occasionally difficult to share Professor Pearce's valuation of his examples—Whittier's *Snow Bound*, for instance, is certainly a delightful and sustained performance, splendid for the family reading for which it is intended, but is it really a "great poem"? Second, there are two omissions among Professor Pearce's choice of poets: Yvor Winters and Laura Riding. Winters is surely the one supreme example of the poet who has dug in his heels and said that American poetry could have been a very different thing from what it is and from Pearce's view of it—and he has written memorable poems to show in what way. Whether he is right or not, he is the great exception and his voice should have been admitted to the debate. Laura Riding, the most astonishing woman poet of her generation, carries to an extreme one aspect of the American concern, with poetry as reconstituting the poet's and the reader's identity. In the late thirties she decided that this was a mistaken direction, having left her collected verse as instance and warning. She is a supreme poet and, again, her example should perhaps have been part of Professor Pearce's history.

"Ecstasy affords the occasion," says Professor Pearce, quoting Miss Moore at the head of his text, "and expediency determines the form." What gives to both ecstasy and expediency their more than personal point is his contention that we all now share in the American situation, for better or worse. "We have not yet sufficiently realised," he writes, "the degree to which the history of American poetry is a sort of model, an initial if not initiating test-case, for the recent history of all Anglo-European poetry. Almost from the beginning, the American poet's world has been the one we now know everywhere around us: where the very role and function of poetry as a valid human act is in question; where the creative sensibility struggles not just to express itself, assured that such expression has a place, some place, in the world, but merely to survive". He sees the American poet beginning as a pioneer and continuing as one. Perhaps Mr. Alvarez had something similar in mind when, in his recent anthology, he printed the work of two American poets as founding fathers for the kind of contemporary English poetry that he feels is most worthwhile. Yet to be entirely logical he would have had to include not merely the American poets of psychic disturbance, but those of energetic contemplativeness, deepening their view of the relation between the self and the world. How far that world is our world too, Professor Pearce demonstrates with ample evidence and the conviction of insight.

a long book: CT is reviewing Roy Harvey Pearce's *The Continuity of American Poetry* (Princeton: Princeton UP and Oxford: Oxford UP, 1961), xv + 442 pp. Pearce (b. 1919) was Professor of English at the University of California, San Diego.

the TLS: In "Counter Currents," *Times Literary Supplement* (March 9, 1962) 162, the anonymous reviewer of Pearce's book concludes that "Professor Pearce is another instance of the eternal American, always on the frontier, having broken completely with the past and anxious to get off to a fresh start."

"My hand / in yours: CT quotes the closing lines of "Cape Hatteras," Part IV of *The Bridge* (1930) by the poet and essayist Hart Crane (1899-1932).

"break the old apart: CT quotes from WCW's "An Essay on *Leaves of Grass*," first published in *Leaves of Grass One Hundred Years After*, ed. Milton Hindus (Stanford and London: Stanford UP, 1955) 31, 22. Roy Harvey Pearce reprints the essay in his *Whitman: A Collection of Critical Essays* (Englewood Cliffs, N.J.: Prentice-Hall, 1962) 146-54.

Pound: These citations of the poet and critic Ezra Pound (1885-1972) are taken from pp. 84-87 of *The Continuity of American Poetry*. CT's critical accounts of Pound's *ABC of Reading* and Canto 82 likewise echo those of Pearce. The lines from Pound's *Lustra* (1916) come from the poem "A Pact."

"Where Whitman would include": This quotation and the next one come from p. 90 of *The Continuity of American Poetry*.

"Eliot's pronouncements: CT's discussion of T. S. Eliot and Walt Whitman draws upon pp. 303-4 of *The Continuity of American Poetry*.

Puritan anagrammatic poems: On pp. 29-42 of his book Pearce discusses Puritan anagrammatic elegies and the antinomian reaction against Puritanism.

De Tocqueville: The French politician, sociologist, and historian Alexis de Tocqueville (1805-1859) is the author of *Democracy in America* (1835). On p. 137 of *The Continuity of American Poetry*, Pearce compares De Tocqueville's view of Americans to that of the poet, essayist, and mystic Jones Very (1813-1880); the striking phrase "looked at the world with reference to themselves and not, like Frenchmen, at themselves with reference to the world" is adapted from a prize-winning 1836 essay by Very that Pearce quotes on p. 70. CT quotes Pearce's adaptation without acknowledgement.

Emerson: On p. 153 of *The Continuity of American Poetry*, Pearce cites this passage from the epigraph of R. W. B. Lewis's *The American Adam* (Chicago: U of Chicago P, 1955) [ii]. Lewis takes the statement from the journals of the philosopher, poet, and essayist Ralph Waldo Emerson (1803-1882).

"took its most appropriate shape. . .": CT quotes from p. 286 of *The Continuity of American Poetry*. The poet-critics John Crowe Ransom (1888-1974) and Allen Tate (1899-1979) were associated with the Fugitive movement and the New Criticism; Pearce discusses their work on pp. 318-34.

D. H. Lawrence: For D. H. Lawrence's review of WCW's *In the American Grain*, see Letter 1.

Hugh Kenner: On pp. 49-50 of *Gnomon: Essays on Contemporary Literature* (New York: McDowell, Obolensky, 1958), Hugh Kenner quotes the Abbess Hildegard passage from WCW's *Paterson* and says: "This is from Book IV; by so late in the poem, Dr. Williams has so thoroughly presented the actual Paterson world that he can afford to insert one measuring point from the European past without sentimental nostalgia." CT also echoes Kenner's remark in Letter 12.

"the explicitly Whitmanian problem: CT quotes from p. 289 of *The Continuity of American Poetry*.

Whittier's Snow Bound: On p. 230 of his book, Pearce describes *Snow-Bound: An Winter Idyll* (1866) by the poet, newspaper editor, and abolitionist John Greenleaf Whittier (1807-1892) as "the only great poem written by the Fireside Poets."

Yvor Winters: The poet and critic Yvor Winters (1900-1968) is the author of *Primitivism and Decadence* (1937), *In Defense of Reason* (1947), and *Collected Poems* (1952). Winters wrote in traditional metric and stanzaic forms, defended neoclassicism, and attacked romanticism and modern free verse.

Laura Riding: The poet, fiction writer, and critic Laura Riding (1901-1991) is the author of *A Survey of Modernist Poetry* (with Robert Graves, 1927) and *Collected*

Poems (1938). Between 1939 and 1970 she published no books, having renounced poetry as an inadequate linguistic medium of truth.

"Ecstasy affords the occasion": The epigraph for Chapter One of *The Continuity of American Poetry* consists of these words from Marianne Moore's poem "The Past to the Present."

"We have not yet sufficiently realised": This quotation comes from p. 8 of *The Continuity of American Poetry*.

Mr. Alvarez: In *The New Poetry: An Anthology* (Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1962), the English editor, poet, and critic Alfred Alvarez (b. 1929) opens the book with a selection of poems by Robert Lowell (1917-1977) and John Berryman (1914-1972). In his preface and introduction, Alvarez justifies his inclusion of the American writers by saying that they confront "problems that some of the new generation of poets over here are beginning to face." In particular, the Americans go "beyond the gentility principle" and deal with "experience sometimes on the edge of disintegration and breakdown." Alvarez was the principal English champion of the American "confessional" poets: Lowell, Berryman, Sylvia Plath, and Anne Sexton.

Pictures from Brueghel

Charles Tomlinson

Sir,—In an otherwise generous notice of W. C. Williams's *Pictures from Brueghel*, it was surprising to find your reviewer complaining of Williams's arbitrariness and giving as an example of his "eccentricities"

we searched through the
room for
that

sweetest odor and at
first could not
find its

source

Is anything more eccentric at work here than what the reviewer so justly admires in "Asphodel, that Greeny Flower"—Williams' quality of halting, yet artistically shaped bewilderment? The nature of the search is caught perfectly by the above quotation in the speed at which Williams permits the elements of the sentence to come into view. That expressive *rubato* brought about by "through the / room", the slightly longer break between "that" and the sudden exfoliating of "sweetest odor. . ." and the sense of a search still continuing reinforced by the gap between "find its" and "source", are all functional within the context.

Anyone who maintains the familiar English prejudice that one can only see and not hear effects of this kind, needs to experience the public readings of Robert Creeley or Jonathan Williams, poets who have absorbed W. C. Williams' example. Unfortunately, when Jonathan

Williams read at the American Embassy, prejudice prevailed and people went away troubled by his *staccato*—it was, in fact, a *rubato*, but we have still to learn to listen to this kind of verse delivery so challenging to all our own assumptions. In poems like Jonathan Williams', in Creeley's "The Gift" or "I know a Man", in Paul Blackburn's "The Encounter", the discovery of a mode of voice goes back to W. C. Williams and to such sensitivity of lineation as he achieves in verse like "Iris", the poem to which your reviewer takes exception.

Sir: This item originally appeared as a letter to the Editor of the *Times Literary Supplement* (May 21, 1964) 435. CT was responding to an anonymous review of WCW's *Pictures from Brueghel and Other Poems* (London: McGibbon and Kee, 1963) in the *TLS* for May 7, 1964. In it, the reviewer says of WCW: "His vocabulary seems idiomatic, to be sure, but it is continually beset by line-breaks and stanza units which at best seem tricky and at worst quite arbitrary." Quoting the same lines from WCW's "Iris" that CT reproduces here, the reviewer observes: "That Williams had no real need of such eccentricities is demonstrated by his 'Asphodel, the Greeny Flower' [sic], the touching poem of love and old age with which this volume closes. Here. . . [h]is characteristically loose, halting delivery seems rigorously shaped by the tentative, faintly bewildered emotional commitment which is the poem's task" (396). In the *TLS* for May 28, 1964, the reviewer replied to CT's defense of WCW, calling it "ingenious but surely indulgent" (455).

rubato: In musical performance, *rubato* ("robbed" time) is a departure from tempo that involves borrowing time from some notes in order to create separations or pauses between others. This slowing or stretching of time can generate an effect of spontaneity and freedom. With *rubato* the borrowed time is "repaid" later by a hastening of tempo, whereas with *staccato* the separation of the notes by silences is not heard as a departure from the prescribed tempo.

Robert Creeley: For Robert Creeley, see letter 25. CT included Creeley's poem "The Gift" in the "Black Mountain Poets" issue of *The Review* (January 1964).

Jonathan Williams: CT included three poems by the American poet, publisher, and lecturer Jonathan Williams (b. 1929) in the "Black Mountain Poets" issue of *The Review*.

Paul Blackburn's "The Encounter": The "Black Mountain Poets" issue of *The Review* also included "The Encounter" (1960), a poem by the American poet, translator, and editor Paul Blackburn (1926–1971).

Introduction to *Selected Poems* by William Carlos Williams

Charles Tomlinson

It was Ezra Pound, that indefatigable discoverer of talent, who first seized on the essential elements in Williams's poetry. Introducing Williams's second, still tentative, volume, *The Tempers*, in 1913, Pound quoted one of Williams's similes where he speaks of a thousand freshets:

. . . crowded
Like peasants to a fair
Clear skinned, wild from seclusion.

Pound has instinctively isolated here elements thoroughly characteristic of this poet's entire venture—poetic energy imagined as the rush of water; not so much Wordsworth's "spontaneous overflow of powerful feelings," but feelings "crowded," forcing and yet constrained by their own earth-bound track; a certain rustic uncouthness whose end is a celebration and which wears the stamp of locality. "The only universal," as Williams was to say later, "is the local as savages, artists and—to a lesser extent—peasants know."

The most interesting of Williams's early volumes, *Al Que Quiere!*, appeared in 1917, the same year as T. S. Eliot's *Prufrock and Other Observations*. Pound was there to salute the arrival of both volumes and to differentiate them:

Distinct and as different as possible from the orderly statements of an Eliot . . . are the poems of Carlos Williams. . . . If the sinuosities . . . of Misses Moore and Loy are difficult to follow I do not know what is to be said for Mr. Williams's ramifications and abruptnesses. I do not pretend to follow all of his

volts, jerks, sulks, balks, outbursts and jump-overs; but for all this roughness there remains with me the conviction that there is nothing meaningless in his book [*Al Que Quiere*], not a line. . .

Perhaps Pound overstates the "roughness" of Williams, but, in pointing out the "jerks, balks, outbursts and jump-overs," he has arrived at one of the earliest and most accurate formulations of what Williams's verse was about. Not only is "locality" (a sticking to New Jersey when Pound and Eliot had chosen European exile) the geographic source of Williams's poetry, but "locality," seen as the jerks and outbursts of speech rendered on to the here and now of the page, is the source of his lineation. In the imaginative play of Williams's poems, where the attention is frequently turned upon outward things, the sound structure of the poems which embody that attention is an expression of strains, breath pauses, bodily constrictions and releases. Thus Williams's "locality" begins with a somatic awareness, a physiological presence in time and space, and this in quite early poems. When he starts on his longest poem, *Paterson*, in the mid-forties, it is the remembrance of the act of walking through a given terrain which propels some of its best stretches, the gerund "walking" itself used as a repeated motif and, at one point, checked against the descriptions of an article, "Dynamic Posture," from *Journal of the American Medical Association*: "The body is tilted slightly forward from the basic standing position and the weight is thrown on the ball of the foot, while the other thigh is lifted and the leg and opposite arm are swung forward (fig. 6B). . . ." A sentence from later on in this article (quoted by M. Weaver in his *William Carlos Williams, The American Background*) would doubtless have appealed to Williams in his identification of poet and walker: "The good walker should be able to change pace, stop, start, turn, step up or down, twist or stoop, easily and quickly, without losing balance or rhythm. . . ." The Williams poem finds analogies for most of these movements.

The relation between subject and object appears in Williams in a series of images of physical strain—a poem from *Al Que Quiere*!, "Spring Strains," feels out its own balks and resistances against those of the scene outside where the swift flight of two birds is challenged, as:

the blinding and red-edged sun-blur—
creeping energy, concentrated
counterforce—welds sky, buds, trees,
rivets them in one puckering hold!

At the close, the birds exert their own counterforce of speed and lightness, breaking out of the riveted landscape

flung outward and up—disappearing suddenly!

—the poem imparting a verb-like force to its combined prepositions, “outward and up,” and ending, as so often in Williams, on a dangling clause that pulls the main clause towards incompleteness and asymmetry.

This predilection for the open-ended and asymmetrical leaves Williams free to accept the suggestion of his surroundings with their evidence of overlap and relativity—

roof out of line with sides
the yards cluttered
with old chicken wire, ashes,
furniture gone wrong;
the fences and outhouses
built of barrel-staves
and parts of boxes. . .

Instead of wishing simply to reform the poor (“It’s the anarchy of poverty / delights me. . .”), he senses there is a point where the imagination, partaking of this anarchy, could dance with it, could “lift” it to an answering form, but a form fully responsive to the waywardness and inconclusiveness of daily realities. The broken fringes of the city in “Morning” witness a sort of heroism among “diminished things,” humorously absurd:

And a church spire sketched on the sky,
of sheet-metal and open beams, to resemble
a church spire. . .

Williams hears in all this, and in the profusion of natural fact, a kind of music—“a vague melody / of harsh threads,” as he says in “Trees” where the tree which first catches his eye is “crooked,” “bent . . . from straining / against the bitter horizontals of / a north wind,” the jump-overs at the line breaks enacting the pressure of that straining. There is no romantic fusion of subject and object possible in this nature poem: the voices of the trees may be “blent willingly / against the heaving contra-bass / of the dark” but the contra-bass remains contra, the crooked tree warps itself “passionately to one side” and the poem still presses forward as Williams adds “in [its] eagerness,” the poem

like the tree dissociating itself from a blent music for that "melody / of harsh threads." "Bent" puns and rhymes eagerly against "blent" in this piece.

When Williams in his turn paid tribute to Pound, he saw the poet—himself and Pound included—as seeking a language which "will embody all the advantageous jumps, swiftesses, colours, movements of the day. . ." He was praising the collage element in the poetry of Pound's *A Draft of XXX Cantos*, but the terms of his praise ignore those other elements of archaism and of the *musée imaginaire* that Williams distrusted in his friend. Both Pound and Eliot, or so Williams felt, had lost contact—it was a word whose meaning he was to go on exploring—with their American roots: they had sold out to Europe that American renaissance of which Pound himself had spoken, one which he had prophesied would "overshadow the quattrocento." It was an old story, for the trend of the American mind "back to Europe" had grown in its appeal in nineteenth-century America. Williams, who feels the pull himself in his first novel, *A Voyage to Pagany*, reflected towards the end of his life:

The novels of Henry James featured this seeking of Europe by the heiresses of America. He himself, for complex reasons . . . fled to the assurances of Victorian England. It was understandable, it was even admirable in him. He became a distinguished citizen in the republic of letters and a great artist. But he left another world behind. He abandoned it.

Williams's poetry and novels explore an America his two most powerful contemporaries also left behind, in the raw merging of American pastoral and urban squalor. He described his struggle to make articulate that world, in *Paterson*, as "a reply to Greek and Latin with the bare hands." Williams exaggerates, of course, and as he himself well knew his insistence on "contact" and "locality" needed for its completion an awareness that was also European—the kind of awareness he recognized immediately in the reproduction of a painting by Juan Gris, with its cubist sharpness, its almost fastidious handling of a world of broken forms. "Contact" had been Whitman's word: "I am mad for it to be in contact with me," says Whitman of nature in *Song of Myself*. So is Williams. The difference lies in the *eruditus* of that *tactus eruditus* he speaks of in one poem. "A fact with him," says Kenneth Burke, "finds its justification in the trimness of the wording." Whitman is a great poet, but he is never trim. Trimness was something Williams could recognize and applaud in Juan Gris's "admirable simplicity and excellent design."

When he speaks in the prose parts of *Spring and All* (1923) of Whitman, the company he puts him into is that of two great Europeans, Gris and Cézanne, announcing that "Whitman's proposals are of the same piece with the modern trend toward imaginative understanding of life." At this point, the imagination for Williams was identified with the cubist re-structuring of reality; modern poetry with its ellipses, its confrontation of disparates, its use of verbal collages—a device both Pound and Eliot had used—provided direct analogies. In *Spring and All*, after a rapid transition from Gris, Cézanne and Whitman to Shakespeare, Williams tells us of the last named: "He holds no mirror up to nature but with his imagination rivals nature's composition with his own." Shakespeare, too, could be made to belong to the moment of cubism. This seems a far cry from "a reply to Greek and Latin with the bare hands."

Kenneth Rexroth, in an excellent and too little known essay, "The Influence of French Poetry on American" (reprinted in the Penguin critical anthology, *William Carlos Williams*, edited by the present writer) has commented on Williams's cubist allegiances and expresses the relation between these and Williams's stress on localism—"place" and "contact"—with great perspicacity:

Williams could be said to belong in the Cubist tradition—Imagism, Objectivism, the dissociation and rearrangement of the elements of concrete reality, rather than rhetoric or free association. But where Reverdy, Apollinaire, Salmon, Cendrars, Cocteau and Jacob are all urban, even megalopolitan, poets of that Paris which is the international market of objects of *vertu*, vice, and art, Williams has confined himself in single strictness to the life before his eyes—the life of a physician in a small town twenty miles from New York. In so doing, his localism has become international and timeless. His long quest for a completely defenseless simplicity of personal speech produces an idiom identical with that which is the end product of centuries of polish, refinement, tradition and revolution.

On the face of it, the inheritance Williams brings to cubism seems to be very close in spirit not only to Whitman but also to Emerson and Thoreau. If "contact" is re-explored, so is Emerson's attachment to the vernacular: "the speech of Polish mothers" was where Williams insisted he got his English from. "Colleges and books only copy the language which the field and work-yard made," said Emerson. Williams's famous "flatness" comes not from the field, but from the urban "work-yard" of New Jersey. As Hugh Kenner writes of Williams's characteristic diction: "That words set in Jersey speech rhythms mean less but mean it with greater finality, is Williams's great technical perception."

Emerson seems to have prepared the ground for Williams's other war-cry, "No ideas but in things" with his "Ask the fact for the form." Thoreau sounds yet closer with: "The roots of letters are things." Again Emerson tells over things—"The meal in the firkin; the milk in the pan; the ballad in the street; the news of the boat. . ."—in the shape of a list very like Williams's "rigamaroles," as he calls his poems. "Bare lists of words," says Emerson, "are found suggestive to an imaginative mind." When Williams, long after Emerson and after Whitman's application of this, constructed "list" poems, he came in for suspicion, as in the interview which he prints as part of *Paterson* 5 and in which, defending what amounts to a grocery list that forms the jagged pattern of one of his later poems, he concludes: "Anything is good material for poetry. Anything. I've said it time and time again."

Paterson 5 came out in 1958. Years before, Williams had formulated his kind of poem made out of anything and with a jagged pattern, in the 1920 preface to *Kora in Hell*, when he wrote that a poem is "tough by no quality it borrows from a logical recital of events nor from the events themselves but solely from the attenuated power which draws perhaps many broken things into a dance giving them thus a full being." He was often to return to the idea of poem as dance. If, as with Emerson, Williams seems to "ask the fact for the form," the form, once it comes, is free of the fact, is a *dance above the fact*. After *Kora in Hell* he had another shot at the formula in the prose of *Spring and All*, where he concludes of John of Gaunt's speech in *Richard II* that "his words are related not to their sense as objects adherent to his son's welfare or otherwise but as a dance over the body of his condition accurately accompanying it."

J. Hillis Miller in his book *Poets of Reality* has argued that Williams marks an historic moment for modern poetry in that his work sees the disappearance of all dualism. If it is not from dualism it is yet from a duality that much of the interest of his work arises: the words "accurately accompany" a perception of the forms of reality, they dance over or with these forms, but it is the gap between words and forms that gives poetry its chance to exist and to go on existing. Williams's most truncated and Zen-like expression of this fact comes in the tiny

so much depends
upon

a red wheel
barrow

glazed with rain
water

beside the white ·
chickens

What depends on the red wheelbarrow for Williams is the fact that its presence can be rendered over into words, that the perception can be slowed down and meditated on by regulating, line by line, the gradual appearance of these words. The imagination “accurately accompanies” the wheelbarrow, or whatever facets of reality attract Williams, by not permitting too ready and emotional a fusion with them. When things go badly the imagination retreats into a subjective anguish—

to an empty, windswept place
without sun, stars or moon
but a peculiar light as of thought

that spins a dark fire—
whirling upon itself. . .
(“These”)

But when the dance with facts suffices, syntax, the forms of grammar, puns, the ambiguous pull between words unpunctuated or divided by line-endings, these all contribute to—accompany—the richness of a reality one can never completely fuse with, but which affords a resistance whereby the I can know itself.

One has in Williams’s best verse a vivid sense of what Olson calls “the elements and minims of language,” down to the syllabic components or “the diphthong/ae” (“To Have Done Nothing”). It is this drama of elements, played across the ends of frequently short lines, which gives to Williams’s “free verse” its cohesiveness, and intensifies what Olson calls

The contingent motion of
each line as it
moves with—or against—
the whole—working
particularly out of its immediacy.

Williams insisted that he did not write free verse, of course. As early as 1913 he was saying: “I do not believe in *vers libre*, this contradiction in terms. Either the motion continues or it does not continue, either there is rhythm or no rhythm.” In the same essay (“Speech Rhythm,”

quoted by Weaver, pp. 82-83), Williams writes that, in an *Odyssey*, "rightly considered," "no part in its excellence but partakes of the essential nature of the whole":

This is the conception of the action that I want. In the other direction, inward: Imagination creates an image, point by point, piece by piece, segment by segment—into a whole, living. But each part as it plays into its neighbor, each segment into its neighbor segment and every part into every other, causing the whole—exists naturally in rhythm, and as there are waves there are tides and as there are ridges in the sand there are bars after bars. . .

This intuitive conception of the kind of poetic writing he sought gets closer to essentials than Williams's later and self-defeating attempts to define the "variable foot," that "relative measure" which ends by being what Williams said *vers libre* was, a contradiction in terms. It is "the contingent motion of / each line" and what Robert Creeley has referred to as the "contentual emphases" of each line that give life to Williams's verse, rather than any prosodic notion of feet. These emphases are brought to bear most consistently perhaps in relatively short poems. *Paterson* has its incidental finenesses, but there are stretches when one feels, as in others of the more lengthy pieces, that the dance has broken down. At the same time, some of the longer poems, unachieved as a whole, frequently contain passages of great brilliance. Yvor Winters is reminded by Williams of the brevity of a Herrick, which is to narrow Williams's range somewhat unduly; after all, he is capable of the extended range of poems like "The Crimson Cyclamen" and "Elena." The shorter poems are certainly more proof against that meditative self-regard which elsewhere often makes for sentimental proliferation. Even a poem initially as fine as "The Orchestra" runs aground on the most banal professions of innocence.

Williams may not have been capable of the unity of *The Waste Land*, but, as Octavio Paz insists, introducing his translations of Williams in *Veinte Poemas*, "The greatness of a poet is not to be measured by the scale but by the intensity and the perfection of his works. Also by his vivacity. Williams is the author of the most *vivid* poems of modern American poetry." And the vivacity arises, one might add, from the unexpectedness of Williams's apparently wayward forms. How, for example, in "Raindrops on a Briar," did one get from the opening statement to those waterdrops "ranged upon the arching stems / irregularly as an accompaniment," and yet wasn't that devious track the poem's most exact way of saying what it had to and by a superb use of form?

Williams's attitude to form rather resembles his attitude to friendship, which should be, he says, "dangerous—uncertain—made of many questionable crossties. I think, that might fail it. But, while they last, give it a good cellular structure—paths, private connections between the members—full of versatility." This passage comes from Williams's *Autobiography*—Chapter 49, "Friendship." In Chapter 50, "Projective Verse," it is silently transfigured into an ideal of artistic form, and this ideal is seen as part and parcel of Williams's conception of locality. Chapter 50 is, in many ways, pivotal to the book, for, in using Charles Olson's conception of "composition by field," Williams does so—and very tactfully—against an implied background of why his forms were not readily understood in his own country or ours, why "*The Criterion* had no place for me," why Eliot's *The Waste Land* had seemed to him "the great catastrophe to our letters . . . Eliot had turned his back on the possibility of reviving my world." That world seemed to Williams to receive its recognition in Olson's "Projective Verse" essay, with its preference for an explorative, syllable-based verse and its invitation "to step back here to this place of the elements and minims of language . . . to engage speech where it is least careless—and least logical." In Chapter 50 Williams juxtaposes "this place of elements" with an *actual* place—and the leap is beautifully justified in the chapter as a whole—with the painter Charles Sheeler taking over a small stone house on a ravaged New York estate and making of it "a cell, a seed of intelligent and feeling security." "The poem," says Williams, "is our objective, the secret at the heart of the matter—as Sheeler's small house, re-organized, is the heart of the gone estate of the Lowes. . . ." Sheeler and his Russian wife and what they do with the local conditions are vibrant with meaning for Williams as a poet, and the form of the chapter lays bare that meaning: "It is ourselves we organize in this way not against the past or for the future or even for survival but for integrity of understanding to insure persistence, to give the mind its stay." Coming, as it does, in the last lap of the book, this makes a fine conscious formulation for the many years of groping with the potentials of language and it balances four-square in the American locality a mind that had gone back to it armed—despite Williams's frequent protests—by Europe. The figures who stand out in those autobiographical pages are Joyce and Brancusi as well as Sheeler and Demuth: Paris counterpoints Rutherford and New York.

Of all the American modernists Williams was the most tardy in receiving recognition. His writing lifetime was dominated by the liter-

ary criteria of T. S. Eliot and the New Criticism, in neither of whose terminology was there a place for the kind of thing Williams was concerned with doing. Parker Tyler imagines Williams explaining why T. S. Eliot's theory of the objective correlative was not for him and where its shortcomings lay: "My theory of poetry was that it arises from immediate environment, and in the case of *my* environment, America, the poetic formulas for familiar (or 'objective correlative') emotions did not exist. Why not? Because the emotions themselves, and the very imagery of their implicit situations, were elusive and unformed."

To name what possessed no name, to avoid surrendering oneself "into the inverted cone of waning energy . . . [and] fly off at last into nonentity, general deracinate conclusions," were the tasks that Williams had recognized early on—earlier, in fact, than the 1913 essay, "Speech Rhythm," quoted above. *How* early one realizes in his accounts of his undergraduate poem (which he burned) about the prince who is abducted and taken to an unknown country—Williams's inarticulate America—to wake confronted by all the problems of language and cultural identity that Williams himself was to face: "No one was there to inform him of his whereabouts and when he did begin to encounter passers-by, they didn't even understand, let alone speak his language. He could recall nothing of the past. . . So he went on, homeward or seeking a home that was his own, all this through a 'foreign' country whose language was barbarous."

This myth would seem to lend itself to a long psychic alienation. But one sees Williams breaking through by meeting the demands of day-to-day existence, never too involved in himself to feel the ballast of place, people and things. The source of his resilience recalls his hero, the Jesuit Père Rasles, among the Indians, of *In the American Grain*: "THIS is a moral source not reckoned with, peculiarly sensitive and daring in its close embrace of native things. . . For everything his fine sense, blossoming, thriving, opening, reviving—not shutting out—was tuned. He speaks of his struggles with their language, its peculiar beauties, '*je ne sais quoi d'énergique*,' he cited its tempo, the form of its genius with gusto, with admiration, with generosity."

The myth of the prince and the necessity of a counter-statement to it underlie Williams's work. In his *Autobiography*, the counter-statement reappears in the final pages when he drives out to look at the site of the poem, *Paterson*: "The Falls let out a roar as it crashed upon the rocks at its base. In the imagination this roar is a speech or a voice, a speech in particular; it is the poem itself that is the answer."

Ezra Pound: Pound's introduction to WCW's *The Tempers* is reprinted in CT's *William Carlos Williams: A Critical Anthology* 39–40 and in WCW's *I Wanted to Write a Poem*, ed. Edith Heal (1958; London: Jonathan Cape, 1967) 23–24.

"spontaneous overflow": In his Preface to *Lyrical Ballads* (1802), the English poet William Wordsworth (1770–1850) declares that "all good poetry is the spontaneous overflow of powerful feelings."

"The only universal": CT quotes from WCW's "A Tentative Statement," *Little Review* 12, 2 (May 1929): 95–98.

Pound was there: CT quotes from Ezra Pound's "Books Current: The New Poetry," *Future II*, 7 (June 1918): 188–90; rpt. in Pound's *Instigations* (1920) and in *Ezra Pound's Poetry and Prose: Contributions to Periodicals*, arr. Lea Baechler, A. Walton Litz, and James Longenbach, 10 vols. (New York: Garland, 1991), III, 115–17.

"Dynamic Posture": In Book Two, Part I of *Paterson* (1948), WCW quotes from Beckett Howorth, "Dynamic Posture," *Journal of the American Medical Association* 131, 17 (August 24, 1946): 1398–1404. This source was first identified by Mike Weaver, *William Carlos Williams: An American Background* (Cambridge: Cambridge UP, 1971) 206. The first of CT's quotations comes from *Paterson*; the second, from Weaver.

roof out of line: These lines come from WCW's "Pastoral" (1916), which is the opening poem in CT's edition of WCW's *Selected Poems*.

"It's the anarchy of poverty": These are the opening lines of WCW's "The Poor" (1938); in CT's edition of WCW's *Selected Poems*, they appear on p. 117.

tribute to Pound: CT quotes from WCW's "Excerpts from a Critical Sketch: A Draft of XXX Cantos by Ezra Pound," *Symposium II*, 2 (April 1931): 257–63; rpt. *Selected Essays* 105–12, in which the passage quoted by CT appears on p. 109.

"overshadow the quattrocento": In his 1915 essay "The Renaissance," Pound urges Americans to patronize the arts: "If you so endow sculptors and writers you will begin for America an age of awakening which will over-shadow the quattrocento"; see *Literary Essays of Ezra Pound*, ed. T. S. Eliot (London: Faber and Faber, 1954) 224. Marianne Moore quotes the passage in an essay on WCW entitled "A Poet of the Quattrocento," *The Dial* 82 (1927): 213. CT reprints Moore's essay in *William Carlos Williams: A Critical Anthology* 92–94, and he reproduces Moore's quotation from Pound's essay on p. 27 of the same volume.

The novels of Henry James: CT quotes from WCW's "The Future of the Creative Arts," *University of Buffalo Studies* XIX, 4 (February 1952): 111.

"a reply to Greek and Latin": In the epigraph to *Paterson: Book One* (1946), WCW describes his poem as "a reply to Greek and Latin with the bare hands."

Juan Gris: In Sections VI and VIII of *Spring and All* (1923), WCW celebrates the work of the Spanish painter Juan Gris (1889–1927) and the French painter Paul Cézanne (1839–1906), and compares it to that of Walt Whitman. In *William Carlos Williams: A Critical Anthology* 72–73, CT reprints the passages he quotes here.

Whitman: In Section 2 of "Song of Myself" (1855), Walt Whitman says of the earth's atmosphere, "I will go to the bank by the wood and become undisguised and naked, / I am mad for it to be in contact with me." From this point on, CT's introduction incorporates material from his earlier essay, "Dr. Williams' Practice," *Encounter* 29 (November 1967): 66-70.

tactus eruditus: Latin, "educated touch." WCW uses the phrase in his poem "Della Primavera Trasportata al Morale" (1934).

Kenneth Burke: CT quotes from "Heaven's First Law," a review of WCW's *Sour Grapes* by the American philosopher and critic Kenneth Burke (1897-1973) in *The Dial* 72 (February 1922): 197-200. CT reprints Burke's review in *William Carlos Williams: A Critical Anthology* 61-64.

Shakespeare: WCW praises Shakespeare's imagination in Section XI of *Spring and All*. CT reproduces the passage in *William Carlos Williams: A Critical Anthology* 75.

Kenneth Rexroth: The first English-language publication of "The Influence of French Poetry on American" by the American poet and critic Kenneth Rexroth (1905-1982) was in his *Assays* (1961). The passage quoted here appears in CT's *William Carlos Williams: A Critical Anthology* 259.

Emerson and Thoreau: All of CT's quotations in this paragraph and the next from the American Transcendentalist philosophers and essayists Ralph Waldo Emerson (1803-1882) and Henry David Thoreau (1817-1862) may be found in the Emerson chapter of Tony Tanner's *The Reign of Wonder: Naivety and Reality in American Literature* (Cambridge: Cambridge UP, 1965) 38-42, 58. "Colleges and books. . ." comes from Emerson's "The American Scholar" (1837), rpt. in his *Works* (London: George Routledge and Sons, 1903), I, 99. Tanner cites Emerson's "Ask the fact for the form" from Norman Foerster's essay, "Emerson and the Organic Principle in Art," *PMLA* 41 (1926): 197. Thoreau's "The roots of letters are things" is quoted from his *Journal* for October 16, 1859; see *The Writings of Henry David Thoreau*, 20 vols. (Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1906), XVIII, 389. Emerson's "The meal is in the firkin. . ." comes from "The American Scholar," *Works*, I, 111, and the source of "Bare lists of words" is "The Poet," *Works*, III, 22.

"the speech of Polish mothers": In his *Autobiography* 311, WCW says that his language comes "from the mouths of Polish mothers." CT converts this phrase to "the speech of Polish mothers" here and in "Letter to Dr. Williams" (see "A Selection of Poems in Three-Ply Cadence").

Hugh Kenner: CT quotes from Hugh Kenner, "A Note on *The Great American Novel*," *Gnomon* (New York: McDowell, Obolensky, 1958) 35. CT quotes the passage again in *William Carlos Williams: A Critical Anthology* 34.

"No ideas but in things": In Book One, Part I of *Paterson* (1946), WCW writes, "Say it, no ideas but in things." The passage appears on p. 231 of CT's edition of WCW's *Selected Poems*.

grocery list: In Book Five, Part II of *Paterson* (1958), WCW reproduces a 1957 interview in which Mike Wallace quotes a passage from WCW's "Two Pendants for

the Ears: Elena" (1949) and calls it "a fashionable grocery list." WCW agrees with Wallace's term and offers the justification quoted by CT.

preface to Kora in Hell: This passage from WCW's "Prologue" to *Kora in Hell: Improvisations* is reprinted in CT's *William Carlos Williams: A Critical Anthology* 46.

John of Gaunt's speech: This passage from section XXV of WCW's *Spring and All* is reprinted in CT's *William Carlos Williams: A Critical Anthology* 76.

J. Hillis Miller: In *Poets of Reality* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard UP, 1965) J. Hillis Miller argues that the poetry of WCW goes beyond "romanticism and the dualism which usually accompanies it." CT reprints some of Miller's chapter on WCW in *William Carlos Williams: A Critical Anthology* 373–81.

so much depends: Originally published as the untitled twenty-second section of *Spring and All* (1923), this poem is reprinted as "The Red Wheelbarrow" in WCW's *Collected Earlier Poems* (1951) and in CT's edition of WCW's *Selected Poems* 57.

to an empty, windswept place: WCW's poem "These" (1938) appears in CT's edition of WCW's *Selected Poems* 119–20.

Olson: The phrase "the elements and minims of language" comes from an essay entitled "Projective Verse" (1950) by the American poet and critic Charles Olson (1910–1970). WCW reprints the essay as Chapter 50 of his *Autobiography* (1951), where the quoted words appear on p. 331. CT quotes the passage at greater length later in his "Introduction" to WCW's *Selected Poems*. The passage beginning "The contingent motion. . ." comes from Olson's *Letters for Origin, 1950–1956*, ed. Albert Glover (London: Cape Goliard Press, 1969) 85. In a letter to Hugh Witemeyer of December 7, 1997, CT says that he first encountered the lines in Donald Wesling, "The Prosodies of Free Verse," *Twentieth-Century Literature in Retrospect*, ed. Reuben A. Brower (Cambridge, MA: Harvard UP, 1971) 163.

"the diphthong/ae": Originally published as the untitled sixth section of WCW's *Spring and All* (1923), this poem is reprinted as "To Have Done Nothing" in *Collected Earlier Poems* (1951) and in CT's edition of WCW's *Selected Poems* 47–48. "The diphthong/ae" renders the sound of the first-person singular pronoun "I."

"Speech Rhythm": In *William Carlos Williams: The American Background* 82–83, Mike Weaver prints this previously unpublished essay by WCW.

Robert Creeley: For Robert Creeley, see Letter 25. In a letter to Hugh Witemeyer of December 7, 1997, CT says that he recalled the phrase "contentual emphasis" from his conversations with Creeley.

Yvor Winters: For Yvor Winters, see p. 84. The English poet Robert Herrick lived from 1591 to 1634. In "Poetry of Feeling," *Kenyon Review* 1 (January 1939): 104–7, Winters writes: "If I may venture . . . to make a prediction, it is this: that Williams will prove as nearly indestructible as Herrick, that the end of the present century will see him securely established, along with Stevens, as one of the two best poets of his generation." Winters' essay is reprinted in *William Carlos Williams: A Collection of Critical Essays*, ed. J. Hillis Miller (Englewood Cliffs, New Jersey:

Prentice Hall, 1966) 66–69. CT quotes Winters' "prediction" again in *William Carlos Williams: A Critical Anthology* 36.

"*The Crimson Cyclamen*" and "*Elena*": CT includes "The Crimson Cyclamen" (1936), an eight-page elegy for Charles Demuth, in his edition of WCW's *Selected Poems* 103–10. "Elena," a lengthy elegy for WCW's mother, is the second part of "Two Pendants for the Ears" (1949).

"*The Orchestra*": "I love you. My heart / is innocent. And this / the first day of the world!" writes WCW in "The Orchestra" (1952). Despite his reservations about the poem, CT included it in his edition of WCW's *Selected Poems* 181–83.

Octavio Paz: In the introduction to William Carlos Williams, *Veinte Poemas*, trans. Octavio Paz (Mexico City: Era, 1973) 23, the Mexican poet, translator, critic, historian, and diplomat Octavio Paz (1914–1998) writes: "La grandeza de un poeta no se mide por el tamaño sino por la intensidad y la perfección de sus obras. También por su vivacidad. Williams es el autor de los poemas mas vivos de la poesia norteamericano moderna."

"*Raindrops on a Briar*": The "opening statement" of "Raindrops on a Briar" (1947) is: "I, a writer, at one time hipped on / painting, did not consider / the effects." See CT's edition of WCW's *Selected Poems* 152–53.

Autobiography: CT quotes from WCW's *Autobiography* 320.

The Criterion: CT quotes from WCW's *Autobiography* 175, 146, 174. T. S. Eliot edited *The Criterion* from 1922 to 1939. Nothing authored by WCW ever appeared in *The Criterion*.

Charles Sheeler: CT quotes from WCW's *Autobiography* 332–33. WCW first met the American painter and photographer Charles Sheeler (1883–1965) in 1923. In 1939 Sheeler married the Russian dancer Musya Sokolov-Isachenko; around 1942 he moved from Ridgefield, Connecticut, to the Lowe estate in New York's Hudson River Valley near Irvington.

Joyce and Brancusi . . . and Demuth: WCW met the Irish novelist James Joyce (1882–1941) and the Romanian-born French sculptor Constantin Brancusi (1876–1957) during his trip to Paris in 1924. WCW first met the American painter Charles Demuth (1883–1935) in Philadelphia in 1903; see *Autobiography*, chapters 11 and 26.

Parker Tyler: CT quotes from "The Poet of Paterson Book One," *Briarcliff Quarterly* 3 (October 1946) 169, by the American poet, novelist, and critic Parker Tyler (1904–1974). CT includes part of Tyler's review in *William Carlos Williams: A Critical Anthology* 157–58 and quotes this passage from it on p. 31 of the same volume.

"into the inverted cone: We have not identified the source of this quotation.

his undergraduate poem: CT quotes from WCW's *Autobiography* 59–60.

Père Rasles: CT quotes from WCW's *In the American Grain* (1925; rpt. New York: New Directions, 1966) 121.

Autobiography: CT quotes from WCW's *Autobiography* 392.

William Carlos Williams
An Address in Honor of His Induction
into the Poets' Corner
of the Cathedral Church of
St. John the Divine
25 October 1992

Charles Tomlinson

Williams was the most approachable of men. But when I was a young writer I hesitated to approach the great because I knew their time was precious. Instead, I wrote a verse letter to Williams which appeared in the little magazine *Spectrum* to which he also contributed. His reply was swift and its style was truly the man, impulsive, almost boyish, prepared for friendship, feeling that, despite disparities of age and literary experience, we were united by a common pursuit:

Through Hugh Kenner I have just become acquainted with your name. God be praised! for to meet an Englishman to whom my name is not anathema is almost to be classed by me as an event. . . . It signalizes the advent of someone who may turn out to be a friend. . . . We'll exchange letters and find out more about each other as we go along.

We did, as he hopefully foresaw, become friends. We met and we corresponded. And we cheered each other along—I, a young poet unnoticed in the land of my birth, and he an old poet, incapacitated by strokes and still resided in America, advising the younger man, "Take care of yourself. Poetry is a tough racket."

I have said that with Williams the style was the man. He almost appears to be the direct refutation of T. S. Eliot's dictum that "the

more perfect the artist, the more completely separate in him will be the man who suffers and the mind which creates." Williams was also supposed to be a poet whose style was not for export and he, of course, encouraged this notion, by his insistence on what he called the American language and his superstition that Pound and Eliot had sold out to Europe.

As an American there were three things which he communicated to anyone who spoke English and could hear: first, a propriety of cadence which, when he was writing well, encompassed its subject with elegance; secondly, the attention he brought to bear on single words and their placement within the unfolding lineation of his poems; thirdly, an unusual freshness, as if what he was telling you about he had only just experienced. All three qualities appear in

YOUNG SYCAMORE

I must tell you
this young tree
whose round and firm trunk
between the wet

pavement and the gutter
(where water
is trickling) rises
bodily

into the air with
one undulant
thrust half its height—
and then

dividing and waning
sending out
young branches on
all sides—

hung with cocoons
it thins
till nothing is left of it
but two

eccentric knotted
twigs
bending forward
hornlike at the top

Eliot is correct, of course. There does exist a remove between the event seen or suffered and writing about it. Part of Williams' artistry is to give us the illusion that things are otherwise. But Williams had not just been outside to look at a young sycamore—he had seen a photograph of a young tree by Stieglitz, a photograph whose angle already processed the primacy of "the thing" on which Williams insisted. And if the drafts of the poem exist, they are probably as worked over and revised as most of Williams' drafts. His artistry can persuade us that he is artless, as when he shows us something that would have escaped the glance of another poet:

THE TERM

A rumpled sheet
of brown paper
about the length

and apparent bulk
of a man was
rolling with the

wind slowly over
and over in
the street as

a car drove down
upon it and
crushed it to

the ground. Unlike
a man it rose
again rolling

with the wind over
and over to be as
it was before.

Marianne Moore entitled one of her essays on Williams "Things Others Never Notice." And she writes of him, along with Wallace Stevens, that his "way of saying what he says is as important as what is said." Williams maintained throughout his life a quality which Hopkins believed necessary to poetry: it must *bid* us. This quality, Hopkins insists, is "the art or virtue of saying everything right to or at the hearer, interesting him, holding him in the attitude of correspondent."

We are bidden by Williams' poems of immediate perception and also by his more retrospective vein where things are less to the fore and his tone of voice, "his way of saying," is what matters, as in my final quotation from *Paterson* Book Two:

The descent beckons
 as the ascent beckoned
 Memory is a kind
 of accomplishment
 a sort of renewal
 even
 an initiation, since the spaces it opens are new places
 inhabited by hordes
 heretofore unrealized,
 of new kinds—
 since their movements
 are towards new objectives
 (even though formerly they were abandoned)
 No defeat is made up entirely of defeat—since
 the world it opens is always a place
 formerly
 unsuspected. A
 world lost,
 a world unsuspected
 beckons to new places
 and no whiteness (lost) is so white as the memory
 of whiteness.

a verse letter: For CT's "Letter to Dr. Williams" (1957), see pp. xiii-xiv and 139-40.

"Through Hugh Kenner: From Letter 3.

"Take care of yourself: From Letter 2.

T. S. Eliot's dictum: CT quotes from T. S. Eliot's essay "Tradition and the Individual Talent" (1919).

Stieglitz: Alfred Stieglitz, German-American photographer, publisher, and gallery-owner (1864-1946). The resemblance between WCW's "Young Sycamore" and Stieglitz's 1902 photograph "Spring Showers" was noted by Bram Dijkstra, *The Hieroglyphics of a New Speech: Cubism, Stieglitz, and the Early Poetry of William Carlos Williams* (Princeton: Princeton UP, 1969) 190-91.

Marianne Moore: In "Things Others Never Notice," *Poetry* 44 (1934): 103-6, a review of WCW's *Collected Poems 1921-1931* (1934), Marianne Moore says, "Dr. Williams does not compromise, and Wallace Stevens is another resister whose way of saying is as important as what is said." Moore's review is reprinted in *William Carlos Williams: A Collection of Critical Essays*, ed. J. Hillis Miller (Englewood

Cliffs, New Jersey: Prentice-Hall, 1966) 44–46, and in CT's *William Carlos Williams: A Critical Anthology* 130–33.

Hopkins: In a letter to Robert Bridges of November 4, 1882, the English poet and priest Gerard Manley Hopkins (1844–1889) speaks of “a nameless quality which is of the first importance both in oratory and in drama: I sometimes call it *bidding*. I mean the art or virtue of saying everything right to or at the hearer, interesting him, holding him in the attitude of correspondent or addressed or at least concerned”; see *The Letters of Gerard Manley Hopkins to Robert Bridges*, ed. Claude Collier Abbott (London: Oxford UP, 1955) 160.

The descent beckons: This passage from Book Two, Part III of *Paterson* (1948) marks the first appearance in WCW's work of the three-ply cadence or triadic measure used in many of his later poems. In *I Wanted to Write a Poem*, ed. Edith Heal (1958; London: Jonathan Cape, 1967) 84, WCW reproduces the passage and says that it “brought all my thinking about free verse to a head.” CT reprints the passage in *William Carlos Williams: A Critical Anthology* 162–64. His quotation of it here is an act of personal homage, since WCW's three-ply poems were the first that CT admired and imitated (see “A Selection of Poems in Three-Ply Cadence”).

Tomlinson's Use of the Williams Triad

Paul Mariani

In an issue of *The Review* a few years back, there was a cartoon of the English poet, Charles Tomlinson, sporting a Mexican sombrero and poncho, obviously looking stiff and a bit uncomfortable in such foreign garb.¹ He has been made to look there very much like the English tourist on holiday in New Mexico. It is, of course, of the very nature of cartoons to flatten out and exaggerate in order to make their point. The point here is that Tomlinson reversed what had been, until his generation (with a few notable exceptions), the acceptable manner of things: New World neophytes settling, like James, Pound, and Eliot, in London as the most natural place to learn their craft. Instead, Tomlinson has come to the New World in search of becoming, at least in terms of his craft, more "Americanized." This exchange has proved to be, however, a somewhat risky affair. We have, for measure, the earlier examples—and only partial successes—of Lawrence and Auden, who also attempted to export American homemade goods, and Tomlinson, with a great deal of good will, seems to have grafted the new onto the old stock only imperfectly.

Nonetheless, Tomlinson may yet prove to be—for he is just fifty—what Calvin Bedient has described him as: "the most considerable British poet to have made his way since the Second World War."² If a term like "considerable" tends to wobble, however, Tomlinson is, truly, a prodigious observer—of nature, of artifact—possessed of the painter's acute eye for design that we particularly associate with the Ruskin of *Modern Painters* and with Hopkins in his journals. For twenty years Tomlinson has set himself squarely against the English voices we evoke most readily when we consider poetry written in Great Britain since Dylan Thomas' death in a New York hospital in 1953. This difference was most marked in the fifties, when Tomlinson spoke out repeatedly

against the rhetorical resonances of New Apocalypticism like Thomas and Barker as well as against the prevalent *Kulturbolscheismus*, the "common style" of poets like Larkin and Amis. These latter two Movement writers, made very much aware of an England greatly diminished in grandeur, of an island nation besieged by the cries of nationalism at its own doors and reminded daily of its drab industrial sprawl and its blighted pastoral landscapes, had become by the late fifties the recognized spokesmen of Tomlinson's generation. To further isolate and make himself even more "unseasonable" (the term is Bedient's), Tomlinson turned his back on what he considered other excesses: those associated with the Liverpool scene and the Beatles, as well as those being championed by the British critic A. Alvarez in the sixties, the American confessionals.³

Constitutionally, Tomlinson is quiet, reflective, meditative, a poet in some ways like Larkin, who also distrusts excesses of any kind: apocalyptic moments, trombone finales. He is a poet of true intellectual powers, a classicist, really, whose natural affinities seem closer to the late Augustans, and to Donald Davie and Yvor Winters in our own time. This essential reserve, however, this kind of latter-day poetic Toryism, has—at least in my reading of the poetry—acted as a weakness as well as a strength. When Tomlinson was still in his mid-twenties and looking hard for suitable models, he began to read seriously and to champion several of the American modernists, including, most notably, Stevens, Pound, Marianne Moore, and Williams—figures, as he has called them, of energetic contemplation. Some of these influences are readily apparent in any reading of Tomlinson's poetry, and anyone who has even thumbed through *The Necklace* (1955) will feel that he has entered into a strange, still, imagistic world that looks very much like the world of Stevens' "Thirteen Ways of Looking at a Blackbird." For lines like the following are consciously playing with the contours and rhythms of Stevens' "The Snow Man":

when the truth is not good enough
We exaggerate. Proportions

Matter. It is difficult to get them right.
There must be nothing
Superfluous, nothing which is not elegant
And nothing which is if it is merely that.⁴

Thus, about a dozen years ago, Tomlinson exported a product as recognizably "American" as the variously called staggered tercet, three-

ply step-down line, or triple-decker, which we associate with Williams' late phase. Williams first used the staggered tercet in the "Descent" passage in *Paterson II* and perfected it in such classic pieces as "Asphodel, That Greeny Flower," "The Ivy Crown," and "To Daphne and Virginia." We know by now, of course, that Williams himself had the examples of Mayakovsky and of Pound's translations of Guido Cavalcanti's *Donna mi priegha* as models for the staggered tercet, but it was Williams who, for us, made the form his own.⁵ Making it his "own" should not, of course, be construed to mean that no other poet can use it, but that it has its own internal structures, its own poetic logic, which cannot be indefinitely reworked and still be expected to function as a form.⁶

Tomlinson, in a gesture amounting to homage, attempted in *A Peopled Landscape* (published in 1963, the year Williams died) to adapt Williams' tercets and make them his own. Hayden Carruth, however, reviewing Tomlinson's volume for *Poetry*, was particularly upset that anyone, much less an Englishman, should have tried to use this form.⁷ Carruth misses the point, for Williams' aim was to extend the limits of the poetic line and to pass it on as part of a heritage springing out of his own experience with the American language, formalized into a variable pattern. The fact that Tomlinson experimented with the pattern only in this one volume and in his contemporaneous book of translations from Machado suggests that he had achieved only a modest success and was, at best, only moderately satisfied with his results.⁸

It is not really surprising that Tomlinson should have tried this form, for it is Williams' poems written in staggered tercets, with their meditative pace, their sense of ceremony, and even, in Tomlinson's sense, their civility, that have most appealed to the British. In fact, if one were pressed to point to the one poem that most Englishmen might "safely" enjoy—in a country where Williams' works have met with only mild success, and then, only since the poet's death—that poem would be "Asphodel." Certainly, the few reviewers who even deigned to notice Williams in the sixties when his work finally found a British publisher, pointed to the grace, to the "traditional" qualities of this late poem. Finally, they said, this American had come round to their way of thinking. He had ceased his long, weary search for an American language and American forms and had entered at last into the venerable English meditative tradition. In short, they were still not hearing Williams' distinctive voice, nor had they managed to chart his particular homefront strategies.

Admittedly, Williams' staggered tercets look easy to imitate. What makes the form distinctive, however, is the masterful sense of open-ended meditation, of mellow rambling counterpointed sharply against a grid of hesitations; so that we get the sense of a mind quietly but desperately seeking the fiction of an inner peace. This, decidedly, is not Tomlinson's own cast of mind: his intellectual powers are sharper, colder, more disciplined, more self-evidently in control of the utterance. There is in much of Tomlinson's work the sense of a finely controlled desire for the formal means necessary to modify his own poetic line, a means he does not seem to have been able to find among his own British contemporaries; so that he has turned to the older generation of American poets. When, however, he used a form as distinctive as the staggered tercet, what he wanted was a "propriety of cadence," a measure he could adapt to reinforce, shore up, what with hindsight looks like a conservative pastoral vision. The result is that these step-down lines feel peculiarly artificial when measured against Williams' best poems in the mode.

Compare, for instance, Williams' "Address:" from *Journey to Love* (1955) with Tomlinson's "The Picture of J. T. in a Prospect of Stone," from *A Peopled Landscape*. Both poems use the staggered tercet, and both are addresses of sorts: Williams' to his younger son, Paul, then in his late thirties, and Tomlinson's to his young daughter. Consider, too, that Williams was in his early seventies, near the end of his career when he wrote his poem, and that Tomlinson was only in his mid-thirties and at the beginning of his when he sketched his "Picture." Moreover, a man gives advice to another man, even a son thirty years his junior, with more deference and tentativeness than he uses when he is addressing, even indirectly, a little girl. Still, a close comparison of how each poet uses the step-down line should be instructive.

The voice we hear in Williams' "Address:" is tentative, uncertain, the syntax itself reflecting the sense of a man who feels he must say something, but is uncertain of exactly what it is he must say. Williams begins the poem with an address seemingly directed not so much towards his son as to a look "approaching" despair he has caught in his son's eyes. It is a look he knows well, he admits, for he has seen it reflected "in the mirror," has seen it, too, in other men and women. Apologetic, hesitant at this intrusion on his son's privacy, he still knows he must say something, however haltingly, as hesitancy shifts to hesitancy, verbal qualifiers extending out from the main trunk:

To a look in my son's eyes—
 I hope he did not see
 that I was looking—
 that I have seen
 often enough
 in the mirror,
 a male look
 approaching despair—
 there is a female look
 to match it
 no need to speak of that. . . .⁹

How much is confessed here, and yet how much is left unstated! What, for example, does Williams mean by that "female look" of despair? That he has seen it in the eyes of his own wife? In the eyes of his son's wife? The "meaning" here reduces to this: "To a look in my son's eyes . . . [a look] that I have seen . . . in the mirror." The rest is an attempt, a purposely failing attempt, to say what he cannot adequately say, or will not say. That inadequacy, that pressure felt along the line itself of a man forcing an unwilling self to get said what must be said as he approaches death, that pressure of words pushing fitfully forward in starts, qualifiers, asides, is the exact opposite of the kind of rhetorical assurance and formal control we will find in Tomlinson's poetry.

The look he sees there in his son's eyes, Williams says, is like the look that Bobby Burns must often have had in *his* youth, a look which "threw him/ into the arms/ of women" (*JL*, p. 30). It is an oblique confession of the poet-father to the son, a confession of unhappiness in which father and son, and presumably men of all ages, have shared. Men act like this—with abandon—to forget their despair, Williams explains to his son,

not defiantly,
 but with full acceptance
 of his lot
 as a man. . . . (*JL*, pp. 30–31)

For all his excesses, whatever they were, Burns's wife forgave him—as, presumably, Floss has forgiven Williams, or as his son's wife will forgive his son—when he was

too drunk
 with Scotch

or the love of other women
 to notice
 what he was doing. (*JL*, p. 31)

Yet there is nothing that can erase that look. Not war, not even money. What does remain, however, is a kind of difficult integrity such as that which Williams insists Burns (and Williams himself) maintained. For while Burns wrote some of his most beautiful songs for other women, they were "never for sale."

Williams begins by addressing his son, opens the field of the poem to include himself—and by extension other men, other women—and finally focuses on the figure of Burns, another singer and married lover like Williams. So the poem ends with a kind of oblique confession, in which one senses that, despite the feeling of openness and frankness, more has been left unsaid than said. It is the integrity to one's sense of oneself, finally, that Williams stops on—"stops on" rather than "stands on" because the sense of an ending here is tentative, with the tentativeness and momentary resolution of a person in the act of addressing another in what must be an ongoing process. Williams' conclusion is unsure of its own conclusiveness. In short, the strength of Williams' staggered tercets seems to lie, paradoxically, in their tentativeness, in their apparently artless vulnerability.

Once we understand the inner tension of the staggered tercets—the way the syntax gropes across the line-breaks with a stumbling prosaic grace—then the line can indeed be used by other poets. Tomlinson's whole sensibility, however, his entire intellectual constitution, is foreign to this kind of utterance. I can think of no major British poet—except for Hopkins in certain moments of intense private stress—who would not feel embarrassed and uneasy with the kind of voice I have described in "Address:"

Tomlinson himself has told us what he was looking for in the staggered tercets in his "Letter to Dr. Williams," published in *Spectrum* in 1957, where he praises Williams for his

propriety of cadence
 that will pass
 into the common idiom
 like the space
 of Juan Gris
 and Picasso. . . .¹⁰

It is a form with its analogue in the spatial angularity and fragmentation of cubism, a form "invented to be of use" for the "rearticulation

/ of inarticulate facts."¹¹ Here, in fact, the young Englishman himself makes it clear that his own intentions are no doubt different from Williams'—since propriety of cadence does not alone adequately describe the staggered tercet—but that the form itself is flexible enough to allow other voices to fit into it. And yet, one may ask, how far can one stretch or contract even a variable measure before it loses its elasticity and becomes brittle?

At Hugh Kenner's suggestion, Tomlinson began a correspondence with Williams in December 1957, shortly after he wrote his poetic "Letter" to Williams in staggered tercets.¹² He was out, he said, to be the second Englishman—the first being D. H. Lawrence—to read Williams correctly. Since part of that reading focused on the ability to use Williams' step-down lines, it is interesting to watch Tomlinson's changing attitude towards them. At first, Tomlinson is aware only of what he calls his own "technical incompetence" in trying to use what is, he admits, Williams' own form. He recognizes, too, that part of the difficulty resides in his being an Englishman, raised on a different tradition, a different kind of cadence. But by mid-1960, having a dozen or so poems in the step-down line, he is convinced that the line will work just as well for an Englishman as for an American, and that the secret lies in reading the foot as a breath unit, as Olson had said ten years earlier in his "Projective Verse" essay. The real matrix for Tomlinson shifts from Williams to the Wordsworthian meditative line, and the proof Tomlinson needs is in reading Wordsworth's blank verse lines as already containing the triple cadences of the three-ply variable foot. For Tomlinson, therefore, the aim must be to marry the iamb to the variable foot. In other words, as he hears them, the staggered tercets resolve themselves back into the traditional iambic pentameter; they are ultimately variations on the blank verse line. For this reason Tomlinson uses the three-ply line in his translations from Machado (1960), since, for him, the standard iambic measure can and does play nicely "across and into the movement of the variable foot." And there is the crux: whether or not Williams' staggered tercets are essentially blank verse lines filed under another name.

Recall for a moment how for many years Williams himself inveighed against the old, inherited English forms, those forms for which he used the term "sonnet" as his metonymical signature. But, he warned, there were other, more pernicious influences, such as the all-pervasive blank verse line (the trouble was that when you used it, as Stevens' practice had shown, you felt compelled to say something important) and within that line the tyranny which the iambic measure imposed.¹³

So, for example, in the forties Williams pointed repeatedly to the young Auden, Tomlinson's precursor by twenty years, as the figure of the Englishman who had come to the New World in search of a new line. In his lecture "The Poem as a Field of Action" (1948), Williams insisted that Auden had come to America because England could no longer supply him with the poetic means he needed were he to continue to develop as a poet.¹⁴ And though Williams was kinder to Tomlinson, praising his 1958 volume, *Seeing Is Believing*, for its division of the "line according to a new measure learned, perhaps, from a new world,"¹⁵ there were no examples of the staggered tercet.

Anyone who has read even cursorily Tomlinson's eight books of poetry knows that there is indeed in his lines a propriety of cadence that belongs very much to the older English tradition: to Pope, Dr. Johnson, and especially Wordsworth, a measure that remains constant whatever the American influences on his poetry. Along the way, Tomlinson has listened to Pound, for example, especially the Pound of the Chinese cantos and the Confucian translations. He has listened to the syllabics and delicate cut-glass chimings of Marianne Moore; has listened, too, to the meditative patterns in Stevens. And he has listened, of course, to Williams. But Williams becomes strangely muted, a pensive Wordsworthian, finally, if we hear only Tomlinson's proprieties of cadence and not a voice twisting its slow way to its fitful conclusions, discovering flashes of resolution in the very process of the poem's unfolding.

Thus, Tomlinson's "Picture of J. T. in a Prospect of Stone" is much more sure of itself, much firmer than, say, "Asphodel." Its very title, recalling Andrew Marvell's "The Picture of Little T. C. in a Prospect of Flowers," points to the poem's real allegiances, and its ceremony of address, its playful balancings between lightness and seriousness—so much like the image of light playing off stone that is a favorite of Tomlinson's—suggest the Yeats of a poem like "A Prayer for My Daughter" more than Williams. The mode here in Tomlinson is dialogic, the poet asking and assuredly answering his own questions in a version of genial catechesis, as he muses over the kind of gift he would wish for his little daughter. What the eye sees, of course, is the shape of the staggered tercets, but what strikes the ear are the older verse forms deeply imbedded in the new, more flexible lines:

to prove
its quality the better and
thus learn

to love
 what (to begin with)
 she might spurn.¹⁶

The lines will not stay in this unstable solution (though the *prove-love* rhyme keeps the line slightly askew) but must rearrange themselves into heroic couplets such as Marvell might have given us:

to prove
 its quality the better and thus learn
 to love what (to begin with) she might spurn.

Again, examine the final eight lines of the poem, with their syntactical and metrical regularity—

—And so she shall
 but let her play
 her innocence away
 emerging
 as she does
 between
 her doom (unknown),
 her unmown green (*PL*, p. 18)

—and another pattern of loose octosyllabic couplets may be revealed:

And so she shall but let her play
 her innocence away
 emerging as she does between
 her doom (unknown), her unmown green.

The eight lines contain three rhyme sets—*play-away*; *between-green*; *unknown-unmown*. In addition, the sense of an ending is contained within the limits of that final, balanced sentence, with its nice analogue between his daughter's intimation of mortality and the long lovely years still ahead of her, as the poet captures her in this frozen moment stepping lightly across

a sheep-stile
 that divides
 village graves
 and village green? . . . (*PL*, p. 17)

There is in this pastoral a good deal of wry humor, the play of the intellect across an idea that we associate with an older, vanished world order: a world of ceremony, remnants of which Yeats found in Renais-

sance Italy and even in eighteenth-century Dublin, and traces of which Tomlinson, in his turn, finds now in Yeats, as he himself confronts a world that is destroying its architectural forms and aging monuments to the past at an alarming rate. But Tomlinson's short-lived experimentation with the Williams triad may, in the long run, have helped him to loosen his own rhythms and to return to a blank verse mode now notable for its delicate suspension, its phrasal modification, its hesitating stresses. Paradoxically, then, it may well be Tomlinson's contact with American free verse that has helped him to "hear" the voices of his own English fathers—Marvell and Pope and Wordsworth—more clearly. Surely, such poems as the beautiful "Swimming Chenango Lake" (*W World*, pp. 3–4) are new and different from either his own earlier work or from Williams' because he has acknowledged the presence of Williams and his fellow American poets.

Notes

1. Russell Davies, *The Review*, Nos. 29–30 (Spring–Summer 1972), p. 49.
2. Calvin Bedient, *Eight Contemporary Poets* (London: Oxford Univ. Press, 1974), p. 1.
3. See Alvarez' anthology, *The New Poetry* (Harmondsworth, England: Penguin Books, 1962), which leads off with four Americans: Lowell, Berryman, Sexton, and Plath, all of whom but the first were suicides. See, too, his introduction to the volume, defending his selections.
4. "The Art of Poetry," *The Necklace* (1955; rpt. London: Oxford Univ. Press, 1966), p. 14.
5. See Donald Davie's argument for this connection in his *Ezra Pound: Poet as Sculptor* (New York: Oxford Univ. Press, 1964), pp. 112ff.
6. Among those who have used the staggered tercets successfully, I might mention Robert Pack and John Malcolm Brinnin.
7. "Abstruse Considerations," *Poetry*, 104, No. 4 (July 1964), 243. See also Robert Duncan's rejoinder in "A Critical Difference of View," *Stony Brook*, Nos. 3–4 (Fall 1969), pp. 360–63.
8. Or perhaps blank verse was the basic staple to which he would, by testing and circuitous perambulation, return, which may come to the same thing.
9. *Journey to Love* (New York: Random House, 1955), p. 30. Parenthetical page references in the text, preceded by *JL*, are to this edition.
10. *Spectrum*, 1, No. 3 (Fall 1957), 59.
11. *Ibid.*
12. Tomlinson's letters to Williams are now among the unpublished Williams papers in the American Collection at Yale.
13. Cf., for example, Williams' open letter to Kay Boyle, meant for inclusion in *Contact* (1932), but not printed until *The Selected Letters of William Carlos Williams*, ed. John Thirlwall (New York: McDowell, Obolensky, 1957), pp. 129–36; Williams' review of Wallace Stevens' *The Man with the Blue Guitar and Other Poems*, *New Republic*, 17 Nov. 1937, p. 50; and A Garland for William Carlos Williams, ed. Paul Mariani, in *Massachusetts Review*, 14, No. 1 (Winter 1973), *passim*. Hopkins, too, felt the same metrical claustrophobia seventy years earlier, seeing it as analogous to the tyranny imposed on melody by the bar.
14. "The Poem as a Field of Action," in *The Selected Essays of William Carlos Williams*, ed. William Carlos Williams (New York: Random House, 1954), pp. 287–88.

15. "Seeing Is Believing," *Spectrum*, 2, No. 3 (Fall 1958), 189.
16. *A Peopled Landscape* (London: Oxford Univ. Press, 1963), p. 18. Further parenthetical references in the text, preceded by *PL*, will be to this edition.

From *A Sinking Island*: *The Modern English Writers*

Hugh Kenner

In 1955 the Fantasy Press in Eynsham, Oxfordshire, published a little book of poems called *The Necklace*. Its author, Charles Tomlinson, was previously unheard of save for one pamphlet, and his book seemed publishable chiefly thanks to a foreword by Donald Davie, Tomlinson's sometime Cambridge tutor and in '55 a credentialed "Movement" man. Davie began, "These poems require no introduction," which was ideally true. He then went on to supply more introductory words than are to be found in the poems he was introducing. That reflects what he was well aware of, their dissenting conception of what a poem was. Readers expected to hear a poet talk, at least to overhear him muse; they'd take his measure by getting a sense of *him*. Against habits like theirs the little book shut like a clamshell. Its very title (from Wallace Stevens's line "The necklace is a carving not a kiss") rejected the ruminatory presence, affirmed the thing *made*.

In theory, Larkin's fans should not have dissented; but theory of less than scholastic precision is tricky. Larkin said that "to write a poem was to construct a verbal device that would preserve an experience indefinitely by reproducing it in whoever read the poem," and "construct a verbal device" does seem to be talking craftsman's language. But qualifiers lie hidden. For one thing, Larkin's practice posits "experiences" of a quotidian order, like those glimpses he'd caught from the train to London. For another, when he came to construct the verbal device he seemed quite content to trust instinct and chance ("Usually the idea of a poem comes with a line or two of it, and they determine the rest"). What tended to emerge was Larkin, or a persona, situated within the experience and musing about it.

For Tomlinson that was meager. Remembering a Chinese scroll might be a more significant experience than riding the train. Also there was much to learn about the fine joinery of devices; craftsman's lore forgotten in England had, for instance, been preserved and refined in America, whereas in The Movement's Little-Englandism he detected "that suffocation which has affected so much English art ever since the death of Byron." Finally, the poem's words need not entail some presence to murmur them. As his earliest instantiation of such insights, *The Necklace* leaned on transatlantic example and might have been brushed aside as derivative by anyone with a sure knowledge of what it derived from:

Warm flute on the cold snow
Lays amber in sound

 . . .
The sage beneath the waterfall
Numbers the blessings of a flute;
Water lets down
Exploding silk.

Pine-scent
In snow-clearness
Is not more exactly counterpointed
Than the creak of trodden snow
Against a flute.

Easy now, yes, to say how that remembers "Thirteen Ways of Looking at a Blackbird" (it's even called "Nine Variations in a Chinese Winter Setting"): less easy, perhaps, to see how sharply a willingness to learn from Wallace Stevens broke with British custom. And one significant detail owes nothing to Stevens. The lines "Pine-scent / In snow-clearness" quote exactly the title of a Chinese picture Tomlinson saw at 18. ("If I had possessed Miss Moore's scrupulousness it would have been printed in quotation marks.") To let a phrase be a found object was an American maneuver, one more way to cancel what words so readily conjure, an insistent talking presence like a tour-guide's. (Browning's English conscience had not been satisfied till *The Old Yellow Book* was processed into words of his own. But Pound lifted Jefferson's correspondence bodily.) Once a poet has admitted verbatim quotation, with or without quotation marks, he's shed the obligation to stamp each with himself. Language, wherever minted, is minted language.

The liberation of Tomlinson, a boy out of the provinces, had commenced with his quick mind's lighting on odd chances. At grammar school, having bought a *Selected Pound* for a half-crown, he'd naively applied classroom scansion to

For three years, out of key with his time,
He strove to resuscitate the dead art
Of poetry; to maintain "the sublime"
In the old sense. Wrong from the start—

and decided, since it couldn't be done, that "perhaps some type of syncopation was at work." Then he'd been arrested by

. . . is almost afraid that I
will commit that indiscretion

and (miraculously) spotted "the stress and pausing on 'I' before the line break." Canto II "closed on the word 'And. . . .'" That was also something to think about." Later, in Marianne Moore, he found himself admiring not the lady's quirky presence but "the rhyming of light against heavy beat."

What those enlightening recollections show us is a schoolboy bringing to poetry—hardly knowing how—the kind of perception British schoolboys used to bring to trains and wireless kits: an analytic fascination with how something works. The mind that made the first spinning-jenny had paid like attention to an intricate imagined dance (and altered England forever). Analytic attention to process is the British genius. But somehow, some time after Marvell and Pope and Landor, the islanders became persuaded that *literary* perception was of a different order: moreover, that they themselves were literary by birth-right. (They do tend to be impeccable syntacticians.) Thus Literature was something you achieved by sheer native sincerity. Of how a poem came Larkin had this to say: "It happens, or happened, and if it's something to be grateful for, you're grateful."

(How odd are communal self-misapprehensions! The English think they're literary; they are technologists. Though Americans think they're technologists, technology scares them; cherishing the disembodied abstract, they find fulfillment in the themes of law. And Ireland, said to be dreamland, breeds logicians, fierce ones.)

Astute eyes might have spotted in *The Necklace* a poet working in ways new in modern England, and learning from writers—foreign writers at that—who didn't necessarily learn from one another. But astute

eyes were lacking. Sages, flutes, amber: pretty *precious* stuff to be peddling amid skinheadery. Chinese pastiche?—stale; if you want that, go to Waley. As for the Stevens connection, in '55 Stevens had never so much as been published in England. So there was nobody (save Davie) to protest when every publisher in England rejected Tomlinson's next collection as reflexively as they'd have declined an electric eel. *Seeing Is Believing* at length appeared in New York (McDowell, Obolensky, 1958). That book contains no hint of pastiche.

THE ATLANTIC

Launched into an opposing wind, hangs
 Grappled beneath the onrush,
 And there, lifts, curling in spume,
 Unlocks, drops from that hold
 Over and shoreward. The beach receives it,
 A whitening line, collapsing
 Powdering-off down its broken length. . . .

Continuing the first line from the title is a device traceable to Marianne Moore's "The Fish" (another water-poem); but the powerful metrical mimesis is not derived from her or from Stevens but from—from what? At a guess, from potentialities sensed in *Beowulf*. That is one way to use academic learning.

Tomlinson read English Literature at Cambridge, 1945–48 (and French, and German; and of course he had Latin). And he sees no need to hide his education, though he doesn't use it to pester with allusions. That is "foreign" once again. American poets had begun to show the classroom's stamp in Pound's and Eliot's generation, and the tradition persists (Olson, Zukofsky, Davenport). It wasn't till Tomlinson's and Davie's generation that a like phenomenon began to be discernible in England. True, Tennyson was at Cambridge, but we don't take account of what he learned there, save that Arthur Hallam was praiseworthy, and one thing Sam Johnson learned at Oxford was to get out of it.

Always, a Tomlinson poem, in what he would later discover was the norm of the American "Objectivists," is an undertaking: a something as much itself as a clock or a painting, even when it wears the look of responding or reporting. Near the center of *Seeing Is Believing* we find a "Farewell to Van Gogh":

The quiet deepens. You will not persuade
 One leaf of the accomplished, steady, darkening

Chestnut-tower to displace itself
With more of violence than the air supplies
When, gathering dusk, the pond brims evenly
And we must be content with stillness.

Unhastening, daylight withdraws from us its shapes
Into their central calm. Stone by stone
Your rhetoric is dispersed until the earth
Becomes once more the earth, the leaves
A sharp partition against cooling blue.

Farewell, and for your instructive frenzy
Gratitude. The world does not end tonight
And the fruit that we shall pick tomorrow
Await us, weighing the unstripped bough.

Six lines, five lines, four lines, the stanzas diminish with the day. Evening shadows will lengthen at their own pace, and no urgency of Van Gogh's will hasten them. "The world does not end tonight": a valuable lesson, in the heyday of Dylan Thomas. And "Stone by stone / Your rhetoric is dispersed": no English poet admires more the obduracy of stone.

Stone is itself: resistant: the other: that which whim cannot subdue, appropriate, transmute. A poem collected in 1963, "The Picture of J. T. in a Prospect of Stone," wishes for a child "the constancy of stone" and continues,

—But stone
 is hard.
 —Say, rather
it resists
 the slow corrosives
 and the flight
of time
 and yet it takes
 the play, the fluency
from light.

"Takes" means partly "subtracts" but mostly "receives," and the poem, remembering in its title Marvell's "Picture of Little T.C. in a Prospect of Flowers," remembers too how it has been three centuries since a poet could write

See with what simplicity
This nymph begins her golden days!

and not sentimentalize some Alice. Marvell ends with an oblique hint at infant mortality—"Lest Flora. . . / Nip in the blossom all our hopes and thee." Tomlinson, in a time less easily floral, has the child emerge

from between
the stone lips
of a sheep-stile
that divides
village graves
and village green

and reverts to this moment as his poem ends:

but let her play
her innocence away
emerging
as she does
between
her doom (unknown),
her unmown green.

There "unmown" too is a word with Marvell's stamp; the poem comes from a 1963* volume in which Tomlinson, his apprenticeship behind him, is resuming the British side of his heritage. That means, drawing on resources unavailable to American poets, for whom single words cannot have such power to evoke exact areas of reference. Though Pound has potent single words, the occasions they remember come not so much from available tradition as from the parts of it his own fifty years' poem has already appropriated. *The Cantos* were forced to create a tradition for themselves. An English poet hasn't that responsibility.

Still, Tomlinson's tradition does not all come ready-made; in Pound's way, he will let us see him extend it. If the title and some of the diction of "The Picture of J. T." remember post-Civil War England, the poem gets its lineation from the three-ply stanza William Carlos Williams, then still living, had invented in "The Descent":

. . . For what we cannot accomplish, what
is denied to love,
what we have lost in the anticipation—
a descent follows
endless and indestructible

"J. T."—his own child, the poet specifies; scholars must guess who the Marvell child may have been—lives in an Anglo-American century,

and though her "village green" ("unmown") can only be English, idioms have altered. So also, since 1945, have dooms. "Her doom (unknown)" is a phrase with special torque amid our various and specific knowledges of death.

Much of *A Peopled Landscape* was written after a first visit to the United States. It sees its English matter with new eyes, for reconstituting with new techniques. One thing the title says is that much American landscape—notably in the Southwest that drew Tomlinson—is distinctively unpeopled. So what does it mean in England, where people are abundant, to locate them in their landscape? It means, for instance, the strange harmonious assault of "Walking to Bells," where immemorial English churchyard sounds (Tennyson's "mellow lin-lan-lone") are distanced by the subtle conceit of a breaking wave:

The spray of sound
(Its echo rides
As bodied as metal
Whose echoes'
Echo it is)
Stunned, released
Where the house-walls
Stand or cease
Blows, or does not
Into the unfilled space
Accordingly; which
Space whose Adam wits
Slept on till now,
Kindles from cold
To hold the entire
Undoubling wave
Distinct in its jewelled collapse,
And the undertone
Stern and broader than such facile beads
Gainsays
Not one from the toppling hoard its tensed back heaves.

Here people are walking, here are house-walls, and here at no great distance is always the sea. (No place in England is more than a hundred miles from salt water.) Poe's "Tintinnabulation of the bells bells" was placeless, contextless: an early American showing-off. In Tomlinson's poem a single long sentence with interruptions remembers Milton; "accordingly" remembers the chord in its own etymology; since sound does come in "waves," "undertone" can decorously recall "undertow"; and the short ("American") lines attain rest in a

crowded iambic pentameter that resolves all the cumulation of sound in remembering four centuries of British mastery.

Not that it's done without cost. Save for the hint "Adam" conveys, one dominant past voice is absent from this harmony. Though surely church-bells, the bells in this poem are purely acoustic, and if they sound any summons to worship (surely, for someone?) the poem ignores it. A "style," a way of writing, is defined and bounded by what it is forced to omit, and to linger on what this remarkable poet achieved was to grow aware too of what is perforce absent. Amid his strong pieties of place, the religious was absent, and that of course is a mark of the first century since Anglo-Saxon times in which it's been possible to grow up in England, and reconstitute a heritage, and simply ignore what for so long mattered most. Also absent was the whole order of experience Larkin registers, shopgirls, advertisements, junked cars, litter, factories. But major poets (think of Yeats) do not get stuck, and by 1974 (*The Way In*) Tomlinson had the Larkin material under control—

... Flat-dwellers came and went, in the divided houses,
 Mothers unwedded who couldn't pay their rent.
 A race of gardeners died, and a generation
 Hacked down the walls to park their cars
 Where the flowers once were. It was there it showed,
 The feeble-minded style of the neighbourhood
 Gone gaudily mad in painted corrugations,
 Botches of sad carpentry. The street front has scarcely changed.
 No one has recorded the place.
 Perhaps we shall become sociology. We have outpaced
 Gladstone's century. We might have been novels.

That records a revisit to Stoke-on-Trent, his boyhood ambience and (approximately) Arnold Bennett's. It is no longer correct to say, what was true of the earlier poems, that scrupulousness borders on anxiety: that each poem celebrates some precarious equilibration. "Beethoven Attends the C Minor Seminar" is unprecarious. (It's about "Ludmilla Quatsch, the queen of the sleevenote," being silenced by Beethoven's ghost.) "The Littleton Whale" is unprecarious too. So is everything since the mid-'70's. And for the note of transcendence, try the Eden/Arden poems. *The Way In* was a breaking out, unpublicized. He is England's chief living poet. Publishers decline, unread, books about his achievement; he's "minor." Write about Larkin; write about Ted Hughes!

Across from his Gloucestershire cottage, the last time I visited, a white horse trotted, identified as Lady Betjeman's. Sir John Betjeman, connoisseur of Victoriana and of Henry James's morning clothes (which he owned), was by that time Poet Laureate. His lady's bland horse was an emblem of bathos. Engulfed by public bathos, you contrive risks.

. . . In the dark
Height, geese yelp like a pack
Hunting through space.

Nature contrives them too. And London is far.

* By then Oxford University Press had become, to its credit, his publisher. [Kenner's note]

"*Movement*": A group of English writers in the mid-1950s who opposed the apocalyptic neo-romanticism of Dylan Thomas by proclaiming an austere, neo-classical aesthetic of traditional form, pure diction, rational statement, and a clear-eyed acceptance of the drab, provincial realities of postwar England. The Movement included Kingsley Amis, Donald Davie, D. J. Enright, Elizabeth Jennings, Philip Larkin, and John Wain.

Wallace Stevens's line: From Part III of Stevens' "The Auroras of Autumn" (1948).

Larkin: The English poet, novelist, and critic Philip Larkin (1922–1985) published a gathering of his prose in *Required Writing: Miscellaneous Pieces 1955–1982* (New York: Farrar, Straus, Giroux, 1984). Kenner quotes first from Larkin's "Writing Poems" 83 ("to write a poem was. . .") and then from "An Interview with Paris Review" 71 ("Usually the idea of a poem. . ."). "Those glimpses he'd caught from the train to London" is a reference to Larkin's well-known poem, "The Whitsun Weddings."

"*that suffocation*": Kenner quotes from CT's *Some Americans* 18–19.

"*If I had possessed*": *Some Americans* 10.

The Old Yellow Book: A collection of historical documents relating to a Roman murder trial of 1697–98, the Old Yellow Book became the source of *The Ring and the Book* (1868–69) by the English poet Robert Browning (1812–1869).

Jefferson's correspondence: Thomas Jefferson (1743–1826) was the third President of the United States. Passages from his correspondence are incorporated directly into Cantos 31–33 (1931) by Ezra Pound.

the liberation of Tomlinson: Kenner's account in this paragraph is indebted to *Some Americans* 1–4.

a Selected Pound: Ezra Pound, *A Selection of Poems* (London: Faber and Faber, 1940). In *Some Americans* 1, CT specifies that this was "the Sesame Books selection. . . not to be confused with the *Selected Poems* edited by T. S. Eliot."

"*perhaps some type of syncopation*": *Some Americans* 1. The quoted lines ("For three years. . .") are from "E.P. Ode pour l'élection de son sepulchre," the opening

section of Pound's *Hugh Selwyn Mauberley*. The next quotation ("is almost afraid") comes from Pound's "The Garden."

Marvell and Pope and Landor: Andrew Marvell (1621–1678), English poet, prose writer, and politician. Alexander Pope (1688–1744), English poet, translator, and editor. Walter Savage Landor (1775–1864), English poet, prose writer, and translator.

Larkin: We have not been able to identify the source of this quotation.

Waley: For Sir Arthur Waley, see p. 75.

"The Fish": In *Some Americans* 4, CT recalls being disturbed by the way in which the title of Marianne Moore's "The Fish" "became the subject of the first sentence in the poem." He notes that many of his "preferred American poems had been sea-pieces." They "implied for me a moral atmosphere that itself partook of the sharpness of brine and sea breeze" (11).

Olson, Zukofsky, Davenport: For Charles Olson, see p. 101. Louis Zukofsky (1904–1978), American poet and prose writer. Guy Davenport (b. 1927), American short-story writer, translator, and critic.

Tennyson was at Cambridge: The English poet Alfred, Lord Tennyson (1809–1892) attended Cambridge University from 1828 to 1831. There he befriended Arthur Henry Hallam, whose untimely death in 1833 was the occasion of Tennyson's *In Memoriam* and other elegiac poems.

Sam Johnson: The English poet, prose writer, critic, and lexicographer Samuel Johnson (1709–1784) studied at Pembroke College, Oxford, in 1728–29 but left without taking a degree.

the American "Objectivists": A group of New York poets in the early 1930s that included Louis Zukofsky, George Oppen, Charles Reznikoff, and Carl Rakosi. Like the Imagists before them, the Objectivists stressed the impersonal presentation of experience in organic forms dictated by the unique contours of the experience itself. In Chapter 2 of *Some Americans* CT describes his acquaintance with the Objectivists, and quotes WCW's summary of their aims: "it must be the purpose of the poet to make of his words a new form" (47).

Dylan Thomas: Together with Vernon Watkins, George Barker, Henry Treece, and G. S. Fraser, the Welsh poet, short-story writer, and essayist Dylan Thomas (1914–1953) played a central role in a neo-romantic movement of the 1940s called "The New Apocalypse." Poetry of the New Apocalypse was distinguished by its turbulent, surrealistic imagery and its syntactical fluidity.

See with what simplicity: Kenner quotes the opening lines of Andrew Marvell's poem, "The Picture of Little T. C. in a Prospect of Flowers" (1681). The identity of "T. C." is unknown, but Marvell scholars speculate that she may have been Theophila Cornewall, b. 1644.

Alice: The protagonist of *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* (1865) by Lewis Carroll (Charles Dodgson, 1832–1898) was modelled upon Alice Liddell, the beloved daughter of one of Dodgson's Oxford colleagues.

a 1963 volume: CT's *A Peopled Landscape*.

"The Descent": For WCW's "The Descent," see pp. 106–7.

"J. T."—his own child: Justine Tomlinson (b. 1958).

Tennyson's "mellow lin-lan-lone": Kenner quotes from Alfred, Lord Tennyson's "Far-Far-Away" (1889): "What sound was dearest in his native dells? / The mellow lin-lan-lone of evening bells / Far-far-away."

Poe's "Tintinnabulation": Kenner quotes from "The Bells" (1849) by the American poet, short-story writer, and critic Edgar Allan Poe (1809–1849): "the tintinnabulation that so musically wells / From the bells, bells, bells, bells."

Flat-dwellers came and went: Kenner quotes from CT's "From Gladstone Street" in *The Way In and Other Poems* (1974); see *Collected Poems* 244–45.

Arnold Bennett's: The English novelist, playwright, and critic Arnold Bennett (1867–1931) was born in Hanley, Staffordshire. Many of his novels are set in the industrial area known as "the Potteries" around Stoke-on-Trent.

"Beethoven Attends the C Minor Seminar": This poem was published in CT's *The Way In and Other Poems* (1974); see *Collected Poems* 267–68.

"The Littleton Whale": This poem appeared in CT's *The Flood* (1981); see *Collected Poems* 343–46. It is subtitled "in memory of Charles Olson."

the Eden/Arden poems: A poem entitled "In Arden" in CT's *The Shaft* (1978) opens with the line "Arden is not Eden, but Eden's rhyme" (*Collected Poems* 305–6). Earlier poems entitled "Eden" and "Adam" appeared in *The Way of a World* (1969; *Collected Poems* 159–60), and a book entitled *Eden: Graphics and Poems* (Bristol: Redcliffe Poetry) was published in 1985. Kenner may be referring to any or all of these Eden-themed poems.

Ted Hughes: The English poet and prose writer Ted Hughes (1930–1998) became Britain's Poet Laureate in 1984. He is the author of *The Hawk in the Rain* (1957) and many other books.

Sir John Betjeman: The English poet and architectural critic Sir John Betjeman (1906–1984) served as Britain's Poet Laureate from 1972 until his death.

In the dark / Height: Kenner quotes from CT's "The Weatherman" in *The Way of a World* (1969); see *Collected Poems* 168.

From “Larkin’s Politics, and Tomlinson’s”

Donald Davie

Charles Tomlinson has said: “There is no occasion too small for the poet’s celebration.” But is this true? Commonsense, not without quite distinguished endorsement from past centuries, thinks that it is not true; that on the contrary there are occasions too trivial, too lacking in dignity or resonance, to deserve the ceremoniousness that, as Tomlinson rightly perceives, verse-writing always brings with it. The unfortunate effect in such cases is *portentiousness*. “The Red Wheelbarrow” by William Carlos Williams—it is the hackneyed instance, which Tomlinson does not fail to cite approvingly—is surely in this way portentous:

so much depends
upon

a red wheel
barrow

glazed with rain
water

beside the white
chickens.

“So much depends,” says the little squib (for it is nothing more), on the wheelbarrow, the glaze of rain, the chickens. But just how much *does* depend? The momentousness of the sparsely arranged scene is blankly asserted, not proved. Or rather it is proved—by sleight of hand; for if the little scene is not momentous, how did it come to be framed, in all its sparsity, by so much white paper? The reverential hush is

thus not only demanded, but enforced. The poet cannot lose; whatever claims he makes for the momentousness of his subject-matter are vindicated simply by the way those claims are made.

Such poetry is invulnerable, existing in a self-sealed and self-justifying realm called "aesthetic," from which no appeal is allowed, or can be made, to other realms like the ethical or the civic. The literary histories invite us to associate such a belief in the unbreachable autonomy of art with haughty and disdainful decadents of the 1880s and 1890s. The achievement of Williams, of his followers and admirers, has been to show that the most secure haven for such doctrines is on the contrary in an ideology that is aggressively egalitarian, and also secular. A moment's thought shows that this must be true. For the belief that "there is no occasion too small" is naturally at home in a society that makes no distinction between small occasions and big ones, a society that resists any ranking of certain human and civic occasions below or above certain others. Thus it is social democracy that cossets and protects the aesthete, as no other form of society does. Williams's "So much depends" asserts and takes for granted the absence of any agreed hierarchies, hence the freedom of any individual to establish and assert his own hierarchy, without fear of being challenged.

Tomlinson endorsed Williams, and asserted "no occasion too small," in relation to his own poem, "Swimming Chenango Lake." This appeared in his ground-breaking 1969 collection, *The Way of a World*, but it had previously appeared on its own in the USA in a booklet where it was accompanied by a brief lecture, "The Poem as Initiation." This began: "I would like to speak in defence of ceremony." But if this seemed to promise a defence of hierarchy, the hearers were soon disabused; for what Tomlinson went on to say was that all occasions for poetry were equal, since none was too small to be made ceremonious. All the same, there was some fudging of the issue. For on the one hand, whereas indeed taking a swim in a lake seems a small occasion, when we read the poem we discover that this swim was undertaken just before the onset of winter, that it was perhaps the last swim that would be practicable that year; and this makes the occasion quite a large one, acquiescence in the turn of the season towards seeming death. This aspect of the poem as a seasonal rite is what saves it, so some may think, from being portentous. Moreover Tomlinson goes on: ". . . and I would like to speak also in defence of the poem as part of this particular ceremony." For the poem was publicly read, it

appears, on an American college campus as part of an initiation ceremony of the local chapter of the Phi Beta Kappa honour society. And this introduces ironies that Tomlinson might prefer we should not notice. For whereas non-Americans and also many Americans think of Dr. Williams's America as, for good or ill, unceremonious and non-hierarchical compared with most European societies, the Phi Beta Kappa society, which is as old as the Republic, is both ceremonious and unashamedly elitist. What's more, as Tomlinson gracefully acknowledges in references to Phi Beta Kappa poems by W. H. Auden and Robert Frost, poetry has frequently been co-opted into the society's ceremonial. Accordingly, Tomlinson's argument seemed somewhat at odds with the occasion.

Some readers of this important poet have found him rather often in two minds on this matter. Repeatedly in Britain he has been called an aesthete; and although he can be shown to be nothing of the sort, he certainly has the aesthete's habit of displaying his own fastidiousness—his is not the art that conceals itself. His tone accordingly has the aesthete's hauteur, it is not the tone of the social democrat. And sure enough, he has made it plain that he embraces social democracy only grudgingly and *faute de mieux*:

Hard edges of the houses press
On the after-music senses, and refuse to burn,
Where an ice cream van circulates the estate
Playing Greensleeves, and at the city's
Stale new frontier even ugliness
Rules with the cruel mercy of solidities.

In this rendering of a typical and commonplace scene from social-democratic England, the poet's distaste for the "stale new frontier" is so evident that it is hard to believe he finds such scenes acceptable. (Should there not be legislation, he seems to protest, to prevent the archaic and lovely "Greensleeves" being canned for dissemination by ice-cream vans?) And yet in its context as the last stanza of "Prometheus," a poem about the Russian Revolution, the verses do assert that the architecturally squalid housing-estate, and the trader whose trademark is "Greensleeves," must be tolerated. The oxymoron "cruel mercy," taking up and intensifying the preceding oxymoron "stale new," is meant in all earnest: if such inelegance and lack of refinement represent the price to be paid for avoiding the perfervid melodrama of revolutionary politics, then the bargain is a cruel one

but the bargain must be struck, and we must be grateful that this option, in all its shabbiness, is mercifully open. For what is the alternative? It has been spelled out in previous stanzas, which have named Lenin and Trotsky, but also the musician Scriabin and the poet Blok. And it is the latter two, not the men of action but the men of art, who are held most responsible:

Scriabin, Blok, men of extremes,
History treads out the music of your dreams
Through blood. . .

One could hardly go further in denying the aesthete's (and the deconstructionist's) assumption that the artist is responsible to no one but himself. On the other hand, the claim that the artists of Revolution wield more influence than the political and military leaders flies in the face of the common assumption that the arts are a marginal luxury. And so it is no wonder that this profoundly political poem should have been disregarded by those who most vehemently insist that poetry and politics be brought together. Tomlinson's vision, unyieldingly secular, is of a sort that frequently falls for political utopias; but his poem says that all such utopias are murderous. It is what nobody wants to hear, not even the poet's admirers, who are happiest with his epistemology and have therefore missed the significance of *The Way of a World*, in which a poet who had seemed a-political revealed his deeply considered and disconcerting politics.¹ If Tomlinson, on "ceremony" and related matters, seems at times to run with the hare and hunt with the hounds, it is in part because his view of politics and of public life is disenchanted beyond what either his British or his American readers are prepared to contemplate. The British reader should be able to guess the reservations that Tomlinson leaves civilly unspoken when he honours sanguine American democrats like W. C. Williams or George Oppen or (another sort of North American) the Mexican Octavio Paz. There is no evidence, however, that British readers have done this.

¹ See K. O'Gorman (ed.), *Charles Tomlinson. Man and Poet* (Columbia, Missouri, 1988). [Davie's note]

"*There is no occasion too small*: Davie quotes from CT's *The Poem as Initiation* (Hamilton, New York: Colgate University Press [1968]), unpaginated. CT writes: "There is no occasion too small for the poet's celebration—Williams' red wheelbarrow, or Wordsworth's 'naked table'—all ask, through the insistence of the poem's ritual celebration, to be recorded by us in their deeper significances."

the Phi Beta Kappa honour society: Founded in 1776, Phi Beta Kappa is the oldest national collegiate scholastic honorary society in America. Membership is based chiefly upon a student's grades in a variety of courses. In *The Poem as Initiation* CT reminds his listeners that W. H. Auden read "Under Which Lyre" at a Phi Beta Kappa ceremony at Harvard University in 1946, and that Robert Frost read "The Gift Outright" and "To a Moth Seen in Winter" at the 1941 ceremony at the College of William and Mary.

faute de mieux: French, "for lack of something better"

Scriabin and . . . Blok: The Russian composer and concert pianist Aleksandr Scriabin (1872–1915) was a messianic visionary who believed in the imminent regeneration of the world through a cataclysmic event. He welcomed the outbreak of World War I in 1914 as a step toward cosmic renewal. For the Russian poet, playwright, and critic Aleksandr Blok, see Letter 4. Blok welcomed the Russian Revolution of 1917; in the following year he wrote a poem entitled "The Twelve," in which Jesus Christ leads a band of twelve Red Guards.

George Oppen: The American poet George Oppen (1908–1984) was a member of the Objectivist school (see p. 130). CT speaks of him in chapter 2 of *Some Americans*.

Octavio Paz: For Octavio Paz, see p. 102.

Charles Tomlinson

LETTER TO DR. WILLIAMS

There being no immediate
likelihood
of reading your poems
under the impress
Faber and Faber
may a poet
and (at that) an English
poet, salute them?
For here
they are deaf to everything
except the quatrain
which is virtually
as useless as the couplet.
You chose
(so you say) "the speech
of Polish mothers."
Whatever your means
or your intention, the end
has enriched us all
whether we confess it
or no. We have gained

a world, and you
 have enlivened a discipline
 by propriety of cadence

 that will pass
 into the common idiom
 like the space

 of Juan Gris
 and Picasso—
 invented to be of use

 and for the rearticulation
 of inarticulate facts.

WINTER

It is winter. We have ransacked
 the museums for warmth
 and we have produced garishness.
 A Navajo blanket
 woven in a Lancashire factory
 decorates the interior.
 It is picturesque
 and we do not want pictures
 but a weather of being
 an atmosphere
 that we can inhabit.
 Houses
 are built of stone
 pervaded by a locality
 and by durable crafts.
 There are no Indians here,
 but it is winter.

LE MUSÉE IMAGINAIRE

An Aztec sacrifice,
 beside the head of Pope:
 eclectic and unresolvable.
 We admire the first
 for its expressiveness, the second
 because we understand it—
 can re-create
 its circumstances, and share
 (if not the presuppositions)
 the aura
 of the civilities surrounding it.
 The other, in point

at any rate, of violence
 touches us more nearly.
 and yet . . . it is cruel¹
 but unaccountably so; for the temper of awe
 demanded by the occasion, escapes us:
 it is not
 better than we are—
 it is merely different.
 Expressive, certainly. But of what?
 Our loss is absolute, yet unfelt
 because inexact. The head
 of Alexander Pope,
 stiller, attests the more tragic lack
 by remaining
 what it was meant to be;
 intelligible,
 it forbids us to approach it.

OVER BROOKLYN BRIDGE

Mayakovsky
 has it!—
 'in the place
 of style, an austere
 disposition of bolts.'
 The poet cedes
 his elocutionary function¹
 to the telephone book:
 Hermann
 Salinas
 Yarmolinsky,
 words
 reciprocally
 kindling one another
 like the train of fire
 over a jewel box.
 Miss Moore
 had a negress
 for a maid whose father
 was a Cherokee.
 'No', she said
 'I do not live in town
 I live in Brooklyn.
 I was afraid

¹ 'The poet cedes his elocutionary function. . . ' is a slightly travestied version of a famous passage from Mallarmé's *Crise de vers*: 'l'œuvre pure implique la disparation élocutoire du poète, qui cède l'initiative aux mots. . . ' [CT's note]

you wouldn't like it here—
it's gotten so ugly.'
I liked Brooklyn
with its survival
of wooden houses
and behind trees
the balconies colonnaded.
And what I liked
about the bridge
was the uncertainty
the way
the naked steel
would not go naked
but must wear
its piers of stone—
as the book says
'stylistically
its weakest feature.'

I like
such weaknesses, the pull
the stone base
gives to the armature.
I live
in a place of stone
if it's still there
by the time I've sailed to it.
Goodbye

Miss Moore
I hope
the peacock's feather you once saw
at the house of Ruskin
has kept its variegations.
Jewels
have histories:
'I never did
care for Mallarmé'
she said
and the words
in the book of names
are flames not bolts.

POEM OF A DAY

Rural Meditations

Behold me
here—the nightingales'
apprentice, master

of *la gaya scienza*
formerly:
I teach
the living tongues
to a damp and bleak
sombre and straggling
village that belongs
half to La Mancha, half
to Andalusia.
Winter:
the fireside:
in the street
a fine rain falls
alternately as mist or sleet.
I
a husbandman in fancy
dream of fields.
O Lord,
how well thou dost
and how
it rains!
on vineyards and on olive-groves
fields of barley and of beans:
a still
a small and steady rain.
How the sowers of the grain
will bless
like me
your bounteousness,
and those who live
by gathering
the olive,
those who hope
for the fortune of a meal
and have
all that they own
in the year's deceitful wheel—
this
and every year that's gone.
Rain,
rain on!
and alternate
as mist or sleet
and then again
reverting to a tenuous rain
rain, Lord, rain!
My chamber keeps
a wintry light:

the afternoon
 through rain and glass
 sifts its grey illumination—
 a medium where thoughts may pass.
 The clock
 neglected in its corner
 looms distinct:
 its tick
 forgotten in its repetitions
 now beats on
 within my consciousness
 and boring, bored
 a uniform metallic heart
 speaks its one and only part:
 tick
 tock:
 in villages like these
 does one catch
 the pulse of time?
 Truceless
 before the clock
 one, rather, fights
 against monotony
 that, in these villages
 alights
 to measure
 the passage of their vacancies.
 But, clock, is yours
 this time of mine—
 are mine your hours?
 (Tick, tick)
 There was a day
 (tick, tick) that passed
 and that which I
 most loved
 death made away.
 A knell from far
 fades
 into the rain's
 minute, untroubled chime
 that rings against the window panes.
 A husbandman in fancy
 I
 return to fields.
 Lord,
 how they'll bless
 your bounteousness—
 those

who sow the bread.
Lord,
is not the rain you bring
law in the ox-ploughed field
and in
the palace of the King?
Bounteous water,
leave
behind you life—
you that go
drop by drop, and
spring by spring
and river upon river flow,
that, like this time
of weariness supply
the sea
with transitory life,
with all that seeks nativity
to germinate
to spring
and be.
Be
merciful
for you become
tomorrow's
early ear of grain, and
you restore
tint in the field
and in the flesh
and more:
reason
madness
bitterness
the grief that wishes for
and yet remains unsatisfied
with all belief.
Dark
is coming down;
the wire
reddens within the bulb,
gathering to a glow
with scarce more show
than wax on a lucifer.
God only knows
where (under these tomes, reviews
and scribblings)—
ah, here they are:
my spectacles.

New books.
 One
 \ I open
 by Unamuno.
 Oh, the chosen
 cherished spirit
 of the Spain that shall inherit
 our coming life
 our resurrection!
 This
 teacher of a country school,
 unheard of,
 he knows no defection,
 Rector of Salamanca!
 Yours—
 the philosophy you call
 dilettante and inconstant
 balanced
 upon its slender rope—
 nourishes, great
 Don Miguel
 his buried hope.
 Water
 of the good spring,
 fugitive
 always. always living;
 poetry—
 that cordial thing.
 Architectonic?
 (Do you look
 for architecture
 in the wind,
 in the soul's structure?)
 Rower,
 sailor
 across that sea
 which has no shore.
 Henri Bergson
 Les données
immédiates
 de la conscience.
 Is this
 another Gallic artifice?
 This Bergson
 is a sell—agreed,
 Maestro Don Miguel?
 He's no Immanuel Kant—
 it's the immortal somersault

his writings want;
 this devilishly clever Jew
 locates
free will
 within his mind's own gates.
 Ah, well—
every wise man has his problem,
 every idiot his theme.
 And yet
it still would seem
 to matter whether
 we, in a short and evil life
shall live
 as either slaves or free.
 But if
(as the poet shows)
 it's seaward all our living flows—
 all will come
to the same thing.
 Oh, these villages!
 reflections
readings
 annotations
 soon will end
in what they are:
 the yawns
 of Solomon.
Is it all
 solitude of solitudes
 vanity of vanities
as saith Ecclesiastes?
 my waterproof,
 umbrella
and sombrero:
 the rain is moderating—
 shall we go?
Night:
 the talk is on
 in the rear room
at the apothecary's
 where they define
 what makes the liberals such swine
and Don José
 scents consolation
 in the return (predicted)
of the conservative administration,
 all spicing it
 from the inexhaustible resources

of a people's wit:
 'The past \ \
 \ and future
 are the same.
 Others
 like us, will blame
 the government.
 All changes,
 comes
 and goes.' And then,
 for arbitration:
 'No evil lasts a century
 to plague a nation.'
 'And the beans
 have come on splendidly—'
 'These rains—'
 'The barley—'
 'And they'll flower
 by March
 unless the frost—'
 'The labourers
 will count the cost
 in sweat—'
 'Torrents—'
 'Seas
 would scarcely quench the thirst of olive trees.'
 'In other days—'
 'The rain would rain
 at the Lord's will, then
 as now.' 'Until
 tomorrow, gentlemen.'
 Tick
 tock
 tick-tock: one
 day has gone
 like any other
 says the monotone of the clock.
 My table bears
 les données de la conscience
immédiates.
 It's adequate
 this I
 that's fundamental
 and at times
 creative and original, that
 mingling in mortality
 its freedom and contingency,

can feel
 can see, and yet , •
 must overleap the confines
 of its narrow keep.

Baeza, 1913

UP AT LA SERRA

The shadow
 ran before it lengthening
 and a wave went over.
 Distance
 did not obscure
 the machine of nature:
 you could watch it
 squander and recompose itself
 all day, the shadow-run
 the sway of the necessity down there
 at the cliff-base
 crushing white from blue.
 Come in
 by the arch
 under the campanile parocchiale
 and the exasperation of the water
 followed you,
 its *Soldi, soldi*
 unpicking the hill-top peace
 insistently.
 He knew, at twenty
 all the deprivations such a place
 stored for the man
 who had no more to offer
 than a sheaf of verse
 in the style of Quasimodo.
 Came the moment,
 he would tell it
 in a poem
 without rancour, a lucid
 testament above his name
 Paolo
 Bertolani
 —*Ciao, Paolo!*
 —*Ciao*
 Giorgino!
 He would put them
 all in it—
 Giorgino going

over the hill
 to look for labour;
 the grinder
 of knives and scissors
 waiting to come up, until
 someone would hoist his wheel
 on to a back, already
 hooped to take it,
 so you thought
 the weight must crack
 the curvature. And then:
 Beppino and Beppino
 friends
 who had in common
 nothing except their names and friendship;
 and the sister of the one
 who played the accordion
 and under all
 the *Soldi, soldi,*
 sacra conversazione
 del mare—
della madre.
 Sometimes
 the men had an air of stupefaction:
La Madre:
 it was the women there
 won in a truceless enmity.
 At home
 a sepia-green
 Madonna di Foligno
 shared the wall
 with the October calendar—
 Lenin looked out of it,
 Mao
 blessing the tractors
 and you told
 the visitors
 We are not communists
 although we call ourselves communists
we are what you English
 would call . . . socialists.
 He believed
 that God was a hypothesis,
 that the party would bring in
 a synthesis, that he
 would edit the local paper for them,
 or perhaps
 go northward to Milan;

or would he grow
as the others had—son .
to the puttana-madonna
in the curse,
chafed by the maternal knot and by
the dream of faithlessness,
uncalloused hands,
lace, white
at the windows of the sailors' brothels
in the port five miles away?
Soldi—
soldi—
some
worked at the naval yards
and some, like him
were left between
the time the olives turned
from green to black
and the harvest of the grapes.
idle
except for hacking wood.
Those
with an acre of good land
had vines, had wine
and self-respect. Some
carried down crickets
to the garden of the mad Englishwoman
who could
not
tolerate
crickets, and they received
soldi, soldi
for recapturing them. . . .
The construction
continued as heretofore
on the villa of the Milanese dentist
as the evening
came in with news:
—*We have won*
the election.
—*At the café*
the red flag is up.
He turned back
quickly beneath the tower.
Giorgino
who wanted to be a waiter
wanted to be commissar
piling sassi

into the dentist's wall.
 Even the harlot's mother
 \ who had not dared
 come forth because her daughter
 had erred in giving birth,
 appeared by the *Trattoria della Pace*.
 She did not enter
 the masculine precinct,
 listening there, her shadow
 lengthened-out behind her
 black as the uniform of age
 she wore
 on back and head.
 This was the Day
 which began all reckonings
 she heard them say
 with a woman's ears;
 she liked
 the music from the wireless.
 The padre
 pulled
 at his unheeded angelus
 and the Day went down behind
 the town in the bay below
 where—come the season—
 they would be preparing
 with striped umbrellas.
 for the *stranieri* and *milanesi*—
 treason so readily compounded
 by the promiscuous stir
 on the iridescent sliding water.
 He had sought
 the clear air of the cliff.
 —*Salve, Giorgino*
 —*Salve*
 Paolo, have you
 heard
 that we have won the election?
 —*I am writing*
 a poem about it:
 it will begin
 here, with the cliff and with the sea
 following its morning shadow in.

THE PICTURE OF J. T. IN A PROSPECT OF STONE

What should one
 wish a child
 and that, one's own

emerging
 from between
 the stone lips
of a sheep-stile
 that divides
 village graves
and village green?
 —Wish her
 the constancy of stone.
—But stone
 is hard.
 —Say, rather
it resists
 the slow corrosives
 and the flight
of time
 and yet it takes
 the play, the fluency
from light.
 —How would you know
 the gift you'd give
was the gift
 she'd wish to have?
 —Gift is giving,
gift is meaning:
 first
 I'd give
then let her
 live with it
 to prove
its quality the better and
 thus learn
 to love
what (to begin with)
 she might spurn.
 —You'd
moralize a gift?
 —I'd have her
 understand
the gift I gave her.
 —And so she shall
 but let her play
her innocence away
 emerging
 as she does
between
 her doom (unknown),
 her unmown green.

REMEMBERING WILLIAMS

'Wish we could talk today'
you wrote—no more
than that: the time before
it was: 'I stumbled
on a poem you had written,' but the theme
lost itself, you forgot to say
what it was
'that called to mind
something over which
we had both been working, but had not
worked out by half.' Your wife
said she had done her mourning
while you still lived. Life
is a hard bed to lie on dying.

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